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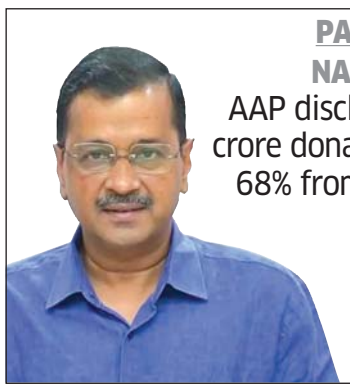
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India at Asiad: Silver for shooter Esha, runner Gulveer



SC steps in on women's safety in Capital

The court also sought scrutiny of fast-track and POCSO courts and sexual-offender databases

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi



Students during the Hum Azad Hain Solidarity March organised at the Delhi University North Campus on Monday PTI

The Supreme Court on Monday passed a slew of directions while taking cognisance of news reports of crimes against minor girls and women across the Delhi-NCR while directing the Delhi Police Commissioner to constitute dedicated police teams to conduct an immediate survey and inspection of vulnerable pockets. The SC directed the commissioner to constitute dedicated police teams for each police district, headed by an officer not below the rank of deputy superintendent of police within a period of four weeks.

"The audit shall be based upon National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) data, local intelligence, past and present complaints received, previous incidents and other objective indicators to identify locations prone to such crimes. These teams shall identify locations where poor lighting, lack of surveillance, insufficient patrolling, abandoned structures, poor access control or other deficiencies may increase the risk of crime. A district-wise vulnerability map shall be prepared and shared across adjoining police stations to ensure that information on recurring patterns of crime and habitual offenders is not confined to individual police-station jurisdictions," the Bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran said.

The SC directed that appropriate patrolling and security arrangements shall be deployed at all identified public parks and vulnerable areas at all times, particularly during evening and early morning hours.

A designated officer shall be responsible for each such location, and the authorities shall prescribe a mechanism for periodic inspection, the SC said.

"An immediate lighting and CCTV audit shall be carried out across all public parks and vulnerable zones to eliminate blind spots. Non-functional CCTV cameras and lighting infrastructure shall be repaired or restored in an expeditious manner. Additional lights and CCTVs to be installed wherever inadequacy is sensed or reported by citizens. A similar audit shall be undertaken in respect of Metro stations, bus stops, bus terminals, railway stations and other major public-transport facilities, particularly those falling within or adjoining identified vulnerable zones," it said.

The Bench directed concerned authorities to utilise the existing citizen grievance-redressal mechanism, including the CM Jan Sunwai Portal, as an additional source of information for identifying deficiencies in public-safety infrastructure.

The SC also directed the registrar general of the Delhi High Court to submit within four weeks, comprehensive information regarding the present status and functioning of the fast track special courts and exclusive POCSO courts in Delhi.

CONTINUED ON >> P4



A traffic policeman issuing a fine for violation in Hyderabad. Representative image WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

SC flags ₹20,000 crore in unpaid traffic fines

RAHUL DATTA ■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday noted that States and Union Territories have a massive outstanding balance of ₹20,000 crore to recover towards unpaid traffic e-challans and suggested linking such challans to electricity bills to recover the amount.

A Bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and KV Viswanathan was informed that despite issuing a vast number of traffic challans, recovery of fines is minimal. The SC said it is not just sufficient to keep issuing e-challans and that recovery of fines is important.

"If people are not paying traffic challans, add it to their electricity dues bill. They will have to pay electricity bills else power line will be disconnected. Work it out. In this country, you have to find a way out," the Bench remarked.

The suggestion came after the SC was apprised that States and UTs had an outstanding of around ₹45,000 crore towards e-challans, of which approximately ₹25,000 crore has been recovered so far.

The court also opined blacklisting vehicles which have not paid challans on the Parivahan portal and blocking ownership transfers.

Justice Pardiwala said authorities need to work at the ground level and also suggested random checks of vehicles to identify those against which e-challans remained unpaid.

"Let there be random checking of vehicles and if found that e-challan has not been honoured, necessary steps to be taken to impound the vehicle itself," the bench said.

The SC was hearing a plea concerning comprehensive systemic reforms in road safety, traffic enforcement, and post-accident victim care.

SC GIVES ECI FOUR MONTHS TO SETTLE TMC DISPUTE

RAHUL DATTA ■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday directed the Election Commission of India (ECI) to decide within four months the dispute between the two rival factions of the All India Trinamool Congress over the party name and the flowers-and-grass election symbol.

A Bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana asked the rival factions to complete their pleadings before the poll panel within four weeks and directed the ECI to decide the issue within three months after the parties complete their pleadings. The SC passed the order while hearing a plea filed by former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee against the ECI's decision to freeze the TMC's name and party symbol.

While hearing the matter on September 24, the court had asked the ECI to apprise it of the time frame within which it can finally decide the dispute between the two rival factions.

CONTINUED ON >> P4



Mamata Banerjee addressing a public rally, at Serampore Court Maidan, in Hooghly district on Saturday PTI

The ByStander



PIONEER IN SHORT

SENSEX SINKS, NIFTY BELOW 22,800

Indian equities suffered their sharpest fall in months on Monday as surging crude prices, renewed geopolitical uncertainty and weak global cues triggered selling. The Sensex plunged 1,124.02 points, or 1.52 per cent, to 72,771.72, its lowest close since March 30, while the Nifty fell 360.25 points, or 1.56 per cent, to 22,780.25. The Sensex had dropped as much as 1,179 points during the session. Twenty-nine of its 30 constituents closed lower, with Larsen & Toubro, Power Grid, Adani Ports, HDFC Bank and Reliance Industries among the major losers. Infosys was the sole gainer. The broader market also weakened, with the BSE SmallCap Select and MidCap Select declining.

FRESH POCSO CASE AGAINST VEERAMANI

The Special Investigation Team probing the alleged sexual abuse of minor girls by granite industrialist R Veeramani registered another case under the POCSO Act on Monday following a complaint by the mother of a minor girl, police said. The woman appeared before the all-women SIT on September 28 and submitted her complaint, following which investigators registered a fresh case and began probing the allegations. The SIT was formed on the direction of Tamil Nadu Director General of Police Mahesh Kumar Aggarwal to conduct a comprehensive investigation into the case against Veeramani and others. Meanwhile, the NCPCR has taken suo motu cognisance of allegations involving girls aged 12-16 and said its fact-finding team would visit Chennai.

Delhi braces for winter smog with sweeping pollution curbs

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi



Anti-smog guns spraying water near India Gate amid haze on February 7, 2026 PTI

The Delhi Government on Monday announced a series of measures ahead of winter and worsening pollution in the national Capital. The measures include staggered office timings, restrictions on vehicular and industrial emissions and curbs on dust generating construction and demolition activities. The measures will be introduced in phases from November 1, 2026, with some restrictions continuing until February 2027.

Unveiling the Winter Action Plan, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the Government has ordered a ban on dust-generating demolition activities and outdoor civil construction work from November 1, 2026, to January 31, 2027. A complete ban on construction and demolition activities will be imposed from December 10, 2026 to January 20, 2027.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Digital creator Nidhi Tiwari found dead

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

The death of Nidhi Tiwari, a popular digital content creator from the Vindhya region, has left her large social media following in shock. Tiwari, 30, was found dead at her residence in the Bhusa Mod area on Saturday. She had built a substantial online presence, with about 9.28 lakh followers on Facebook and 7.12 lakh on Instagram.



Nidhi Tiwari VIA FACEBOOK

Family members took her to a hospital after finding her, but doctors declared her dead. Police have registered a case and are examining the circumstances surrounding her death.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

SC to hear UPI fee challenge, seeks Government, RBI, NPCI replies

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi



WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

On Monday, the Supreme Court refused to grant an interim stay to pause the Government's plan to add Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on UPI payments over ₹2,000 made to merchants, starting October 15. The court agreed to review the challenge against the MDR and asked the Government, the RBI, and the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) to respond within four weeks.

A Bench of Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was responding to advocate Anjan Datta's public interest petition challenging the Government's notifications dated September 14 and 15 that introduced MDR on UPI payments over ₹2,000 to merchants.

The Government will charge a 0.4 per cent fee on UPI payments over ₹2,000 made to merchants from October 15 ending almost six years of free UPI payments.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Ujjain road widening turns tense ahead of Simhastha Kumbh 2028

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ujjain



Barricades placed in front of Shahi Masjid following stone-pelting incidents and protests against the proposed removal of a portion of the mosque for a road-widening project in Ujjain, Madhya Pradesh PTI

Tension briefly flared in Ujjain on Monday when police used tear gas and mild force to disperse a crowd that allegedly resorted to stone-pelting while protesting the removal of a portion of the Shahi Masjid at Chhatri Chowk for a road-widening project ahead of Simhastha Kumbh 2028.

The road from Kanthal Crossing to Gopal Mandir is being widened to 15 metres to facilitate the movement of pilgrims expected to visit the city for Simhastha. The project involves removing or modifying structures within the proposed road alignment.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

From choppers to Google ads: Inside BJP's ₹529 core poll spending

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi



Prime Minister Narendra Modi during a roadshow ahead of the West Bengal Assembly polls in Howrah on April 23 PTI

The recently concluded Assembly polls in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Assam, and Kerala saw major political parties spend nearly ₹1,006 crore, according to expenditure statements filed with the Election Commission of India (ECI), with the BJP spending more than half that amount. The party submitted its poll expenditure statements to the ECI in August.

The party's expenditure details record that the BJP received receipts of around ₹1,500 crore between March and April 2026. The filing shows the BJP's opening balance rose from ₹6,782.65 crore to ₹7,793.88 crore. Of the donations received, the party spent ₹529.38 crore on the Assembly elections the recent polls across five States and a Union Territory, with more than half the expenditure (₹286.99 crore) incurred in West Bengal. This includes ₹217.16 crore on party propaganda in the State and ₹69.83 crore on candidate-related expenditure.

The Congress's total expenditure across five states and a Union Territory, according to the filings, was ₹248.55 crore. The party reported spending ₹42.08 crore in West Bengal. This included ₹12.96 crore on general campaigning and ₹29.12 crore on candidates and related expenses. In Assam, Keralam, Tamil Nadu and Puducherry, the party spent ₹91.92 crore, ₹83 crore, ₹51.52 crore and ₹12 crore respectively.

The Trinamool Congress, which split into several factions post-poll, has yet to file its expenditure details.

The filing also shows the scale of the BJP's campaign-related spending. The party's central headquarters reported ₹51.50 crore in travel expenses for star campaigners, while ₹55.76 crore was spent on media advertisements for party propaganda. The listed expenses include aircraft and helicopter travel involving several senior BJP leaders. The filing further shows that Google received around ₹24 crore and Facebook ₹5 crore from the BJP during the campaign in West Bengal.

The BJP's Kerala expenditure statement records gross election expenditure of ₹82.67 crore, combining party propaganda (₹54.93 crore) and candidate-related expenditure (₹27.74 crore). Within this, the State unit reported ₹41.13 crore on propaganda, including ₹26.01 crore on media advertisements, ₹5.01 crore on publicity material and ₹8.30 crore on travel for star campaigners.

While limits cap how much a candidate can spend on contesting elections, parties can spend unlimited amounts on fighting polls.

TVK spent ₹19.8 crore for the 2026 Assembly election in Tamil Nadu. In comparison, DMK reported poll expenditure of ₹197.8 crore and AIADMK ₹112.4 crore.

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | SEPTEMBER 29, 2026

Delhi Govt, ICCR ink pact to promote artists

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



Local and young artists from Delhi will get opportunities to showcase their work at international cultural festivals and events abroad under a new partnership between the Delhi Government and the Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR).

The initiative will cover artists from fields including performing arts, literature, sculpture, textiles, architecture, culinary arts and handicrafts, with the government preparing a comprehensive database of talent and sharing it with ICCR for international programmes, according to a statement.

The partnership, formalised through a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) on Monday in the presence of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, will also seek to promote Delhi's cultural heritage and tourism while expanding academic and cultural exchanges with foreign artists, scholars and students.

Under the agreement, artists from Delhi will get opportunities to participate in ICCR's 'Horizon Series' and international cultural festivals. The Delhi Government will identify established and emerging talent and enlist them with the cultural body, it stated.

The database will bring together artists from different disciplines, creating a directory that can be used to identify talent for international cultural programmes and events, the statement stated.

The agreement also provides for performances by foreign artists at cultural and tourism festivals in Delhi. Joint art exhibitions, artist residency camps, workshops, conferences and seminars involving artists from India and abroad will also be organised.

Foreign scholars and dignitaries visiting India under ICCR's Distinguished Visitors Programme and Academic Visitors Programme will be hosted in Delhi, while study camps and orientation visits will be organised for foreign students associated with ICCR to familiarise them with the city's historical and cultural attractions, it said.

The partnership will also promote Delhi's educational institutions and universities among ICCR's international student network, opening avenues for greater academic interaction.

It said that for international cultural groups participating in events in Delhi, the government will bear necessary expenses, while ICCR will assist in identifying participants and with visa and travel-related arrangements.

For Delhi-based artists and cultural groups participating in events abroad, the Delhi Government will bear expenses related to domestic and international air travel, transportation, visas, and necessary Government approvals, it said, and added that ICCR will assist with international stay, performances, publicity, and medical requirements.

A joint committee comprising ICCR's director general or representative, senior officials of the Delhi Government's Department of Art and Culture and the head of ICCR's regional office will oversee implementation and finalise a minimum annual activity plan, the statement read.

The MoU will remain in force for five years from the date of signing and can be extended for another five years by mutual consent, it mentioned.

Gupta said the partnership would connect Delhi's art, culture and talent with wider platforms in India and abroad. She said the Government wanted Delhi's heritage, art and cultural identity to progress alongside its development, adding that the partnership would give fresh impetus to the city's culture, tourism and creative economy.

Art, Culture and Language Minister Kapil Mishra said the agreement would provide Delhi artists opportunities on international platforms and help create a database of talented artists across disciplines.

He also said the partnership would promote cultural exchanges with foreign artists and scholars, while orientation programmes, study camps and introductory visits would help international students connect with Delhi's cultural heritage.

2 drunk drivers lose licences, 94 cases sent to court: Police

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi Traffic Police convicted two motorists of drunken driving, suspended their driving licences for three months and forwarded 94 such challans to courts for further action, officials said on Monday. They said the crackdown coincides with special enforcement drives where police prosecuted 18 motorists for drunken driving, issued challans for 253 vehicles for wrong-side driving, and for 59 vehicles using unauthorised tinted or black films.

The traffic police also initiated proceedings under relevant sections of the Motor Vehicles Act against habitual violators based on their challan history and driving licence particulars. They sent proposals to the concerned licensing authorities. In the two drunk-driving cases, a local court convicted the offenders under Section 185 (drunk driving) of the Motor Vehicles Act and imposed a fine of Rs 10,000 each.



The court also ordered police to suspend their driving licences for three months. The court passed the orders on September 24 based on written requests submitted by police.

The court directed that copies of the orders be sent to the concerned Regional Transport Offices (RTOs) through the traffic inspector. The orders also record the statutory consequences of holding or obtaining a driving licence during the disqualification period, they said.

In West Delhi, traffic police identified habitual and repeat violators based on challan history and available driving licence details. The traffic police forwarded necessary proposals to the Delhi Driving Licence Suspension Cell and to licensing authorities in other states from which the offenders obtained their driving licences.

Officials said the concerned licencing authorities initiated proceedings in appropriate cases by issuing show-cause notices to licence holders, allowing them to submit their explanations before a decision is taken under the prescribed procedure.

In addition to the 94 drunken-driving challans forwarded to court, 79 challans for dangerous driving have also been sent for necessary legal action.

Police submitted 19 applications to the concerned DTOs to initiate driving licence suspension proceedings against offenders involved in dangerous driving and repeated violations. The traffic police also used data generated by Over Speed Detection (OSD) and Red Light Violation Detection (RLVD) cameras to identify repeat and habitual offenders. Officials said they are analysing camera-generated violation records along with challan histories and previous traffic violations for the concerned vehicles and drivers.

Delhi records pleasant day on Monday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



The national Capital experienced another pleasant day, with the city's maximum temperature dropping to 28.7 degrees Celsius, six degrees below normal for this time of year. This follows a day when Delhi recorded the second-lowest September temperature in 25 years. It was not the early onset of winter, however, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) clarified and said that the current spell of pleasant weather may end soon as temperatures are likely to rise steadily in the coming days.

The minimum temperature at Safdarjung, the city's primary weather station, was 23 degrees Celsius, 0.3 degrees below normal and 2 degrees higher than Sunday. The day temperature on Sunday was 30.6 degrees Celsius, according to the weather office. Delhi and its adjoining areas have seen a drop in temperatures under the influence of a western disturbance and an upper-air cyclonic circulation over northwest Uttar Pradesh and the neighbourhood.

CM Rekha launches Delhi Udyog Mitra Portal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday launched the "Delhi Udyog Mitra Portal" under the Seva Sankalp campaign, an integrated digital platform that gives entrepreneurs, traders, MSMEs, startups, industrial units, and investors access to Government services and approvals through a single interface.

Industries Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa and senior officials from the concerned departments attended the launch. The portal currently integrates more than 50 Government services from 15 departments, with the government aiming to expand this to over 100 services across 21 departments. The initiative is expected to make Government services easier to access for over 8 lakh traders in Delhi, including MSMEs.

The portal has also been integrated with the National Single Window System, allowing investors and businesses to access Central and State-level approvals through one digital platform, making the approval process faster and more transparent.

Applicants can use the portal to identify needed approvals, submit applications, track status and communicate with different departments through a single interface. Its features include Single Sign-On, which lets users access different departments' services through one login, and a Common Application Form, which reduces the need to repeatedly submit the same basic information.

The "Know Your Approvals" feature will help entrepreneurs identify the approvals required for their proposed business. An applicant dashboard lets users view all application statuses in one place, while a departmental dashboard helps departments monitor applications and service delivery. A guidance module provides FAQs, manuals and guidance so entrepreneurs understand the process before applying.

The Chief Minister said that in line with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "Make in India" vision, the Delhi Government is working to create a business environment where entrepreneurs and investors do not face unnecessary procedural complexities and can focus on expanding businesses, driving innovation and creating jobs.

Metro Railway, Kolkata

e-Tender is invited by Principal Chief Engineer, Metro Railway for the following work: **Name of work:** Supply, installation, commissioning and operating of track based gauge face rail lubricators (Electronic type) for 05 years at Noapara-Jai Hind Bimanbandar section of Yellow Line of Metro Railway, Kolkata. **Approx. Cost of Work:** Rs. 2,10,51,120/-, **Earnest Money:** Rs. 2,55,300/-. **Completion Period:** Sixty (60) Months. **Date and Time of Closing:** 27.10.2026 at 12:00 Hrs. The Tender Document and other details can be obtained from the website **www.ireps.gov.in** Amendments/Corrigendum, if any, would be uploaded only on the website.
Abridged e-Tender Notice No. : Civil-2549-2026-Recall(Open) (Two Packet)
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KONKAN RAILWAY CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of India Undertaking)
E-Tender Notice

On behalf of Konkan Railway Corporation Ltd., Divisional Electrical Engineer, KRCL, Ratnagiri, is inviting E-Open Tenders for the following work. **Name of the work** - Supply, erection, testing and commissioning of Passenger Lifts (02 nos) at Sawantwadi station under Ratnagiri region of Konkan Railway (26 Passenger Lift/ 1768 Kgs / 1 Speed / 2 Floors / 2 Stops / Stainless Steel (1.5 Mm) Car Cabin). As per RDSO approval and specification. **Tender No. KR/RN/EL/T/28/2026 DATED 29.09.2026**, **Estimated cost** - ₹ 85,76,272/- (Excluding GST), **Cost of Tender form** - NIL, **EMD** - ₹ 1,71,500/- (or as shown on IREPS portal). **Last date and time of depositing of tender ON LINE :** 13/10/2026 upto 15:00 hrs. For further details, contact office of Divisional Electrical engineer, MIDC area, Mirjole, Ratnagiri or on Railway web site (www.ireps.gov.in).

NORTHERN RAILWAY
GeM Bid Notice
Invitation of Bid through E-Biding (GeM Bid Systems)

GeM Bid No. (Custom Bid)	GEM/2026/B/8030531
Name of Work and its location	Bid for "Un-Skilled worker for unloading of 3600 MT scrap for a period of 02 years at Jagadhari Workshop."
Approx. Cost of Work	Bid Cost: Rs.8,37,612/- including GST (Rs. Eight Lakh, Thirty Seven Thousand Six Hundred Twelve Only).
Earnest Money	Rs. 16,750/-
Completion Period of Work	24 months from date of LOA
Cost of Bid document on cash/by post	NIL
Date and Time for submission of Bid	Upto 16:00 hrs. on 19.10.2026
Website particulars, notice board location, complete details of Bid can be seen	Above Bid available on GeM site i.e. **www.gem.gov.in**

GeM Bid No (Custom Bid): GEM/2026/B/8030531 Dated: 26.09.2026 3367/2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

GOVT. OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER P.W.D. NALBARI DISTRICT TERRITORIAL BUILDING DIVISION,NALBARI
No.EE(N)/ HG/03/2025-26/ 1033

PRESS NOTICE INVITING RE- TENDER

The Executive Engineer, PWD, Nalbari District Territorial Building Division, Nalbari on behalf of Governor of Assam re-invites item rate bids in electronic tendering system for the work. "Construction of RCC G+1 Office building for accommodation of the District Commandant, Home Guards Office, Nalbari with provision of store at the Ground floor" with an approximate value of work Rs. 1,21,99,414.00 from APWD(Building & Electrical) Class-I (A/B/C) Registered contractors having experience in similar nature of works.

Details of the bid may be seen at e-procurement portal website; www.assamtenders.gov.in and also in the office of the undersigned during office hours.The bidders must be enrolled in www.assamtenders.gov.in for participating in the bidding process.

The intending tenderers are advised to visit the site and familiarize themselves with site conditions before submitting their tenders at their own cost and responsibility.

Sd/-
Executive Engineer, PWD,
Nalbari District Territorial Building ,
DIPR/C//PIO/132/29-Sep-26 **Division, Nalbari**

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, hitherto known as MANORAMA MINJ ALIAS MANORAMA TOPPO D/O JAMES MINJ W/O ANURANJAN TOPPO R/O RZ-F1/219-B, GALI NO. 2, MAHAVIR ENCLAVE, PALAM VILLAGE, SOUTH WEST DELHI, DELHI-110045 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as MANORAMA TOPPO.

I, hitherto known as SHUBHANGI TIWARI ALIAS SHUBHANGI AGNIHOTRI D/O VIJAYKANT TIWARI W/O XHITIZ AGNIHOTRI R/O FARM NO. 1A, GULMOHAR AVENUE, DLF FARM, VTC: CHATTAR PUR, PO: CHATTARPUR, SOUTH DELHI, DELHI-110074 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as SHUBHANGI AGNIHOTRI.

I, Balakrishnan C, Father of No.15719459A L/Nk Shibin B, R/o- S V Bhavan, Puthuval, Nalloorvattom, Plamoottukada P.O, Vill- Kulathoor, Teh- Neyyattinkara, Dist- Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala- 695122, have changed my name from Balakrishna C to Balakrishnan, vide affidavit dated 28/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Sibnarayan Patra, Father of No. 15346116A Hav Uttam Kumar Patra, R/o- Vill- Bhanderjalpai, Po- Dayaldasi, Teh- Chak Simulia, Dist- Purba, Medinepur, West Bengal - 721632, have changed my name from Sibnarayan Patra to Shibnarayan Patra, vide affidavit dated 28/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.15431097X Hav/AA Chilla Lokanath, R/o- Vill- Gudivada, PO- Chittivalasa, Dist- Vizianagaram, A.P. - 531162, have changed my mother's name & DOB in my service record from Chilla Krishnavant 28.02.1962 to Chilla Krishna Veni 15.07.1975, vide affidavit dated 28/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Puspa Patra, Mother of No. 15346116A Hav Uttam Kumar Patra, R/o- Vill- Bhanderjalpai, Po- Dayaldasi, Teh- Chak Simulia, Dist- Purba, Medinepur, West Bengal - 721632, have changed my name from Puspa Patra to Pushpabala Patra, vide affidavit dated 28/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Firoza Begam, Mother of No.15209939N Hav SK Miraj, R/o- Vill&PO- Kandra, Dist- Burdwan, West Bengal - 713129, have changed my name from Firoza Begam to Firoja Bibi, vide affidavit dated 28/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Vasantha S, Mother of No.15719459A L/Nk Shibin B, R/o- S V Bhavan, Puthuval, Nalloorvattom, Plamoottukada P.O, Vill- Kulathoor, Teh- Neyyattinkara, Dist- Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala- 695122, have changed my name from Vasantha S to Vasantha, vide affidavit dated 28/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, hitherto known as Varinder Pal Singh Syan S/o- Joga Singh, R/o- WZ-265, Gali No. - 9, Lajwanti Garden, South West Delhi, Delhi - 110046, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Varinder Pal Singh.

I, Laxman Singh, Father of No.16018401A Hav Shrawan Singh, R/o- Vill- Satakhedi, Teh- Sitamau, Dist- Mandsaur, M.P.- 458389, have changed my name from Laxman Singh to Laxman Singh Bhati, vide affidavit dated 28/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Bhanwar Kanwar, Mother of No.16018401A Hav Shrawan Singh, R/o- Vill- Satakhedi, Teh- Sitamau, Dist- Mandsaur, M.P.- 458389, have changed my name from Bhanwar Kanwar to Antar Kunvar Bhati, vide affidavit dated 28/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Annu Kuwar, Wife of No.16018401A Hav Shrawan Singh, R/o- Vill- Satakhedi, Teh- Sitamau, Dist- Mandsaur, M.P.- 458389, have changed my name from Annu Kuwar to Annu Kunwar, vide affidavit dated 28/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.15446382N Nk Tejpal, R/o- Vill- Kashipur, Teh & Dist- Palwal, P.S- Hassanpur, Haryana- 121107, have changed my Father's name in my Army service record from Harbans to Harvansh, vide affidavit dated 28/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.15446382N Nk Tejpal, R/o- Vill- Kashipur, Teh & Dist- Palwal, P.S- Hassanpur, Haryana- 121107, have changed my Mother's name in my Army service record from Bala Devi to Wala, vide affidavit dated 28/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Indumathi J, W/o- No.4592634P Nk Jayasuriya G, R/o- D/No. 4/9, Muthu Nagar (Vill), Bargur (TK), Sevvmpatti, Nadupatti (PO), Krishnagiri (Dt), Tamil Nadu- 635203, have changed my name from Indumathi J to Indumathi R, vide affidavit dated 28/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.16018401A Hav Shrawan Singh, R/o- Vill- Satakhedi, Teh- Sitamau, Dist- Mandsaur, M.P.- 458389, have changed my daughter's name from Aditi Kunwar to Aditi Bhati, vide affidavit dated 28/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण
प्रथम तल, कॉमर्शियल कॉम्प्लेक्स, ओमेगा-1 (पी-2), ग्रेटर नौएडा
Toll Free No. 18001808296, वेबसाइट : www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com

पंत्राकः वाई.ई.ए./भूलेख/69/2026 दिनांकः 23.09.2026

सार्वजनिक सूचना

यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा **ग्राम तकीपुर बांगर** के अन्तर्गत आने वाली भूमि का सुनियोजित विकास हेतु सम्बन्धित कृषकों द्वारा दी गयी सहमति की दर रु. 4037.00/- प्रति वर्ग मी. से प्राधिकरण द्वारा कार्यालय आदेश संख्या वाई.ई.ए./भूलेख/अ.मु.का.अ./137/2026 दिनांक 20.08.2026 में तय प्रक्रियानुसार निम्नानुसार क्रय किया जाना प्रस्तावित हैः-

क्र. सं.	भूखण्ड सं.	ग्रामवार खसरा संख्या
		तकीपुर बांगर
1.	30 मी. चौड़ी सड़क एवं सैक्टर 24 ए	63, 92, 149

उपरोक्त भूमि क्रय किये जाने में यदि किसी व्यक्ति को कोई आपत्ति है तो वह लिखित रूप में 15 दिन के अन्दर अधोहस्ताक्षरी को अपनी आपत्ति प्रस्तुत कर सकता है।

डिप्टी कलेक्टर

यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण के अधिसूचित क्षेत्र में प्राधिकरण द्वारा स्वीकृत मास्टर प्लान के अतिरिक्त प्लॉटिंग/हाउसिंग/कॉलोनी या किसी भी प्रकार का अन्य निर्माण पूरी तरह से अवैध है। सामान्यजन इस प्रकार की खरीदफ़रोख्त से पूर्णतः सचेत रहें तथा कॉलोनाइजर के भ्रामक विज्ञापनों से बचें। अधिक जानकारी के लिए प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट **www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com** देखें।

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA, MINISTRY OF DEFENCE
EX-SERVICEMEN CONTRIBUTORY HEALTH SCHEME, STATION HQ (ECHS CELL), BANBASA
Phone No: 05943-263223, Mob No: 8433260789, E-mail: banbasa@echs.gov.in.
EMPLOYMENT NOTICE

1 **Station Heaqquarters, Banbasa (ECHS Cell)** invites applications to engage following ECHS staff on contractual basis in **ECHS Polyclinic Banbasa** for a period of 11 months/ one year renewable for additional period of one year/till attaining the maximum age subject to performance of candidate/other condition according to the criteria as mentioned against each post

Sr. No	Catagory	Age Limit		Basic Qual.	Work Experience	No of Vacancies Banbasa	Reserved for Ex-servicemen	Fixed Remuneration
01	OIC	63	65	Graduate	Minimum 03 years work experience in health Care Institutions or Managerial positions	01	100%	95000/-
01	Medical Officer	66	68	M.B.B.S	Minimum 03 years after internship. Preferable addi qualification in Medicine/ surgery	01	60%	95000/-

2. For Terms & Conditions, Application Form, Remuneration. Kindly see our website www.echs.gov.in. For details please contact Stn ECHS Cell Stn HQ Banbasa at tele No 05943-263223, Mob No 8433260789 & ECHS Polyclinic email on banbasa@echs.gov.in. Also approach concerned ECHS Polyclinic for details, performance will be given to the Ex-servicemen.
3. Last date of receipt of application as per format given at our website Application as per requiside format alongwith self attested photocopies of testimonials in support of Educational Qualifications, work experience, PAN Card, Adhaar Card and Medical Fitness Certificate should be sent only by Registered Post in sealed envelop depicting the post applied for OIC ECHS Cell Station Headquarters Banbasa-262310 by 10 Oct 2026 in duplicate. Any application received after 09 Oct 2026 will not accepted.
4. Interview Date, Timing & Venue. Short listed candidates will be informed telephonically/SMS and interview will held at Station HQ Banbasa on 10 Oct 2026 at 0900hrs. Candidate must bring all the original certificate//mark sheets/degree of 10th /Matric, 10+2 & Graduation//diploma/course, attempt certificate, work experience & Disch book, PPO, service record PAN Card, Adhaar Card and Medical Fitness Certificate and, 02 PP size colour, photographs at the time of interview. No TA/DA admissible. Only candidates meeting the Qualitative Requirement may apply.
5. On Job Training (OJT) OIC Polyclinic, Medical Specialist, Gynaecologist, Radiologist Medical Officer and Dental Officer will carry out 10 days Ob Job Trainig (OJT) and obtain certificate fromOIC Polycliniv before signing the contract. In case of OIC Polyclinic, the certificate would be rendered by the OIC ECHS Cell Station HQ Banbasa. The duration of Ob Job Training (OJT) will remain unpaid and as mandatory requirement before assuming charge as a contratucal employee.
6. With regards to remuneration, ESM can exercise option as per Govt of India, Min of Def letter No 22 D(19)/2017-D(WE/Res-1) (i) dt 24 Jul 2025 and letter No 22 D(19)/2017-D(WE/Res-1) (ii) dt 18 Sep 2025

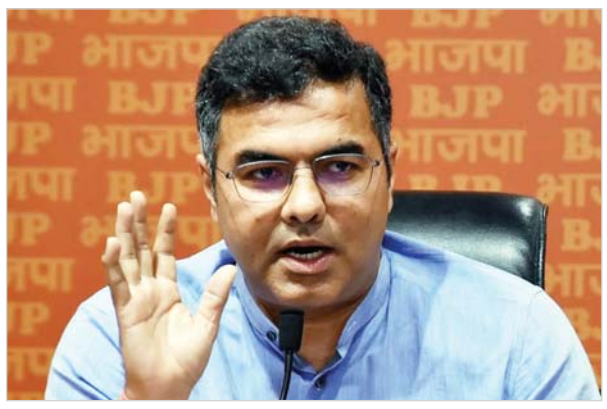
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The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | SEPTEMBER 29, 2026

Verma hits out at Kejriwal over abuse claim

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



Delhi's Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Verma on Monday made a sharp attack on Aam Aadmi Party national convener Arvind Kejriwal and reiterated that an AAP worker had abused his family while conducting an inspection of a road in the national Capital's Tilak Nagar area on Sunday.

Responding to a video by the former chief minister, Verma said the AAP worker who abused his family was not a Gen Z, and he shouldn't shield himself behind the youth. The Delhi minister said he would not accept it if the AAP's "goons" continue to obstruct the Government's development work in the city-state.

"I warn you... you remember me, right?" Verma, who defeated Kejriwal in the New Delhi assembly constituency in the 2025 assembly elections, said in a two-minute thirty-three-second video on X (formerly Twitter). "That person is not any Gen-Z. He is a goon who has an FIR registered against him for assaulting an MCD official three months back. He was arrested also."

"This Gen-Z drama of yours will not work... If you or your goons, your MLAs in future try to obstruct Delhi Government's work or threaten our officers, contractors, then I will not tolerate this," the Delhi minister added.

Verma's latest video came hours after Kejriwal released a one-minute, fourteen-second video on X and said Prime Minister Narendra Modi is resorting to different ways to connect with the Gen Z, but has miserably failed. He alleged Verma slapped a person who was Gen Z and said he must be immediately arrested.

Delhi BJP President Harsh Malhotra said that the speech and political drama staged by Kejriwal during his visit to Vikaspuri today reflect the duplicity in his conduct and politics. "The political drama staged by him by visiting Vikaspuri on Monday has left the people of Delhi stunned," Malhotra said.

Kejriwal on Monday said the Gen Z does not trust him because of such acts.

"The minister slapped a young boy. This country does not belong to your father. You cannot slap anyone like this. This country belongs to 140 crore Indians," Kejriwal said, addressing reporters after he reached the Tilak Nagar area where the young man was recording Verma during a road inspection. "Gen Z does not trust you at all because of such acts by you. Parvesh Verma says he is Modi ji's favourite. I want to tell both of them, people of the country do not accept this kind of behaviour," the former Delhi chief minister said. Kejriwal said people are fed up with the BJP, and if they make up their minds, they will throw them out of power.

The Public Works Department (PWD) is carrying out road repair work on the Outer Ring Road stretch from Janakpuri District Centre Chowk to Najafgarh Drain, where the incident occurred. "This is a new road, and it is already damaged. We had not seen such roads before in Delhi. We were also in Government for 10 years. It is clear there has been corruption in the construction of this work and should be investigated," he further said.

In a related development, members of the Sikh community on Monday staged a protest outside Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Verma's residence over a video purportedly showing him slapping a man during a road inspection in Tilak Nagar. Visuals showed several protesters being detained as police deployed heavy security and set up barricades outside Verma's residence near BSNL House on Janpath Road to prevent the protesters from reaching the house.

Delhi Police files NCR against Parvesh Verma



Police personnel gather as they keep a vigil during a protest outside Vikapuri police station in New Delhi on Monday PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi Police has filed a Non-Cognisable Report (NCR) against PWD Minister Parvesh Verma for slapping a 22-year-old man during a road inspection in west Delhi's Tilak Nagar, even as it emerged that the man was an accused in an earlier assault case involving an MCD worker.

The NCR against Verma has been filed under Section 115 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) for voluntarily causing hurt, police said. An NCR is recorded when the information relates to a non-cognisable offence. In such cases, police require the permission of a magistrate to investigate, unlike a cognisable offence where police can proceed with the investigation as provided under the law.

The incident took place on Sunday during an inspection of road repair work on a stretch of the Outer Ring Road between the Janakpuri District Centre Chowk and the Najafgarh Drain. A video showing Verma slapping the man, identified as Sahib Singh, circulated widely on social media.

Verma, however, said he would not tolerate what he described as attempts by AAP workers to obstruct Government officials from carrying out their duties. He also alleged that Singh was associated with the AAP and that there was a previous case against him. According to police records, Singh was an accused in an assault case involving an MCD worker in June this year. Police arrested him in the case and later granted him bail.

The June 2 incident occurred when the MCD worker was collecting waste. A dispute broke out over garbage being thrown from the second floor of a building into the collection vehicle, according to the complaint filed by the worker.

The complaint alleged that two men arrived on a motorcycle and got into an altercation because the vehicle did not leave enough space for them to pass. The worker alleged that the men, along with others from the same house, pulled him out of the vehicle and assaulted him.

The handwritten complaint named one of the accused as Sahib and the other as Monu. The injured worker was taken to the Deen Dayal Upadhyay Hospital, where his medico-legal examination was conducted. Police records say they subsequently registered an FIR under the relevant provisions of the BNS.

After Sunday's incident, the Public Works Department (PWD) separately filed a complaint against Jarnail Singh at the Tilak Nagar police station, alleging obstruction of officials in the discharge of their duties.

DDA completes safety audit of 300 parks, beefs up night security

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi



The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has completed a safety and security audit of 300 parks and strengthened security arrangements across its parks, with the authority clarifying that park timings remain unchanged and visitors may continue using them during the previously applicable hours.

The steps follow directions from Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, amid concern over the safety and security of park visitors. DDA said the audit of all its parks will be completed this week, examining guard deployment, patrolling, CCTV coverage, lighting, access control, and the condition of fencing and boundary walls, with gaps to be addressed and further measures taken wherever necessary.

In consultation with law enforcement agencies, DDA has increased security deployment and intensified patrolling where required. Additional guards have been deployed during the night shift where necessary, bike patrols equipped with torches and safety equipment are being conducted, and senior officers are carrying out surprise night inspections.

Additional lighting is being provided at identified dark spots, plants around light poles have been pruned, and gaps in fencing and boundary walls are being addressed. CCTV coverage and entry and exit arrangements are also being strengthened.

Guards are maintaining coordination with the concerned police beat officer and have been instructed to report suspicious activity and take appropriate action promptly.

Signage boards advise visitors to use well-lit main routes after sunset and to report any suspicious activity to park security or the police. DDA said this advice is precautionary and does not restrict access during permitted hours.

DDA also clarified that entry to its parks is not regulated based on gender or any other such criterion. The authority said it is committed to the safety of all visitors, particularly women, children, senior citizens and persons with disabilities, and welcomes public suggestions and cooperation in making its parks safer and more accessible.

LG orders security boost at parks, public spaces

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Monday directed that parks and public spaces must not be closed to citizens in the name of security, while ordering agencies to step up patrolling, lighting and security across the Capital, and warning that any laxity would invite disciplinary action against officers.

Sandhu chaired a high-level meeting to review measures Government departments and agencies are taking the ensure women's safety in Delhi. Those present included the Chief Secretary, MCD Commissioner, NDMC Chairperson, Principal Secretary (Education), DDA Vice Chairman and the Vice-Chancellor of Delhi University, according to officials who attended the meeting.

At the outset, the LG asked all agencies, especially the police, to substantially and proactively increase on-ground engagement with students in colleges and schools, heads of institutions, RWAs and market trade associations. These interactions should take place at the level of DCPs, Additional DCPs, ACPs and SHOs at least. Based on them, measures must be taken to ensure the demands and concerns raised by these groups are met at the earliest and in earnest.

Sandhu issued firm directions to intensify visible police patrolling across vulnerable stretches. He asked the park and road-owning agencies to ensure proper lighting and security in public parks without curtailing citizen access. He also directed the heads of all agencies to inspect the big parks in their jurisdictions personally.

Delhi Police was directed to strengthen patrolling and visible policing, especially at vulnerable sites. DDA, MCD and PWD were directed to ensure adequate lighting, security personnel and secured boundaries, and to eliminate dark spots. The Transport Department was directed to secure its buses and other vehicles as directed earlier and to provide adequate lighting at bus stands. The LG cautioned that any laxity would be treated seriously and that appropriate disciplinary action would be taken against officers found derelict in these duties.

The meeting also discussed enhanced community engagement, particularly with students and educational institutions, and the steps Delhi Police is taking to strengthen patrolling and visible policing as a deterrent to anticipated crimes. It reviewed what DDA, MCD and NDMC are doing to ensure adequate lighting and security personnel in their parks and to secure broken boundaries of parks and public properties.

Barapullah Phase-III inauguration to affect ring road traffic

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Traffic movement is likely to be affected on the Ring Road between Sarai Kale Khan and Ashram Chowk on Tuesday in view of the opening ceremony of the Barapullah Phase-III flyover. Union Home Minister Amit Shah will inaugurate the third phase of the Barapullah project.

According to a traffic advisory issued on Monday, the Public Works Department (PWD), Delhi Government, has scheduled the opening function of the Barapullah Phase-III flyover for September 29. A large gathering is expected to reach the flyover site by bus and car.



Traffic will remain affected from 9 am to 2 pm in areas including Sarai Kale Khan, Maharani Bagh and Ashram Chowk, the advisory said.

The traffic police have advised commuters to avoid the Ring Road stretch between Sarai Kale Khan and Ashram Chowk during the period and use alternative routes.

The Barapullah-Phase 3 corridor, which is the biggest of the four projects, aims to provide seamless connectivity between East and South Delhi, linking Mayur Vihar Phase-1 and AIIMS via signal-free carriageways. The new flyover will merge with the existing Barapullah flyover at Sarai Kale Khan, completing a stretch of around 9 km.

Originally approved in 2014 and initiated in 2015, the project was initially scheduled for completion in 2017. However, it faced multiple delays and significant cost overruns, and the revised project cost is now approximately ₹1,635 crore.

In South Delhi, the PWD is extending the Modi Mill flyover to the Kalkaji Temple flyover and constructing additional half-flyovers at key intersections to create a 7.2-km signal-free corridor to the IIT Gate. It will have three lanes in both directions, enabling smoother and uninterrupted traffic flow.

The third project is the construction of a half-flyover beside the existing Savitri Cinema, a 435-metre, three-lane single carriageway. Initially approved by the UTTIPEC in 2017, the project has faced delays due to a lack of financial and administrative approvals from the Government.

This flyover is expected to ease traffic congestion for commuters heading to Nehru Place, Okhla, and other areas, as the PWD plans to expand the existing single carriageway into a dual carriageway.

DU suspends 3 students over alleged harassment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi University has suspended three students from their respective courses with immediate effect over an alleged harassment incident involving a Hindu College postgraduate student in northwest Delhi, a university official said on Monday.

The students, all pursuing LLB at Law Centre-II, were suspended following allegations that a group of men in a car followed a Hindu College student and her friend in the Mukherjee Nagar area and allegedly attempted to pull them into the vehicle.

The action was taken based on an FIR registered by the Delhi Police in connection with the incident that occurred around 9:30 pm on September 23, the official said.

According to the notice issued on Monday by the Proctor, the action was taken under Clause 3(e) of Ordinance XV-B of the Delhi University Act, 1922.

The notice, issued separately to the three students, also mentioned that their entry into the University of Delhi's premises is banned with immediate effect under the ordinance, and the same has been approved by the varsity's competent authority.

The university's disciplinary action comes amid heightened concerns over the safety of students, particularly women, on and around Delhi University campuses.

Dwarka's Delhi Sadan to offer food, public plaza

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



Delhi Sadan, a proposed State guest house in Dwarka, will feature a craft bazaar, food court, public plaza and rooftop restaurants showcasing local cuisine and curios, according to a DTTDC document outlining the design of the project.

The Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation (DTTDC), entrusted with constructing the facility, has estimated the project cost at ₹119.70 crore, with the building scheduled for completion in 21 months, the document said.

Spread over a 3,899.42-square-metre plot in Sector 19, the facility is planned as a two-basement structure with a ground floor, upper ground floor, service floor, podium level and six upper floors, with a total built-up area of 15,984 square metres, it said.

The building will include 32-bed dormitories, 36 guest rooms, six VIP rooms, and two VVIP rooms, as well as a discussion room, meeting rooms, multipurpose areas, administrative offices, and spaces for public and cultural activities, according to the document.

The podium level is planned to house a craft bazaar, food court and public plaza, while the rooftop will have indoor and outdoor restaurant spaces. The design document said the rooftop eateries are intended to serve local cuisine and offer curios associated with Delhi.

The project is designed around a central courtyard that would serve as a social and environmental anchor, allowing greater interaction while improving natural light and airflow. Glass window slits and landscaped elements are also planned to bring biophilic views into the building, it said.

The twin 39.15-metre-high building blocks will have vertically landscaped facades with triangular openings inspired by New Delhi's radial road network, according to the concept design.

18.61 crore bottles sold, beer most popular in July

SHRUTI BHARDWAJ
New Delhi



As many as 18.61 crore liquor bottles of all shapes and sizes were sold from Delhi Tourism Department off-shops over the past two fiscal years, with beer most popular during July, according to an RTI reply.

Among spirits, Indian Made Foreign Liquor (IMFL) was more in demand than Imported Foreign Liquor (IFL), with Delhi tourism outlets selling about 4.14 crore IMFL bottles in 2024-25, compared with just 22.72 lakh bottles of IFL, the reply shows.

The gap widened further in 2025-26, when IMFL sales touched 4.47 crore bottles, nearly 20 times more than the IFL sales of around 23.3 lakh bottles during the fiscal year.

For IMFL connoisseurs, January 2025-26 saw heavy purchases, with shops selling around 45.4 lakh bottles. February logged nearly 43.3 lakh IMFL-bottle sales, while November saw around 42.3 lakh such bottles fly off liquor shop shelves across the capital, as per the data.

With Diwali and a host of festivals, November also saw a sharp jump in IMFL sales from the previous month. After some 26.6 lakh IMFL bottles were sold in October 2025-26, the figure climbed to nearly 42.3 lakh in November, with more than 15 lakh additional bottles sold during the month, data shows.

Holi in March also called for celebration, with IMFL sales touching nearly 37.9 lakh bottles in 2025-26, compared with around 33.1 lakh bottles sold during the corresponding period in the previous financial year.

The 2025-26 fiscal year also saw higher liquor purchases than the previous financial year, with sales rising from around 9 crore bottles in 2024-25 to about 9.61 crore in 2025-26, according to the reply. The Delhi tourism department runs 233 liquor shops selling 1,013 brands, giving tipplers across the city a wide choice.

Beer drinkers, on the other hand, fervently sought their fix during summers. July 2024 saw around 48.5 lakh beer bottles sold, the highest monthly beer figure in the two years. In July 2025, another 42.4 lakh beer bottles disappeared from off-shop shelves.

Beer sales rose from about 3.51 crore bottles in 2024-25 to 3.76 crore in 2025-26, with 25 lakh more beer bottles sold during 2025-26, the RTI reply said. The second half of 2025-26 also saw beer sales pick up. From October to March, around 1.98 crore beer bottles were sold, compared with around 1.78 crore bottles during the corresponding period a year earlier.

April was also busy for liquor outlets, with nearly 83.5 lakh bottles across categories sold in 2025-26, up from about 69 lakh bottles in April 2024-25. May saw nearly 80.3 lakh bottles purchased, up from around 68.7 lakh bottles in May 2024-25. June was the biggest month for overall liquor sales in 2025-26, with 93.9 lakh bottles sold.

November saw another jump. Delhi liquor shops sold nearly 83.9 lakh bottles across categories, compared with about 67.7 lakh bottles in November 2024, a difference of more than 16 lakh bottles. Imported liquor, however, remained a niche choice. IFL sales stood at about 22.72 lakh bottles in 2024-25 and rose only marginally to around 23.3 lakh bottles in 2025-26.

IFL sales moved up from about 6.9 lakh bottles between April and September 2024-25 to nearly 9.9 lakh bottles during the corresponding period in the next fiscal year, before losing momentum during later months, the data showed.

January 2025-26 saw a lull in imported liquor sales, with about 2.83 lakh IFL bottles purchased, down from nearly 3.72 lakh bottles a fiscal year earlier. October too saw a sizeable fall, while April recorded a sharp increase.

Imported beer had a bigger market than IFL spirits. Around 1.12 crore bottles of imported beer were sold in Delhi in 2024-25, with the figure rising to around 1.14 crore bottles in 2025-26.

IFL beer numbers also picked up in the latter half of the year, with more bottles sold between October and March than during the first six months of 2025-26.

Thus, we may surmise from the figures that when Delhiites go liquor-shopping, Indian-made spirits and beer are at the top of their lists, while imported spirits remain a niche drinking choice. (*PTI*)

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | SEPTEMBER 29, 2026

IN FOCUS



People perform rituals at Assi Ghat on the second day of Pitra Paksha, in Varanasi Uttar Pradesh, Monday PTI

LPU violence sparks political row in Punjab over safety

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

The violence in Phagwara's Lovely Professional University following allegations of a woman student being raped on campus snowballed into a full-scale political controversy on Monday with Opposition parties lashing out at Punjab's ruling AAP over law and order and blaming the police for laxity.

The BJP also alleged that the violence was linked to Union Home Minister Amit Shah's rally scheduled in Jalandhar on September 3, and accused the Bhagwant Mann Government of sending miscreants to the university.

Shah will address the rally to mark the culmination of the BJP's 'Nasha Mukt Punjab Yatra'. LPU students allegedly went on a rampage on the campus late Saturday, vandalising property and blocking a stretch of the New Delhi-Amritsar highway outside their campus over claims that a plumber had raped a female student on the university premises.



Lovely Professional Universitystudents carrying their luggage prepare to leave for their hometowns outside the university campus in Phagwara PTI

Another wave of violence erupted on Sunday evening after the protesting students allegedly pelted police personnel with stones and attacked their vehicles, leaving several cops injured on Sunday, officials said.

The situation remained peaceful on the LPU campus on Monday.

BJP leader and former Union minister Ravneet Singh Bittu alleged that the AAP was "rattled" by the support for the BJP's anti-drug yatras and blamed the Mann Government for "allowing riots" in Jalandhar to disturb Shah's scheduled rally. He said the Government in Punjab is set to change in a few months and officials will be held accountable. Punjab is scheduled to go to polls early next year. Bittu claimed that police adopted a "lax" approach, allowing miscreants to indulge in arson and vandalism and leaving police personnel and students injured.

West Bengal speaker to decide fate of TMC rebel

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

The Supreme Court has for the time being left it on the Bengal Assembly Speaker, Rathin Bose, to decide on the petitions seeking the disqualification of 10 rebel TMC MLAs.

The Bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V. Mohana left it on the Speaker to take a decision by October 10, stating the three-month deadline fixed by the Court in the matter would expire on October 10.

The petition was filed by pro-Mamata Banerjee MLA and former minister Sobhandeb Chattopadhyay, who sought an early decision on the disqualification petitions. Recently the Election Commission of India froze the name and the symbol of the All India Trinamool Congress for the time being, bifurcating the party into two—Mamata Al India Trinamool Congress allotting it a football player as a symbol and the Democratic Trinamool Congress allotting it an envelope.

With the present orders of the ECI and the Apex Court, both groups of the TMC were likely to contest the coming civic elections in the state as per the temporary arrangement made by the poll panel.

The Trinamool Congress split up into two parts after Mamata Banerjee's party was defeated by the BJP in the April-May Assembly elections this year.

While BJP won 208 seats, TMC won 80. Out of these, about 60 MLAs left Mamata Banerjee and formed a parallel group led by present Opposition Leader Ritabrata Banerjee.

Telangana CM objects to SIR mass deletions



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Launching a blistering attack on the BJP-led Central Government, Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy drew a parallel between the pre-independence era and current times, urging the nation to unite and chant "SIR Go Back", much like the historic "Simon Go Back" movement against the Britishers.

Speaking on Monday as the chief guest at The Conclave 2026, organised by the Pratidin Media Network, Assam, in New Delhi, the Chief Minister accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi of weaponising the Election Commission of India (ECI) to strip the poor of their voting rights. "While the Congress party stands firmly with the underprivileged, the BJP aligns itself exclusively with the wealthy," Reddy asserted.

The Chief Minister levelled serious allegations regarding the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process, claiming it is a calculated political exercise targeting the 2029 general elections.

Reddy alleged that 13 crore votes have already been deleted across the country, with active efforts underway to purge another 7 crore votes.

He claimed this is a targeted attempt by the Modi administration to eliminate 20 crore votes belonging to citizens who oppose the BJP.

"When the entire decision-making authority has been centralised with Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar in Delhi, what is the purpose of having BLAs, BLOs, and District Collectors?" Reddy questioned.

Crimes against women in Delhi-NCR show systematic police failure, recalls Nirbhaya: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday observed that cases of crimes against girls and women across Delhi-NCR underline a systematic failure of the police and said one cannot help but draw painful parallels to the 2012 Nirbhaya case, calling into question whether systemic law enforcement mechanisms have made any meaningful progress in the decade since then.

The top court also passed a slew of directions while taking cognisance of news reports of crimes against minor girls and women across Delhi-NCR while directing the Delhi Police Commissioner to constitute dedicated police teams to conduct an immediate survey and inspection of vulnerable pockets. The court also asked media outlets, journalists and publishing platforms to practise responsible, empathetic and restrained journalism while reporting sexual offences. A bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran said sensationalist headlines, graphic or lurid



descriptions of sexual violence, and insensitive phraseology fail to serve any public interest and risk causing severe secondary trauma to the victims and their families. The Supreme Court made these observations while taking su0 moto cognisance of the alleged gang rape of a 17-year-old girl at Aastha Kunj Park in Delhi, alleged gang rape and murder of a teenage girl in the Swaroop Nagar area of Delhi and alleged sexual assault of a minor girl inside a moving sleeper bus. The law enforcement agencies allegedly failed to intercept while it traversed a distance of over 47 km from Greater Noida to Delhi.

The court said these incidents, considered alongside other recent reports of sexual offences across Delhi-NCR, starkly underline a systemic failure on the part of law enforcement and civil administrative authorities to guarantee basic public safety.

"The right to live with dignity, free from the fear of violence, is an intrinsic facet of the fundamental guarantee of life and personal liberty enshrined under Article 21 of the Constitution. Public spaces, including parks, roads, buses, metro stations, subways, foot bridges, etc. cannot be permitted to become zones of high risk due to grossly inadequate illumination, poor surveillance, lax patrolling, or other preventable administrative deficiencies," the bench said.

The top court said statements made by public authorities and elected representatives expressing concern over these incidents are understandable.

"However, expressions of concern, devoid of accountability, fall short of answering the larger institutional question. Expressing solidarity is not the solution to this social evil.

1,500 pilgrims rescued after landslide hits Kedarnath trek



Members of the State Disaster Response Force (SDRF) specialised high-altitude team trek through forest terrain during a rescue operation along the Kalindi Trek near the Auden's Col area in Uttarkashi district PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Uttarkashi

About 1,500 pilgrims stranded in the Chirbasa area along the Kedarnath trek route after a landslide were successfully evacuated, officials said on Monday.

Joint teams comprising State Disaster Response Force (SDRF), National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) and District Disaster Response Force (DDRF) successfully rescued and escorted approximately 1,500 pilgrims to Gaurikund after they were stranded late at Sunday night, the SDRF said in a press statement.

It said that the Sonprayag police received information that several pilgrims were stranded in the Chirbasa area — located about 3 kilometres from Gaurikund -- due to a landslide. Upon receiving the information, an SDRF team from Sonprayag, led by Sub-Inspector Ashish Dimri, arrived at the site and found debris accumulated on the road near the Chirbasa helipad due to the landslide, officials said. Additionally, continuous rockfalls from the hillside made the movement of pilgrims extremely hazardous. Assessing the situation, the SDRF, NDRF, and DDRF teams launched a joint rescue operation, officials said. The rescue teams carefully guided the pilgrims across the landslide zone; they were safely escorted to the other side and sent onward to Gaurikund, according to the statement.

FROM PAGE - 1

SC steps in on women's safety in Capital

The Bench sought a comprehensive status report on the measures presently undertaken to ensure adequate safety and security arrangements in public places frequented by women and children.

The report shall indicate whether such arrangements remain equally effective during peak hours, late evening hours and early morning hours, when public spaces may have reduced visibility and footfall, it said.

The Bench also sought a report on the manner in which the National Database on Sexual Offenders (NDSO) is presently being utilised by the Delhi Police.

"We would require the authorities to indicate whether the database is being regularly accessed for antecedent verification and identification of repeat or habitual sexual offenders...," the bench said, while also seeking a report on the manner in which the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) is utilising the Investigation Tracking System for Sexual Offences (ITSSO).

"The authorities shall place on record the manner in which ITSSO is being utilised in Delhi, including the mechanism for monitoring investigations which are required to be completed within the statutory period, the officers responsible for such monitoring, the frequency with which cases are reviewed and the remedial steps taken where an investigation is delayed.

"The report shall also indicate whether senior officers receive alerts or periodic reports in cases where the prescribed timelines are not being adhered to," it said.

SC gives ECI four months to settle TMC dispute

On Monday, senior advocate DS Naidu, appearing for the poll panel, referred to four past instances when the ECI had to decide the symbol matter. He said such matters take time as documents and affidavits from party workers come in huge numbers.

"Three months have gone by. Within the next three months, you decide this," the Bench told Naidu. The SC observed that the poll panel can make use of AI tools and take help of technology. Naidu said that the time frame should be fixed from the date the parties complete their pleadings. Senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Banerjee, said they have already filed their responses in July, but the other side has not yet done so.

Naidu told the Bench that Assembly elections in some States are scheduled to come up, and the ECI needed to focus its resources there also.

When the Bench asked the ECI to finally decide the matter within three months of the completion of pleadings, Naidu requested that some more time be given. The Bench said in case of any exigency, the poll panel may approach the court. The ECI on September 17 allotted separate names and symbols to the two rival factions following its interim decision to bar both groups from using the All India Trinamool Congress name and its reserved symbol pending a substantive determination of the dispute.

The poll panel allotted the name Mamata All India Trinamool Congress and football player as its symbol to the Mamata Banerjee-led faction, while the Ritabrata Banerjee-led faction was allotted the name Democratic Trinamool Congress and given the symbol of an envelope. Assembly bypolls to Nandigram in East Medinipur district and Rejinagar in Murshidabad district of West Bengal are scheduled for October 6, with vote counting on October 9.

A similar case related to Shiv Sena is before the SC, which had on September 24 said the dispute should be decided expeditiously and asked the ECI to suggest a time frame that would allow both sides a fair opportunity to present their evidence while enabling the poll panel to reach a final decision.

Delhi braces for winter smog with sweeping...

Also beginning November 1, BS-IV vehicles registered outside Delhi will be completely prohibited from entering the city.

The CM also said parking charges across the Capital will be doubled from November 1, while office timings will be staggered and 50 per cent work from home will be implemented. Electric vehicles and parking spaces owned and managed by the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) will be exempt from the revised charges.

The decisions were taken after Union Minister of Environment, Forest and Climate Change Bhupender Yadav chaired a high-level meeting with CM Gupta. PWD Minister Parvesh Verma, Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa and senior officials of Delhi Government were also present.

Under the plan, public representatives would undertake regular field visits of Delhi's traffic hotspots with officials, RWAs, traders, and traffic police. So far, 42 hotspots have been rectified, with eight more targeted in October. In consultation with Delhi Traffic Police, one-way traffic and decongestion trials would be undertaken at hotspots. A strict campaign against end-of-life vehicles will also be carried out at all petrol pumps in the Capital.

Delhi has ranked as the most polluted among 33 states and Union territories with an annual mean PM2.5 concentration of 101 micrograms per cubic metre, 2.5 times the Indian standard and 20 times the WHO guideline, according to a satellite-based analysis. The Government has registered 723 construction sites on its monitoring system, with pollution control at the sites being monitored through an AI-enabled automated system. Sirsa said less than 2-3 per cent of the sites had reported violations. According to the Government presentation, 600 of the 723 registered construction sites have been equipped with web cameras, while 100 per cent camera coverage of sites registered on the construction and demolition portal is targeted by October-end.

A target has been set for the redevelopment of 3,000 km of roads to control dust generated from roads, of which work on 1,193 km has already been completed, the minister added. The concrete work has been given a deadline of October 31, 2026, while the bitumen work is to be completed by November 15, 2026. Alongside road reconstruction, work on deep cleaning, mechanised cleaning, water sprinkling, creating paved surfaces across roads, improving footpaths, removing garbage accumulation points and increasing green cover on vacant land is being expedited.

Digital creator Nidhi Tiwari found dead

Tiwari had established herself as a prominent social media personality through regular posts and videos that attracted a large audience. Her content received thousands of reactions and some of her videos were viewed millions of times. She was also pursuing opportunities in modelling and acting.

In 2024, she won the 'Miss Pretty India' title, an achievement that further boosted her public profile. According to people familiar with her, she aspired to establish herself in the entertainment industry and remained involved in modelling events and digital content creation.

Her family has told police that she had been speaking to someone over the phone on Saturday evening. Police are examining this and other circumstances preceding her death, but officials have cautioned against attributing any specific reason to the incident until the investigation is complete.

Morwa police station in-charge Dr Gyanendra Singh said investigators were collecting information from her family members, acquaintances and others connected with the case. Call records, digital activity and other relevant evidence are also being examined to establish the sequence of events before her death.

The news of Tiwari's death prompted an outpouring of grief across social media. Followers posted tributes recalling her online presence, modelling journey and achievements, while messages expressing shock and condolences continued to appear on her social media accounts.

Ujjain road widening turns tense ahead of...

Members of the Muslim community and the Shahi Masjid committee agreed to voluntarily remove the portion of the mosque within the proposed widening area after a meeting with the district administration on Sunday night.

Removal work began Monday morning. Ujjain Collector and District Magistrate Roushan Kumar Singh said the work was progressing with community cooperation. He said some people tried to disrupt the process but police brought them under control. Singh appealed to people to ignore rumours and maintain peace.

Superintendent of Police Pradeep Sharma said some people attempted to obstruct the work and later resorted to stone-pelting. Police used tear gas and mild force to disperse the crowd. He said no one was injured. Police arrested some people, while 15 others were detained. Police registered a case against seven people, including some social media influencers accused of sharing inflammatory content and inciting people. Police have intensified surveillance in the area, with CCTV and drone cameras being used to identify those allegedly involved in stone-pelting. Sharma said police would take legal action against those found responsible. Police also conducted flag marches in the city as a precautionary measure.

Police cordoned off the area around Chhatri Chowk and temporarily restricted movement. Senior police and administrative officials remained on site to monitor the situation.

Ujjain Shahar Qazi Khalil-ur-Rehman and senior members of the Muslim community appealed to people not to believe rumours. Khalil-ur-Rehman said the mosque issue had been resolved through mutual consent during discussions on Sunday night.

The administration said the road-widening exercise is part of preparations for the large influx of devotees during Simhastha. Singh said people from different religious communities were voluntarily cooperating with the development work and removing obstructions falling within the planned road alignment.

SC to hear UPI fee challenge, seeks...

It is capped at ₹300 for payments of ₹75,000 or more. Person-to-person payments and smaller amounts will still be free, the NPCI has clarified.

Additional Solicitor General N Venkataraman, representing the Government, told the court that 96 per cent of people using the payment gateway would not be affected by the new fee. "The Government of India is not taking even a single rupee out of it," the law officer said.

The court asked the Government to submit a written explanation about why it decided to charge a fee on UPI merchant transactions over ₹2,000. Venkataraman said charges for essential services are capped at ₹5. He said, "It is neither a tax nor a fee." The court said, "We need all these facts in a short affidavit. It will help us understand better. It is less a legal issue and more a technical issue... Is it a tax or a fee? If not a fee, then what is the executive basis for making this expropriation?"

ASG explained that the fee is a settlement charge between payment aggregators and banks. He added, "The Government is several steps away from this money."

After the Bench issued notice on the plea, the petitioner's lawyer requested, "Please stay it till then." Payments made to mutual funds, securities, and through stockbrokers and dealers will have a 0.02 per cent MDR, with a maximum charge of ₹300.

The petition claims the new fee was introduced without enough legal safeguards, transparency, or public input. It challenges the constitutional validity of the amended Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, alleging that it gives the executive unguided power to decide which electronic payment modes would receive the no-charge protection.

"Declare that no MDR or analogous compulsory charge may be imposed or recovered merely on the strength of a press release or FAQs absent a duly authorised, authenticated and published statutory instrument," it said.

The petitioner also questioned why UPI transactions are treated differently from RuPay debit card payments, noting that RuPay cards still have no-charge protection with no upper limit. The petition argues that the new rules are unfair and could hurt merchants with small profit margins. It also warns about possible hidden costs for consumers and the risk that some people could be left out of digital payments.

It has sought to quash or suspend the framework insofar as it imposes an MDR on UPI transactions above ₹2,000.

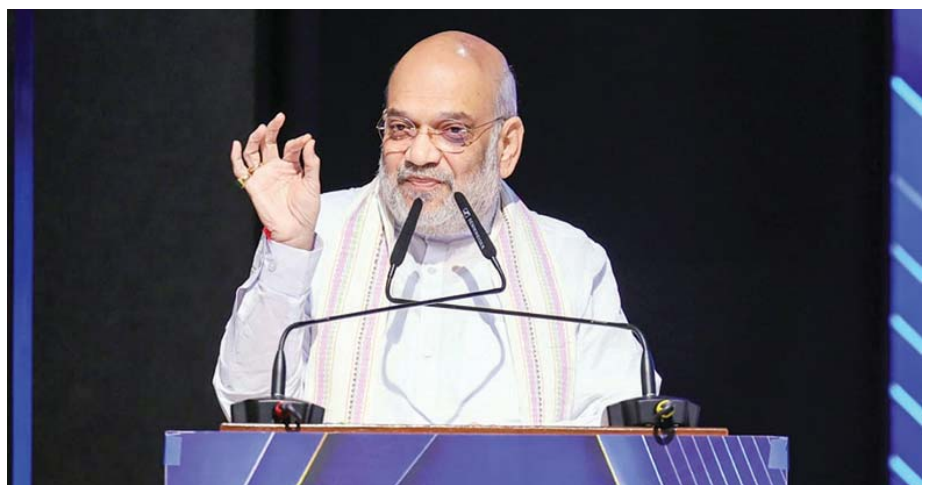
Alternatively, the petition wants the rules reviewed after open consultation, data sharing, and an impact study, with protections for micro and small businesses.

"Direct that any future MDR classification be based on relevant considerations including merchant turnover, statutory MSME status, actual margins, geography and ability to bear the cost, and avoid cliff-edge treatment unsupported by evidence," the plea said.

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | SEPTEMBER 29, 2026

Shah launches India's first counter-terrorism policy

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
New Delhi



Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation Amit Shah on Monday inaugurated the Conference on 'PRAHAAR-CT Policy and Strategy' in New Delhi. The meeting brought together senior security and police officials to review and implement India's first national counter-terrorism doctrine.

Shah said the Government of India, under Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has adopted a zero-tolerance policy against terrorism. He called for ongoing review of the PRAHAAR framework based on analysis of terror incidents, and for building a mechanism that can serve the country over the next decade. He said the principles of PRAHAAR must be implemented at the police station level, and that all levels of the security system should act proactively.

Shah called for an automated counter-terrorism response at every level to avoid delays and ensure effective action. He said central agencies, state police, and other stakeholders must coordinate closely so that there is no delay when a threat arises.

The Home Minister said the Government has already used this coordinated approach in recent operations. Between 2019 and 2026, authorities brought back 288 fugitive criminals from 36 countries. Improved coordination led to the dismantling of over 40 modules of the Shahzad Bhatti network, which was involved in cross-border smuggling of weapons, explosives, and narcotics. Authorities registered more than 100 FIRs and arrested 350 people across 15 States.

The network has been declared a terrorist organisation under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. Shah also launched a new Extradition Portal to speed up efforts to bring back fugitives. He directed state police to form teams to work with central agencies so they can prepare and follow up on extradition requests quickly.

For decades, India's counter-terrorism efforts relied on separate laws, agencies, and practices that developed over time. In 2026, PRAHAAR brought these elements together as the country's first unified National Counter-Terrorism Policy and Strategy. Shah has stressed that the policy needs regular updates, should become part of daily operations, and must be implemented at every police station.

The doctrine is built on seven main pillars. Prevention relies on intelligence to stop plots, propaganda, sleeper cells, funding, and arms networks before attacks happen. Response means local police act quickly and appropriately, with fast backup from central forces to avoid delays in the crucial first hours.

Aggregating Internal Capacities means updating state police, standardising training, and working closely with agencies like the Multi-Agency Centre, the National Investigation Agency, the National Security Guard, and the Central Armed Police Forces. It also stresses the importance of human rights and the rule of law to keep counter-terrorism efforts legal and trustworthy. Attenuating Conditions for Terrorism focuses on de-radicalisation, involving communities, and supporting youth and women in at-risk areas to lower recruitment. Aligning International Efforts covers sharing intelligence, legal help, extradition, and diplomacy to stop terrorists from finding safe havens, weapons, or funding abroad.

Recovery and Resilience takes a society-wide approach to help communities, rebuild infrastructure, and restore public trust after an attack. Shah pointed out that these pillars are important because earlier methods were often reactive and scattered across different ministries and agencies.

PRAHAAR does not set up new organisations. Instead, it gives a single framework for the ones already in place. This framework should be used at every level and tested in real situations to make sure it stays effective. Shah has also linked the doctrine to current tools, such as faster return of fugitives, trials in absentia, stronger investigations under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, and joint action against networks that mix crime, drugs, weapons, and ideology.

The doctrine moves away from one-off responses and instead uses a single national approach. It covers every part of terrorism, such as propaganda, funding, logistics, overseas handlers, and recovery after attacks. Local police handle the first response, with quick help from central forces. The doctrine also combines security work with social and economic steps to reduce radicalisation and shows India's strong commitment to working with other countries and maintaining zero tolerance.

TRAI orders cheaper voice-and-SMS packs

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
New Delhi



For millions of Indians who mostly use their phones for calls and texts, prepaid recharge has often felt like being forced to buy a combo meal. Staying connected at the lowest cost usually meant paying for mobile data they hardly used. Now, that is starting to change.

The Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) has notified the Telecom Consumers Protection (Thirteenth Amendment) Regulations, 2026, directing operators such as Reliance Jio, Bharti Airtel and Vodafone Idea to expand voice-and-SMS-only Special Tariff Vouchers. The rules take effect about 30 days after gazette publication, putting the new packs on shop floors and apps around late October.

TRAI saw a clear problem. After a 2024 rule required at least one voice-and-SMS-only pack, most companies offered only long-term options, like 80- or 84-day packs, or annual plans lasting 336 to 365 days.

Those packs suited people who could lock in money for months. They did little for daily-wage workers, elderly users, feature-phone owners, rural subscribers and people who keep a second SIM only for calls. Short-duration, no-data choices were scarce. If an operator sold a 28-day or 30-day bundle with calls, texts and data, a cheaper The new rules fix this gap. If a company already sells a bundled pack for 30 days or less, it must now offer a similar voice-and-SMS-only voucher at a lower, fair price. voucher at an "appropriate" lower price.

TRAI did not set a strict formula after hearing from stakeholders, but the main idea is simple: if you remove data, the price should go down. Operators must also offer at least one voice-and-SMS pack that renews on the same date each month. If that date does not exist, like February 31 (This month has 28 days), the renewal happens on the last day of the month. They also need to keep at least one longer-term no-data pack that matches their quarterly or annual plans. This monthly-date rule is important. Many prepaid packs still use 28-day cycles, which means users recharge 13 times a year. A same-date monthly option brings it back to 12 payments, making it easier for families to plan their budgets.

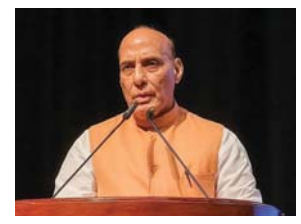
For families who recharge on salary day, this small calendar change can be as helpful as a lower price. It is easy to imagine who will benefit: a grandparent who never uses YouTube, a shopkeeper who relies on Wi-Fi at home and only needs the phone for customers, a migrant worker who cannot afford a big quarterly payment, or a student with campus internet who wants a cheap backup number. Right now, voice-and-SMS annual packs cost between ₹1,748 and ₹1,849, and quarterly packs are about ₹448 to ₹470. Shorter, cheaper options should make it easier for these users to stay connected.

TRAI finalised the amendment after sharing a draft on April 7, 2026, receiving 1,132 public comments, and holding an open-house discussion in June. The regulator says its goal is not to slow India's data growth, but to ensure bundling does not become an extra cost for people who do not want data. Feature phones, second SIMs, and Wi-Fi-first homes are still a big part of the market. Customers will no longer have to buy unused gigabytes to keep a number alive. Implementation will test the operators. They must redesign menus, recast prices and make the new vouchers easy to find in apps, USSD codes and kirana-store recharge counters.

Clarity will matter as much as price. If the no-data packs are buried under flashy unlimited-data offers, the reform will exist only on paper. If they are visible, affordable and easy to renew, the next recharge will feel less like buying extras and more like paying only for what the phone is actually used for: a call, a message, and a connection that lasts as long as the user can afford.

Gunners remain pillar of India's defence: Rajnath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



The historic Regiment of Artillery marked its 200th Raising Day on Monday, with Defence Minister Rajnath Singh saying the Gunners have distinguished themselves through courage, precision and unwavering commitment across generations, while remaining a "formidable pillar" of India's combat prowess.

The Indian Army and its chief, General Dhiraj Seth, also extended greetings to the serving personnel and veterans of the Regiment, saying that with precision, firepower and an unwavering commitment to mission accomplishment, the Gunners remain a formidable force on the battlefield, serving with pride and upholding the motto of 'Sarvatra Izzat-O-Iqbal'.

September 28 has a special significance in the annals of the history of the Regiment of Artillery as the first Indian Artillery unit, 5 (Bombay) Mountain Battery equipped with 2.5 inch RML Gun, was raised on this day in 1827. The Regiment celebrates the occasion every year as Gunners Day on September 28.

The Regiment of Artillery also proved its mettle during the military operations of 1947-48, 1962, 1965, 1971 and 1999. After the 1999 Kargil conflict, the artillery acquired further prominence, and with its vast array of weapons, it is acknowledged as a significant "Arm of Decision", the defence ministry had said earlier.

Piyush Goyal to visit US for G20 meet, push for interim trade deal

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi



Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal will travel to the United States from September 29 to October 5 to attend the G20 Trade Ministers' meeting and hold discussions with his US counterpart on efforts to advance an interim India-US bilateral trade agreement (BTA).

Goyal is visiting Milwaukee, Wisconsin, at the invitation of the US Trade Representative. He is scheduled to participate in the G20 Trade Ministers' meeting on September 30 and October 1 before travelling to Chicago for meetings with American business leaders and members of the Indian diaspora, according to the Commerce Ministry.

At the G20 meeting, India will seek to work with member countries towards an open, transparent and non-discriminatory global trading system, with the World Trade Organization (WTO) remaining at its centre. India will also emphasise the need to preserve sufficient policy flexibility for developing economies.

Goyal is expected to hold bilateral discussions with several trade counterparts on the sidelines of the meeting. The talks will focus on expanding opportunities for Indian farmers, fishermen, women entrepreneurs, startups, micro, small and medium enterprises and other businesses.

A key component of his US visit will be discussions with the US administration on the India-US BTA. The two sides have been working towards an interim arrangement as part of broader efforts to establish a balanced and mutually beneficial trade framework.

India and the US had reached a framework for an interim BTA in February. However, the proposed agreement has faced delays following developments surrounding the legal basis for the preferential tariff structure offered by Washington. New Delhi is seeking a competitive tariff arrangement that would provide Indian exporters a level playing field with competing economies.

During his meetings in Milwaukee and Chicago, Goyal will also interact with senior executives from major US companies across sectors including manufacturing, consumer goods, agribusiness, retail and technology. He is expected to promote India as a manufacturing and investment destination and participate in discussions with businesses, startups and innovative companies.

The Commerce Ministry said the visit is aimed at strengthening the India-US trade and investment relationship while deepening New Delhi's engagement with its G20 partners.

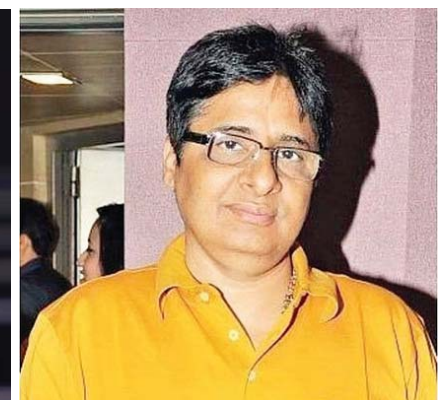
In Chicago, Goyal is also scheduled to pay tribute to Mahatma Gandhi on Gandhi Jayanti and Swami Vivekananda. He will meet professional associations representing the Indian community during his visit.

Before leaving for the US, Goyal on Monday co-chaired the 14th meeting of the India-UAE High-Level Joint Task Force on Investments in Mumbai with Sheikh Hamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, managing director of the Abu Dhabi Investment Authority.

Income Tax Department raids 12 Mumbai sites linked to Rakul Preet, Vashu Bhagnani

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Mumbai





Actor Rakul Preet Singh, Producer Vashu Bhagnani

The Mumbai Income Tax Department on Monday began simultaneous search operations at 12 locations across the city linked to actor Rakul Preet Singh, her father-in-law and producer Vashu Bhagnani, and the production-distribution company Panorama Studios. Separate teams fanned out to offices and other premises associated with the film personalities and the banners around them. The action, according to people familiar with the matter, follows inputs that funds may have been sent abroad in the name of film financing.

Officials are examining whether remittances described as project costs were used to move money out of India and, in the process, under-report income or evade tax. The suspected cover includes foreign location shoots, international production expenses and the sale or purchase of overseas distribution rights. Investigators have been examining paper files, digital records, ledgers, and bank statements related to those cross-border transfers. No official amount has been disclosed, and the department has not issued a detailed public note on what has been found so far.

The sites under search include premises linked to Rakul Preet Singh and the Bhagnani family as well as offices associated with Pooja Entertainment and Panorama Studios. Rakul Preet Singh is married to actor-producer Jackky Bhagnani, son of Vashu Bhagnani. Pooja Entertainment, the family banner, has produced more than forty Hindi films, among them the 1990s commercial hits Coolie No. 1, Hero No. 1 and Biwi No. 1. Panorama Studios, headed by Kumar Mangat Pathak, is known for titles such as Raid and the Drishyam series. One of its forthcoming releases, Drishyam: The Conclusion, is scheduled for October 2.

As of late Monday, the searches were still in progress. Reporters who sought comment from Rakul Preet Singh's team, the Bhagnanis and Kumar Mangat Pathak received no reply by the time early accounts were filed. That is not unusual while teams are still on the premises and records are being taken into custody. A search is an investigative step. It does not by itself prove wrongdoing, and it does not amount to a charge. The department will first study the material recovered, match it against declared income and permitted remittances, and then decide whether notices or further proceedings are warranted.

The case has drawn notice because overseas spending is a normal part of film work. Foreign shoots, co-productions and international rights deals happen regularly, and money can leave India for those purposes when invoices, contracts and tax treatment are in order. The present inquiry turns on whether the remittances under review were genuine project costs or a way to shift funds and conceal income. Until the papers are analysed, that question remains open.

No list of specific films, no names of foreign counterparties and no seizure value have been made public by the IT department. Sources said clearer official word is expected only after the searches end and the records are processed.

BJP will make West Bengal economic giant again: Nabin

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
Kolkata

The Suvendu Adhikari Government would work nonstop towards making West Bengal an economic giant once again, BJP national president Nitin Nabin on Monday said. Blaming the Trinamool Congress regime led by Mamata Banerjee for leaving a devastating effect on the State's economic health, Nabin said the priority of the saffron Government would be to make West Bengal an investment-friendly State once again.

"The TMC Government ruined the economy of West Bengal... so much so that about 6700 companies fled the State in the 15 years that it ruled... they literally robbed Bengal of its economic backbone," the BJP leader said, launching a scathing attack on the former Chief Minister. "With the help of the people of West Bengal, a new dawn has arrived... and the priority of our Government will be to bring back investment," he said. He was addressing a 'Yuva Samvad Conclave'. Hitting back at the BJP leadership, senior pro-Mamata TMC MLA Kunal Ghosh said that Bengal was a victim of the BJP-led Central Government's stepmotherly attitude.

Kolkata to drop Marx, Lenin names from road names for Indian icons

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
Kolkata

Soon Karl Marx, VI Lenin, Ho Chi Minh, or, for that matter, Prince Anwar Shah, the grandson of Tipu Sultan, would go off Kolkata roads, giving way to Desi exemplars like Debaprasad Ghosh or Michael Madhusudan Dutt and even Ram Kothari, one of the brothers who were killed in Ayodhya police firing.

The 10-member committee constituted by the State Government has already started functioning, with Kartik Maharaj, or Swami Pradiptananda of the Bharat Sevashram Sangha, among its members. Among others on the committee are former Bengal BJP president and ex Tripura Governor Tathagata Roy and Subrata Gupta, the Chief Advisor to Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari.

The monk, who has already been allocated an office at the Kolkata Municipal Corporation, has started his work in earnest on the road rechristening project, one was told.

"There are many roads of Kolkata which were arbitrarily named after people who neither visited Bengal or India or left any contribution for this country... so where is a need to lug their so-called legacy by us," the Swami said, adding the panel has already received names of a few roads for consideration, including Biswa Bangla Sarani (named by former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee) and Ho Chi Minh Sarani — "names which are not connected either to Bengal's culture or history."

Recommendations had been sent on a few roads: "the members will consider their connections with Bharatiya Sanskriti (Indian culture) and that of Bengal and draw up a proposal after careful consideration," he said, adding that the proposal will then be recommended to the State Assembly. Wondering, "what Lenin or Karl Marx did for India or why the names like Prince Anwar Shah will have to be continued for nothing ... what contribution do they have for India or Bengal... even in their own countries they are not remembered today," said BJP MLA Sajal Ghosh.



Lenin Sarani, Kolkata WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

While Karl Marx was a German philosopher, social and political theorist, and revolutionary socialist, Lenin was the father of the Bolshevik Revolution in Russia, and Ho Chi Minh was the Vietnamese communist revolutionary and statesman who founded the Democratic Republic of Vietnam in 1945 and became its first president.

The road-renaming exercise is not new to Kolkata; previously, roads like Amherst Street were renamed Rammohan Roy Sarani, Lansdown Road was rechristened Sarat Bose Road, and Bidhan Sarani was called College Street. Similarly, today's Lenin Sarani was called Dharamtalla Street, whereas Karla Marx Sarani was known as Kidderpore Circular/Garden Reach Road.

According to sources, members have suggested renaming Ho Chi Minh Sarani (avenue) after Debaprasad Ghosh, a mathematician and former president of the Bharatiya Jana Sangh. Proposals have also come to rename the Karl Marx Sarani Kidderpore/Circular Garden Reach Road after prominent Bengali poets Michael Madhusudan Dutt or Rangalal Bandyopadhyay. Parallel names have also been suggested for Ho Chi Minh Sarani (formerly Harrington Street), according to which it should be renamed after US civil rights leader Martin Luther King Jr.

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | SEPTEMBER 29, 2026

States Focus



NAVAL COMMANDERS' MEET TO FOCUS ON WEST ASIA CRISIS

The Navy top brass will review operational readiness, with a special focus on the ongoing West Asia conflict and ongoing modernisation of the naval fleet during the three-day biannual conference starting Tuesday.

Giving details, an official said on Monday that the senior leadership will undertake a comprehensive review of its operational preparedness and contribution to safeguarding India's maritime interests, including energy security amid the West Asia conflict.

The commanders' conference - the Navy's apex-level forum - will be attended by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) General NS Raja Subramani and Navy Chief Admiral Krishna Swaminathan. Army Chief General Dhiraj Seth is also scheduled to interact with participants. (*PNS*)



GOA CM SAWANT SLAMS CONGRESS FOR TARGETING ECI

Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant on Monday hit out at the Congress for targeting the Election Commission of India (ECI), saying political parties cannot win elections by repeatedly levelling accusations against constitutional institutions and demanding proof of electoral procedures. Addressing a press conference in Panaji, Sawant alleged that the Congress questions the credibility of EVMs only when it loses elections but accepts the same system after winning in States like Karnataka, Telangana and Himachal Pradesh. He also cited Goa's zilla panchayat elections, which are conducted using ballot papers, to argue that the party's electoral setbacks cannot be attributed solely to EVMs.

"When the EVM issue does not work, they (Congress) start making allegations against constitutional institutions," he said, alleging that the Opposition party's actions aim to create doubts in the minds of voters. Sawant's remarks have come amid a row over the ECI's functioning after the Indian Express reported that Election Commissioners SS Sandhu and Vivek Joshi objected on record at least 14 times over the past 10 months to decisions concerning voter registration, deletions and restoration of names and the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. The Election Commission is an independent body, and repeatedly levelling allegations against institutions was not appropriate, Sawant said. (*PNS*)

J&K passes resolution demanding full Statehood

MOHIT KANDHARI
Jammu



PDP MLA holds a placard amid a protest in support of statehood resolution moves by Jammu and Kashmir CM Omar Abdullah during the Autumn session of union territory Legislative Assembly in Srinagar on Monday PTI

Notwithstanding stiff opposition from Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) legislators, the Jammu and Kashmir Legislative Assembly on Monday passed another resolution calling upon the Government of India for the immediate and urgent restoration of full Statehood to the Union Territory.

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah moved the resolution on Friday, September 25, during the ongoing autumn session. It was deferred after several members sought to speak on the issue and after protests disrupted proceedings.

On Monday, it was taken up again and passed by voice vote after BJP members walked out.

The resolution will be forwarded to the Government of India.

Meanwhile, four MLAs were also marshalled out of the Assembly after BJP members created a ruckus in the House, protesting the resolution moved by the Chief Minister to restore Statehood.

The text of the resolution States: "In addition to the November 2024 resolution resolutions passed by this House on June 26, 2000 and 6 November 2024, the House calls upon the Government of India for the immediate and urgent restoration of full statehood to Jammu and Kashmir and resolves that this resolution be forwarded to the Government of India."

The 2000 resolution, passed during Farooq Abdullah's tenure, had sought restoration of Jammu and Kashmir's pre-1953 constitutional position. The had called for dialogue on special status and constitutional guarantees after the abrogation of Article 370.

BJP legislators strongly objected to those references, arguing they amounted to an attempt to revive autonomy and special-status demands under the cover of a Statehood resolution.

Leader of Opposition Sunil Sharma said the party supports restoration of Statehood but rejects linking it to the pre-August 5, 2019 status.

The BJP said the reference to autonomy and special status in the resolution was an insult to the Constitution and it would not allow a discussion on it or its passage in the House.

The Opposition BJP protested against the resolution with party members jumping into the well of the House, tearing business papers and conducting mock proceedings.

BJP members also demanded Speaker Abdul Rahim Rather leave the chair.

The party also submitted a notice seeking the Speaker's removal, alleging he had allowed the resolution in violation of rules. Rather declined to step down, saying he had not read the notice and that procedure required it to be listed later.

As chaos prevailed, Leader of Opposition, Sunil Sharma, raised provocative slogans targeting the Chief Minister. National Conference (NC) members reacted, resulting in a slogan-shouting match between the opposition and the treasury benches.

The Congress also raised slogans against the BJP Government at the Centre. Congress MLA Irfan Lone was seen displaying a banner reading "Gyanesh Kumar resign".

As the noisy scenes continued, Deputy Chief Minister Surinder Chaudhary said the chair should direct the LoP to tender an apology for the "unparliamentary language" used against the chief minister.

The BJP MLAs continued their protest and attacked Congress MLAs with a microphone stand; however, the Assembly marshals overpowered them.

BJP MLAs Vikram Randhawa and Arvind Gupta, along with Congress MLAs Irfan Lone and Iftikhar Ahmad, were marshalled out of the Assembly.

Participating in the Assembly debate on statehood, the Chief Minister asked tough questions: why Jammu and Kashmir must wait for "guns to go silent".

He also urged members of the ruling benches not to press for amendments to the resolution, saying this could provide the BJP with a reason to oppose it.

"Please don't press for your amendments because that gives a reason to the BJP to oppose the resolution," he told the ruling party members.

Meanwhile, Leader of Opposition Sunil Sharma and other BJP members raised slogans of "Delhi *ke saath aankh macholi bandh karo*" in the House.

Sharma objected to the language being used in the Assembly in connection with the proposed resolution.

"We also are in favour of Statehood. We want to bring Statehood," he said. "But the kind of language being used in this House is tearing apart the basic structure of the Constitution of India."

AAP discloses ₹12.1 crore donations, down 68% from last year

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi


AAP National Convenor Arvind Kejriwal during an interview session on Day 2 of 'The Conclave 2026' in New Delhi on Monday PTI

The AAP has disclosed Rs 12.10 crore in contributions for 2025-26, down 68 per cent from the previous year, with nearly 83 per cent of the amount coming from Prudent Electoral Trust and Trident Limited, a company founded by former party MP Rajinder Gupta.

According to the party's contribution report to the Election Commission, Ashutosh Ranka, now a co-convener of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) and former AAP spokesperson, donated ₹21,100 to the party.

The contributions were made during 2025-26, before he took up his role in the CJP.

Prudent and Trident each gave ₹5 crore to the AAP. The remaining contributions totalled about ₹2.10 crore.

Gupta was elected to the Rajya Sabha on an AAP ticket in October 2025.

Trident's ₹5-crore cheque was dated January 9, 2026, when Gupta was with the Arvind Kejriwal-led party. He joined the BJP in April this year.

AAP had disclosed ₹38.10 crore in contributions in 2024-25, more than three times the ₹11.06 crore it reported in 2023-24. Prudent was its largest donor in 2024-25, giving ₹16.40 crore.

The latest filing covers the first full financial year since the AAP lost power in Delhi in February 2025. The party continues to govern Punjab, where Trident is based.

Its report contains 1,202 numbered entries.

Party chief Arvind Kejriwal is listed against three contributions of ₹10,000 each. Former Delhi chief minister Atishi made 12 payments of ₹3,500 each, totalling ₹42,000, while Punjab AAP president Aman Arora is listed against 12 payments of ₹10,000 each, totalling ₹1.20 lakh.

Reports filed by three other regional parties also show how their disclosed contributions have changed since the 2024 Assembly elections.

The Telugu Desam Party (TDP), which came to power in Andhra Pradesh, reported ₹58.25 crore in contributions for 2025-26, down from ₹83.03 crore the previous year. Prudent Electoral Trust gave it ₹45 crore, up from ₹40 crore in 2024-25.

The YSR Congress Party, which was ousted from power by the TDP, reported contributions worth ₹24.31 crore, down from about ₹140.04 crore in 2024-25. Its largest donor in the latest filing was Goodwood Sanctuary Private Limited, listed against ₹10 crore.

The Biju Janata Dal, which lost power in Odisha in 2024, listed no contributions above ₹20,000 in its latest report. It had disclosed ₹60 crore in 2024-25, all received in April and May 2024, before the election results were declared. The party had also filed nil reports for such contributions in 2022-23 and 2023-24, when electoral bonds were still available.

Under the rules, parties must identify donors whose contributions exceed ₹20,000 during a financial year. These contribution reports do not show a party's full annual income, which is reported separately in its audited accounts.

CJP will not back down till CEC resigns: Ranka

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Guwahati

CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka on Monday asserted that the outfit would not back down from its demand for the resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar over the alleged exclusion of 13 crore names from electoral rolls and challenged him to clear the allegations against him before the press and the public.

Ranka claimed that the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) had "defrauded" 13 crore people by removing their names from electoral rolls and questioned why the BJP was "defending" Kumar over the allegations. "For 48 hours, the ball was in Kumar's court; now it is in CJP's court. We will start our nationwide protest on October 2, and we won't back down till he resigns. CJP is a platform which, if it gets involved in any matter, doesn't let go of it until we win," Ranka told reporters.

CPI(M) rejects ECI clarification, demands CEC's resignation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



The Communist Party of India (Marxist) has rejected the Election Commission of India's (ECI) recent clarification regarding the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, reiterating its demand for the immediate resignation or impeachment of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

In a statement issued by its Polit Bureau, the CPI(M) asserted that the ECI's statement on September 26 failed to address fundamental questions raised about the functioning of the poll panel and the integrity of the nationwide electoral roll revision.

The Left party cited recent investigative media reports revealing that two Election Commissioners had repeatedly raised formal objections regarding procedures for enrolling new voters, the deletion of names, the centralisation of the electoral database, and alleged illegal modifications to Form 6.

"The concerns raised by opposition parties and civil society organisations arose in a specific context—the enforced SIR process across the country. They have only been reinforced by disclosures from within the Commission itself," the Polit Bureau stated.

It added that the core issue remains whether the electoral process is being conducted transparently and in accordance with the law to prevent the wrongful exclusion of eligible voters.

Criticising the official response, the CPI(M) said the poll panel neither denied nor addressed these substantial issues, nor did it fix accountability for the hardships faced by citizens due to "whimsical and authoritarian acts".

CPI condemns alleged RSS attack on West Bengal rally

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



The Communist Party of India (CPI) on Monday strongly condemned an alleged attack by Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) activists on a massive protest organised by the party in West Bengal's Midnapore.

The demonstration, organised on the birth anniversary of Shaheed Bhagat Singh, was directed against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and the Suvendu Adhikari-led Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) Government in West Bengal.

In a statement issued from New Delhi, the National Secretariat of the CPI alleged that local administrative authorities initially attempted to derail the gathering by withholding permission for the rally. Despite the denial, party cadres and local residents assembled in large numbers outside the Midnapore Collectorate to voice their anger against political violence, communalism, and the alleged erosion of democratic rights in the State.

According to the party, violence erupted while CPI National Secretary Rama Krushna Panda was addressing the crowd. Supposed RSS workers allegedly attempted to disrupt the meeting and subsequently tried to physically assault CPI West Bengal State Secretary Swapan Banerjee as he rose to speak.

Unpaid dues leave MP village without power for 3 months

UMESH NIGAM
Bhopal



Nearly 70 households in Khajuri village, under Chhaigaon Makhan Janpad Panchayat in Khandwa district, have been without electricity for about three months after the village transformer failed and the power supply was disconnected over outstanding bills. The crisis has now extended to agricultural connections, leaving homes and fields without power.

Residents said the transformer stopped working around three months ago. According to them, the electricity company cited outstanding dues against consumers in the village and did not repair or replace the faulty transformer. Power supply was gradually stopped, leaving the entire village without electricity.

The prolonged outage has affected routine life and agricultural activities. Villagers said they celebrated Rakhi and the Ganesh festival in darkness and have been struggling to operate fans, lights, mobile phones, and other essential electrical appliances.

The situation worsened on Sunday when electricity supply to agricultural fields was also disconnected. Farmers said the move could affect irrigation and other farm-related activities at a time when electricity is essential for cultivation.

According to electricity company officials, Khajuri has around 70 electricity consumers, of whom only five families regularly pay their bills. Around 65 consumers have outstanding dues estimated at nearly Rs 9 lakh. The company has also said that around 40 to 50 families in the village are tribal households and that some consumers have accumulated dues of up to ₹40,000 each.

The company officials maintain that prolonged non-payment and the substantial outstanding amount led to the disconnection. Officials said some consumers have now started coming forward to deposit their dues following the shutdown and that restoration can be considered after the outstanding amount is recovered.

50 million Indian children still lack sanitation services in schools: WHO-UNICEF report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



Nearly a fifth of the children with no access to sanitation services in schools are in India, the highest for any country in the world, according to the WHO-UNICEF Joint Monitoring Programme (JMP) report.

India has 50 million of the world's 244 million children without sanitation services in schools in 2025, the report "Progress on Drinking Water, Sanitation and Hygiene in Schools 2015-2025" noted.

The report also added that India recorded a 14 per cent reduction in the number of schools without sanitation services during the period assessed.

The World Health Organisation (WHO) and the United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF)'s joint monitoring programme produces internationally comparable estimates of progress on drinking water, sanitation and hygiene (WASH) and monitors the Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) targets related to WASH.

The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development includes global goals for water and sanitation and for education. Goal 4 aims to ensure "inclusive and quality education for all and promote lifelong learning" and includes targets to build and upgrade education facilities that are child-, disability- and gender-sensitive and provide safe and effective learning environments for all.

This includes providing all schools with access to electricity, computers, the internet, adapted infrastructure and materials for students with disabilities, and basic WASH services.

Goal 6 aims to "ensure availability and sustainable management of water and sanitation for all" and includes targets for universal access to safe drinking water, sanitation and hygiene for all.

"In 2025, despite progress, 244 million children still had no sanitation service at their school," the report said.

India accounted for 50 million of them, Nigeria 34 million, Ethiopia 26 million, the Democratic Republic of the Congo 11 million and Indonesia 8 million, the report said.

For SDG monitoring, a basic drinking water service means schools have access to a functioning improved water source. A basic sanitation service means schools have improved, single-sex, usable sanitation facilities, and a basic hygiene service means schools have handwashing facilities with soap and water available at the time of the survey.

Hygiene remains another area of concern. Around 20 million Indian children had no hygiene service at schools. However, the JMP noted that insufficient recent data meant it could not generate hygiene coverage estimates for India and the Central and Southern Asia region beyond 2024.

"India performed comparatively better on school drinking-water access. In 2025, around 12 million Indian children lacked drinking-water services at school, accounting for roughly one in every 20 children globally without such services.

"India is among 28 of 62 countries considered on track to achieve universal basic drinking-water coverage in schools by 2030. Its basic drinking-water coverage increased by more than 4 per cent annually during the period assessed," it said.

The monitoring report noted that with just five years remaining until the end of the SDG period, the world is not on track to achieve universal access to basic WASH services in schools by 2030.

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | SEPTEMBER 29, 2026

PROSPECT

104th MES Day observed at Narangi Cantt



The 104th MES Day was celebrated with enthusiasm at HEADQUARTERS, Additional Director General North East Infrastructure (HQ ADG NEI), Narangi. Officers and staff of HQ ADG NEI, Chief Engineer (Air Force) Borjhar, GE (AF) Borjhar and GE (Projects) AF Digaru attended the event.

Prabhakar Mittal, IDSE, Additional Director General, North East Infrastructure, extended warm greetings to all officers, staff and their families on the occasion.

In his address, the ADG recalled the distinguished journey of the Military Engineer Services and appreciated the dedication and perseverance of its personnel in meeting the Armed Forces' infrastructure requirements under challenging conditions in the North East.

He highlighted that the Armed Forces' expectations of MES are continuously increasing and stressed the need for timely project completion, improved planning and execution, adoption of new technologies, and enhanced quality in both works and maintenance.

He emphasised standardisation of processes to improve efficiency and accountability, and called upon all personnel to discharge duties with the highest standards of integrity, professional ethics and devotion to duty.

On the occasion, Prabhakar Mittal presented commendation cards to deserving officers and staff in recognition of their devotion to duty.

He expressed confidence that with collective effort, MES will continue to uphold its proud legacy and meet future challenges. (*PNS*)

Assam Terriers organise veterans' rally in Silchar



An ex-servicemen rally under the 'Atoot Bandhan' initiative was organised by Assam Terriers at Silchar on 28 September, 2026 to strengthen the bond with veterans and address their welfare requirements.

The rally drew over 75 participants, including veer naris, ex-servicemen, and veterans from various arms and services.

Participants discussed welfare and pension-related issues concerning veterans and veer naris. Attendees interacted with representatives of the unit and were assisted on matters pertaining to pension, documentation, welfare schemes and entitlements. The event reaffirmed the Indian Army's commitment towards welfare of its veterans and families, upholding the ethos of 'Once a Soldier, Always a Soldier'. (*PNS*)

IRFC signs ₹4,200 crore loan agreement with DVC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Indian Railway Finance Corporation Limited (IRFC), a Navratna Central Public Sector Enterprise under the Ministry of Railways, has taken another significant step in its strategic expansion and diversification with the signing of an ₹4,200 crore term loan agreement with Damodar Valley Corporation (DVC) to finance its renewable energy projects across Jharkhand and West Bengal.

The transaction marks an important milestone in IRFC's evolving role as a diversified infrastructure financier, extending its established long-term financing capabilities to the clean energy ecosystem while remaining closely aligned with the broader railway ecosystem. The loan agreement was signed in New Delhi in the presence of senior officials of IRFC and DVC, led from DVC by Manish Kumar, Member (Finance), DVC, and Manoj Kumar Dubey, Chairman & Managing Director, IRFC.

The financing will support DVC's portfolio of floating solar, ground-mounted solar, rooftop solar and Battery Energy Storage System (BESS) projects, leveraging its existing land, reservoirs and transmission infrastructure.

IRFC CMD, Dubey, said, "Renewable energy is no longer peripheral to the Railways; it is at the core of Indian Railways' journey towards Net Zero Carbon Emissions by 2030. Through this ₹4,200 crore financing to DVC, IRFC is extending its long-term financing capability to the clean energy infrastructure that will power India's future. This is IRFC 2.0 in action — strategic diversification that remains firmly connected to the Railways ecosystem and to the nation's larger development priorities."



Chairman and Managing Director of IRFC Manoj Kumar Dubey

"This partnership with DVC demonstrates how IRFC can bring long-term capital to renewable energy infrastructure that supports the Railways' growing energy requirements while contributing to a greener, more sustainable and future-ready India," Dubey added.

The transaction thus extends IRFC's financing capabilities into clean energy infrastructure that complements its core railway financing mandate, while supporting the broader transition towards a sustainable energy ecosystem.

The DVC transaction marks another important step in IRFC's calibrated diversification into strategic railway-linked infrastructure sectors, building on its established strength in providing long-term financing.

IRFC's expanding financing portfolio includes sectors such as renewable energy, power, metro rail, logistics and other infrastructure with strong linkages to national development priorities.

The transaction demonstrates IRFC's ability to mobilise long-term capital for nationally important railway linked infrastructure, bringing together its core financing strengths with emerging requirements in clean energy and sustainable infrastructure.

KRIBHCO's 46th AGM held at New Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Krishak Bharati Cooperative Limited (KRIBHCO), one of India's premier fertiliser-producing farmers' cooperatives, reported a pre-tax profit of Rs 824.68 crore for the financial year 2025-26. The society declared a 20% dividend on the equity capital of its member cooperative societies for the year.

The annual accounts of the Society were approved during its 46th annual general body meeting, held on 25th September 2026, at the Ashok Hotel, New Delhi. The meeting was presided over by V Sudhakar Chowdary, Chairman of KRIBHCO, in the presence of the board of directors and attended by delegates from various member cooperatives across the country.

KRIBHCO achieved remarkable production figures in FY 2025-26, with Urea production at 21.34 lakh MT and Ammonia production at 12.39 lakh MT, achieving 97.26% and 99.36% capacity utilisation, respectively. Expanding its product offerings to cater to the diverse needs of farmers, KRIBHCO's portfolio includes not only Neem Coated Urea but also imported DAP, MAP, MOP,



Complex Fertilisers, Bio Fertilisers, Compost, Certified Seeds, Hybrid Seeds, SSP, Zinc Sulphate, Natural Potash, Mycorrhiza and Sea Weed Fortified Bio-stimulants. During the year, KRIBHCO sold 45.37 lakh MT of fertilisers (including Urea and P&K Fertilisers).

KRIBHCO Fertilizers Ltd (KFL), a wholly-owned subsidiary of KRIBHCO, also delivered strong performance with the production of 11.02 lakh MT of Urea and 6.68 lakh MT of Ammonia, achieving capacity utilization of 127.48% and 133.16%, respectively. KFL declared a dividend of ₹14.40 crore for the year.

SS Yadav, Managing Director of KRIBHCO, informed the gathering about the sustained high standards of production and operational efficiency maintained by KRIBHCO and its subsidiaries.

KRIBHCO's wholly-owned subsidiary, KRIBHCO Agri Business Limited (KABL) is contributing significantly. KABL achieved a turnover of ₹1919.35 crore in FY 2025-26, the growth was supported by a substantial expansion in domestic business, which contributed ₹1,436.81 crore, while export sales stood at ₹482.54 crore. Meanwhile, KRIBHCO Green Energy Private Limited (KGEPL), is constructing two plants in Hazira, Gujarat, and Nellore, Andhra Pradesh, expected to be operational in FY 2026-27.

As part of its commitment to rural development, KRIBHCO's social arm, Gramin Vikas Trust is continuing to build scalable, community-led models integrating livelihoods, environmental sustainability and improved quality of life for underserved communities.

Aligned with the Government of India's vision of "Sahakar Se Samriddhi," KRIBHCO is playing a pivotal role in promoting seed and export activities among cooperatives as lead promoter of Bharatiya Beej Sahakari Samiti Limited (BBSSL) and a joint promoter of National Cooperative Export Limited (NCEL) and Sahakar Taxi Cooperative Limited (Bharat Taxi) under the guidance of the Ministry of Cooperation.

In recognition of its outstanding performance, KRIBHCO received several awards from FAI, PRSI and other prestigious organisations.

During the AGM, KRIBHCO also honored two eminent cooperators for their remarkable contributions to the cooperative movement in India. Shankarbhai Chaudhary from Gujarat was conferred the KRIBHCO "Sahakarita Shiromani award", and Bhagwan Singh Yadav from Madhya Pradesh received the KRIBHCO Sahakarita Vibhushan award.

YEIDA approves key projects during 93rd board meeting



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Noida

The Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA) announced major infrastructure and policy decisions at its 93rd board meeting in Noida.

YEIDA reported a sharp rise in revenue, recording ₹4,222.37 crore till mid-September in FY 2026-27, a 182.35% increase over the same period last year. Revenue from industrial and mixed-land schemes alone stood at ₹2,420.7 crore, at 174.47% of the annual budget.

Total expenditure rose to ₹5,501.71 crore, including ₹4,344.34 crore for land acquisition and loan repayments. In a major policy move, the board approved the YEIDA Corpus Fund Investment Regulation 2026-27, which will ring-fence one-time lease rents and non-recurring receipts into a dedicated fund for long-term maintenance of roads, drainage, lighting and green belts.

To expand its industrial footprint under Master Plan 2041, YEIDA cleared the rollout of the Multi-Modal Logistics Park Policy-2024 through e-auctions. It also reviewed plans for an 8,000-hectare Industrial Node south of Noida International Airport and an International Trade City on the lines of Yiwu, China. On farmer welfare, YEIDA expedited 7% residential plot allotment to 10,069 landholders and released ₹3,142 crore as additional 64.7% compensation.



BJP leaders Arvind Menon, Bharati Praveen Pawar, Roop Kumari Chaudhary, Vijay Chauthaiwale, Aseervatham Achary, and others met with the Sri Lankan delegation, led by M Tilvin Silva, General Secretary, Janatha Vimukthi Peramuna (JVP), during their visit to BJP headquarters under the KNOW BJP initiative on Monday PIONEER PHOTO

IndusInd Bank MD and CEO says his name unmapped from electoral roll

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

IndusInd Bank MD & CEO Rajiv Anand has said his name has been "unmapped" from the electoral roll and he has been asked to appear for a hearing to avoid deletion from the voter list.

"I have been told my name is "unmapped" from the voting list. I have voted in every election ever since I have been eligible to vote. I hold a passport, PAN Card, voter ID card and Aadhar card. I am now being asked to appear for a hearing else my name will be deleted. Why should I?," Anand said in a X post on Sunday.

"Indians have so many certificates to prove who they are. Aadhar card. PAN Card. Voter ID. Passport. You would think there is an identity crisis!", he said in another post.

Amid the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, the Election Commission last week announced a slew of decisions for the ease of voters who have been issued notices, including doorstep collection of documents and extending deadlines in Delhi and Maharashtra.



IndusInd Bank MD & CEO Rajiv Anand

The period for filing claims and objections has been extended till October 30 for Delhi voters, while for Maharashtra it has been extended till October 12.

BSES holds industry workshop on BESS safety

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



As battery energy storage becomes an increasingly important part of India's clean-energy transition, BSES recently organised a three-day workshop on the Battery Energy Storage System (BESS) Safety Framework, bringing together power-sector leaders, global safety experts, utilities, fire and emergency services and industry professionals.

The workshop focused on a priority: ensuring battery storage scales up safely, responsibly, and with the right level of preparedness. Discussions covered safety-by-design, early warning and detection, thermal runaway, recognised testing, emergency preparedness, evacuation protocols and first-responder readiness.

The inaugural session was addressed by Ghanshyam Prasad (Chairperson, CEA); Amal Sinha (Director & Group CEO, BSES); Abhishek Ranjan (CEO, BRPL); Sunil Kumar Jha (Director General, FS, CD & HG); Santosh Kumar (COO, BYPL); Alok Kumar (Director General, AIDA); Asko Rajput (Chairman, Standards Committee, BIS); Tanya Singhal (Vice President & Country Head, GEAPP); and Dr Rashi Gupta (MD, Vision Mechatronics Pvt Ltd).

The workshop moved beyond discussions to practical preparedness. A major highlight was a live thermal runaway demonstration in a battery module, followed by firefighting intervention by Delhi Fire Service personnel. The exercise helped participants understand how battery failures can develop and the challenges emergency responders may face.

Global experts Richie Stephen (Senior Standards Project Manager, UL Standards & Engagement), Kurt Vollmacher (Director, Intotech & Fire Safety Trainer) and Dr Judy Jeevarajan (UL Standards & Engagement) shared insights on system testing, failure modes, manufacturing defects, battery ageing, fire safety and emergency response, drawing on experience.

The workshop concluded with nine multidisciplinary teams working through emergency scenarios involving smoke at a BESS site, flooding at an installation, and post-fire dismantling and waste management. The exercise helped participants identify priorities, responsibilities and the safest course of action.

The programme also drew on BSES' experience with its pioneering 20 MW/40 MWh Kilokri BESS, reinforcing the need to keep safety at the heart of storage growth.

DERC chairperson visits PPCL's PPS-III in Bawana

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

SCL Das, Chairperson, Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC), along with Ajay Kumar Jain, Member (Law), DERC, visited the 1,371.2 MW Pragati Power Station-III (PPS-III), Bawana.

The visit was undertaken to review the operations of the largest-capacity power generation plant in northern India and Delhi, which plays a vital role in meeting the uninterrupted power supply requirements of Delhi consumers. PPS-III also serves as a load-centre generating station and forms an important part of the islanding scheme.



The dignitaries were warmly welcomed by Amit Ahuja, Director (Technical), along with RB Meena, executive director (Technical), PPS-III, and RK Yadav, general manager (Commercial). During the visit, the dignitaries toured the PPS-III plant site and were briefed on the power station's operations and functioning.

Delhi Minorities Commission pays tribute to Bhagat Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

A floral tribute and commemorative programme was organised at the office of the Delhi Minorities Commission on the birth anniversary of Shaheed-e-Azam Bhagat Singh. Delhi Minorities Commission Chairman Nirmal Jain, along with Members Kuldeep Singh and Mohammad Haroon, was prominently present on the occasion.

Several social workers, teachers and representatives from different communities, including Jagdeep Singh Kohli, Vivek Singh Mata, Balwinder Singh, Charanjit Singh Rajput, Manpreet Singh Hanspal, Jaspreet Singh Mata, Harpreet Singh Kalra, Narendra Singh, Darshan Singh, Faiz Khan, Goldy Randhawa and Darshan Pal Singh, among others, also attended the programme. The dignitaries and participants paid floral tributes to Shaheed Bhagat Singh and remembered his supreme sacrifice for the nation.

Addressing the gathering, Delhi Minorities Commission Chairman Nirmal Jain said that Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta had recently paid floral tributes at the statue of Shaheed Bhagat Singh, and inspired by the occasion, the Delhi Minorities Commission also organised the tribute programme.



Commission Member Sardar Kuldeep Singh said that Sardar Bhagat Singh played a significant role in awakening the spirit of freedom and patriotism among the people of the country. He highlighted various aspects of Bhagat Singh's life and elaborated on his contribution, sacrifice and commitment to the nation.

Commission Member Mohammad Haroon said this was the first programme organised by the Delhi Minorities Commission after its constitution, and that it was an honour to dedicate the Commission's first programme to the memory of Shaheed Bhagat Singh.

The programme concluded with a solemn tribute to Shaheed Bhagat Singh and a remembrance of his immense contribution and sacrifice. The participants said that it is the collective responsibility of society to preserve the memory of those brave sons who sacrificed their lives for the country's freedom and to pass their ideals on to future generations.

Editor's TAKE

It's a matter of the heart: Don't miss a beat!

India's demographic dividend is only as strong as its arteries. On World Heart Day, the pledge is simple: don't miss a beat, and don't let the country miss one either

Every September 29, World Heart Day asks the world to listen to the one organ we notice only when it falters. Founded in 2000 by the World Heart Federation with the WHO, the day endures because its message never ages: cardiovascular disease is the planet's leading killer, claiming nearly 20 million lives a year. More than four in five of those deaths are heart attacks and strokes, and a third strike people younger than 70. This year's campaign, "Don't Miss a Beat", targets the disease's cruellest feature: it often gives no warning until it is too late.

How did an ailment of old age become an epidemic of the prime of life? Because modern living has industrialised every risk factor. Ultra-processed food, salt, sugar and trans fats have displaced home cooking. Desks have replaced fields. Tobacco persists, air pollution chokes our cities, and sleeplessness is worn as a badge of ambition.

Cardiovascular disease caused 26.6 per cent of all Indian deaths in 2017, up from 15 per cent in 1990. Heart attacks in the thirties and forties, among breadwinners, are at their peak. Kerala, Punjab and Tamil Nadu rank among the top. An estimated 315 million Indians live with hypertension, yet only about 28 per cent know it, and barely one in eight has it under control. Another 136 million have prediabetes. The epidemic is not concealed. We simply are not looking.

The way out is neither exotic nor expensive. First, detect early. Blood pressure, sugar and cholesterol checks must become as routine as a mobile recharge, available at every health and wellness centre. Second, treat cheaply and continuously.

The India Hypertension Control Initiative proves it works: across nine districts, blood pressure control rose from 37 to 48 per cent between 2018-19 and 2023-24, while patients' out-of-pocket medicine spending fell from 47 to 9 per cent. That model belongs in every district.

As a nation, we have to make choices, healthy choices, that can make India fit again. No doubt yoga can be a great way to get healthy, but it must be accompanied by lifestyle choices, eating right, sleeping right and keeping three culprits, hurry, worry and curry, in check. Then there are so many things in the market that are enough to make us unhealthy. Salt and trans-fat limits, tobacco, alcohol and plenty of processed food need to be curtailed. Besides, cleaner air and daily walks can make all the difference. Moreover, it is very important to prepare for emergencies before they happen. Chest pressure, breathlessness and pain spreading to the jaw or arm demand a hospital, not a home remedy, and CPR should be taught in every school and office. World Heart Day is a reminder that the heart is more than an organ that keeps us alive, it is at the centre of our physical well-being, working silently every moment.

Azerbaijan: The art of being everyone's exception

Baku does not balance between friends and enemies. It balances between the interests of its friends, its neighbours and its own survival. In an age increasingly obsessed with blocs, Azerbaijan offers a rather different lesson. The strongest position for a small state may not be choosing a side. It may be making every side need a relationship with you



BHOPINDER SINGH



Azerbaijan is one of those countries that makes conventional geopolitics look strangely inadequate. Here is a predominantly Shia country that is deeply secular, culturally Turkic and strategically close to Israel. It is bound to Turkey by an almost fraternal alliance, maintains a strategic partnership with Pakistan, is deepening ties with China, and yet remains obliged by geography to keep talking to Iran, its fellow Shia neighbour.

On paper, it is a collection of contradictions. In practice, it is a remarkably coherent strategy. Baku has mastered the art of being close without being captive. Azerbaijan does not appear to organise its foreign policy around ideological camps. It organises it around interests. Religion does not dictate its diplomacy. Neither does geography. Neither does friendship.

That is why Israel and Turkey can coexist comfortably in Baku's foreign-policy architecture. Turkey provides strategic depth and an intimate political relationship. Israel provides defence, intelligence, technology and energy cooperation. Pakistan provides political solidarity and a useful partnership in the Muslim world. China offers capital, connectivity and another great-power relationship. Iran, meanwhile, is the unavoidable neighbour whose hostility can never be allowed to become a permanent rupture.

The remarkable thing is not that Azerbaijan has all these relationships. It is that it has managed to keep them from cancelling one another out. This is strategic ambiguity, but not ambiguity in the sense of not knowing where one stands. Baku is remarkably clear about its interests. The ambiguity lies in refusing to let those interests be reduced to membership in a single geopolitical camp. And that distinction matters.

Azerbaijan can be Israel's strategic partner without becoming Israel's proxy. It can be Turkey's closest ally without becoming merely an extension of Ankara. It can cultivate Pakistan without adopting Pakistan's worldview wholesale. It can deepen relations with China without joining a Chinese bloc. And it can quarrel with Iran while still recognising that Iran will remain next door tomorrow, next year and for decades to come. That is the essence of strategic balance among the unnatural and the unthinkable.

The relationship with Iran is perhaps the most revealing. Shared Shia identity has done remarkably little to eliminate geopolitical suspicion. Iran has long been uneasy about Baku's relations with Israel and Turkey, while Azerbaijan has had its own grievances with Tehran. Yet the two sides have repeatedly tried to restore practical cooperation when their interests converge.

> BAKU'S RELATIONSHIP WITH PAKISTAN IS EQUALLY INSTRUCTIVE AND PARTICULARLY UNCOMFORTABLE FOR INDIA. AZERBAIJAN AND PAKISTAN CALL THEIR RELATIONSHIP A STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIP AND HAVE STEADILY EXPANDED COOPERATION IN DEFENCE, ENERGY, TRANSPORT AND DIPLOMACY

Baku's relationship with Pakistan is equally instructive and particularly uncomfortable for India. Azerbaijan and Pakistan call their relationship a strategic partnership and have steadily expanded cooperation in defence, energy, transport and diplomacy. On Kashmir, Baku has consistently backed a settlement based on international law and relevant UN Security Council resolutions. During the India-Pakistan crisis of May 2025, Azerbaijan went further, expressing solidarity with Pakistan after Indian strikes. Yet this has not stopped Azerbaijan from maintaining economic links with India.

Again, there is no contradiction if one understands the Azerbaijani method. A country can separate strategic relationships from individual disputes. The 2026 Iran war provided the ultimate test of this formula and punctured one popular misconception. Azerbaijan was not simply "neutral", nor was it immune from the conflict. On March 5, Iranian drones struck Azerbaijan's Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic, damaging an airport terminal and injuring civilians. Baku formally protested and demanded an explanation from Tehran.

Yet Azerbaijan simultaneously avoided allowing the confrontation to turn into a wider war. Analysts at Israel's Institute for National Security Studies have described Baku's posture as "alignment tempered by restraint" rather than neutrality, strategically close to Israel and the West, but careful to preserve working relations with Tehran and avoid being dragged into the conflict. That may be the clearest description of Azerbaijan's foreign policy. Aligned, but not subordinate. Friendly, but not ideological. Pragmatic, but not neutral.

This is why Azerbaijan is so fascinating. Its real strategic asset is not oil, geography or even its military, important though all three are. It is optionality.

Baku has constructed a foreign policy in which several competing powers have reasons to value Azerbaijan simultaneously. Turkey needs it. Israel values it. Pakistan embraces it. China is investing in its connectivity. Iran cannot ignore it. And Russia, Europe and the United States all have interests in the South Caucasus that intersect with Baku. For a country of Azerbaijan's size, that is an extraordinary position. It has not achieved it by choosing the perfect ally. It has achieved it by ensuring that no single ally ever becomes indispensable enough to dictate the whole of Azerbaijani foreign policy.

That is the Azerbaijani paradox and perhaps its strategic genius. Baku does not balance between friends and enemies. It balances between the interests of its friends, its neighbours and its own survival. In an age increasingly obsessed with blocs, Azerbaijan offers a rather different lesson. The strongest position for a small state may not be choosing a side. It may be making every side need a relationship with you.

The writer is a former Lieutenant Governor of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Puducherry, and a military veteran

Daiv Vani

WISDOM FOR A MEANINGFUL LIFE

The King Who Became a Sage

Some transformations are not sudden revelations, but the slow result of an entire lifetime spent in struggle.

Vishwamitra was born a king, accustomed to power, command, and the easy deference of an entire army, until an encounter with the sage Vasishtha, whose simple hermitage possessed a wish-fulfilling cow far more valuable than his own considerable military might, humbled him more deeply than any battle ever had. Determined to attain such spiritual power himself, he renounced his throne entirely and undertook centuries of relentless penance, facing repeated setbacks and humiliating failures along the way, including being seduced by the celestial Menaka and losing years of hard-won progress in a single unguarded moment of weakness.

Rather than giving up in shame, he simply began again, and then again, eventually earning the exceedingly rare title of Brahmarishi, a sage born a warrior, but elevated purely through sustained discipline rather than birth or lineage.

His path was never one of smooth, uninterrupted mastery, but rather repeated failure met each time with renewed effort, proving convincingly that persistence mattered far more in the end than an unbroken record of success.

We often abandon our own self-improvement after a single setback or embarrassing failure, quietly believing that failure has permanently disqualified us from ever truly succeeding at it.

Today, return to one goal you abandoned after a setback, and begin again, without treating that earlier failure as the final word on what you are capable of.

–DAIV

PIC TALK



People perform 'Tarpan' ritual at Assi Ghat on the second day of 'Pitra Paksha', in Varanasi, Uttar Pradesh. PHOTO: PTI

The wisdom of leaving space



SIDDHARTH ROY

2ND OPINION

A civil engineer is trained to calculate how much a structure can carry. But engineering also asks a less celebrated question: how much should remain unbuilt? A river needs a floodplain. A bridge needs expansion joints. A road needs setbacks. A city needs open ground. What appears empty on an engineering drawing may be the space that prevents failure.

This principle has implications beyond engineering. It should influence how governments make decisions about land, infrastructure and urban growth. Yet public policy often rewards visible construction while treating unoccupied space as an opportunity lost. The pressure to build is understandable. But when every space is consumed, efficiency can quietly turn into vulnerability.

Consider floodplains.

A river does not recognise a zoning map when heavy rainfall arrives. Its floodplain is part of its natural drainage system, providing temporary storage when water levels rise. Allowing extensive construction in such areas may generate short-term economic value while transferring the eventual cost to taxpayers, insurers and residents.

A policy that protects floodplains may appear restrictive in the present while preventing far greater losses in the future. The same logic applies to wetlands, urban ponds and drainage corridors.

They can look economically unproductive because their value is not always captured in a land-price calculation. Yet they store water, recharge groundwater, moderate heat and support ecosystems. The policy question is not simply, "How much revenue can this land generate?" It is also, "What public function will disappear if this land is built over?"

Engineering offers another useful analogy.

Materials expand and contract with temperature. Structures move under changing loads. Expansion joints deliberately provide room for that movement. Without such allowances, stresses accumulate until something cracks.

Infrastructure policy requires margins. Roads, drainage networks, electricity systems and hospitals cannot be designed only around average demand. They need capacity for rainfall, traffic surges, heatwaves, power failures and shocks. Building precisely to today's demand may seem efficient, but leaving no reserve capacity can make tomorrow's emergency much more expensive.

This is where policy must resist the seduction of short-term arithmetic. The cheapest project today is not necessarily the least expensive choice over its lifetime. Preventive spending, protected open spaces and unused capacity can be difficult to justify because their successes are often invisible: the flood that did not become a disaster, the road that did not collapse into congestion, the hospital that could accommodate a sudden surge.

Leaving space also raises a question of intergenerational responsibility. Once a wetland is filled or a public ground disappears beneath concrete, restoring it may be impossible. Today's planning decisions therefore consume land and the options available to tomorrow's citizens.

The wisdom of leaving space is ultimately a philosophy of restraint. It does not oppose development. It asks development to recognise limits, uncertainty and public risk. A river needs room to overflow.

A structure needs room to move. Infrastructure needs spare capacity. Perhaps good policy, like good engineering, is not about using every space. It is about knowing which spaces society cannot afford to lose.

The writer is a consultant to Rashtriya Raksha, a civil engineer, short story writer, columnist, public policy expert and contemporary affairs commentator

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Youth deserve to be heard

Whether the ruling party likes it or not, the youth are deeply concerned about their future. Given concerns over education, healthcare and employment, along with corruption and the growing influence of criminals and the affluent in governance, many young people have little reason to feel secure about what lies ahead.

It is natural for citizens to seek changes that could lead to a better future. Denying people the right to voice their concerns and protest against government policies can further deepen their dissatisfaction. Suppression, threats or intimidation may only strengthen their determination to raise their concerns. The government would be better served by engaging with young people through dialogue and addressing their demands with the seriousness and priority they deserve. Constructive engagement can help build trust and provide a democratic avenue for resolving grievances.

After all, young people are citizens of the country and deserve to be heard. Their concerns about education, healthcare, employment and governance should receive meaningful attention. A responsive administration must ensure that democratic participation remains open and that citizens can express their views peacefully and without fear.

AG RAJMOHAN | ANDHRA PRADESH

King Kohli rewrites ODI history

There are innings that win matches, and then there are innings that remind the world why a cricketer has become an era-defining figure. Virat Kohli's magnificent 139 not out, featuring 10 fours and nine sixes in the first ODI against the West Indies, belonged firmly to the latter category.

Kohli's performance was more than another entry in an extraordinary record book. It was a statement from a batter whose appetite for runs remains undiminished. During the innings, he extended his record of ODI centuries to 55, became the fastest batter to reach 15,000 ODI runs and moved ahead of Sachin Tendulkar for the most ODI runs on home soil. He also surpassed Mohammad Azharuddin's record for the most ODIs played by an Indian against the West Indies, making his 44th appearance against them.

Yet statistics tell only part of the Kohli story. His defining quality has always been his ability to approach every innings with the urgency of a newcomer and the confidence of a champion. He refuses to live on past achievements. Every innings becomes another challenge, another opportunity to prove himself. For millions of Indian cricket fans, watching Kohli walk to the crease remains an event in itself. His intensity and ambition continue to create lasting memories.

AP THIRUVADI | CHENNAI

Diplomacy must follow strong words

With reference to "Jaishankar's rebuke: Necessary message" (September 28), the significance of the External Affairs Minister's UN statement will depend on what India does after the applause has faded. His remarks came after Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif raised Kashmir and the 2025 conflict at the General Assembly. India responded by reiterating that terrorism cannot be normalised and that it retains the right to defend itself.

The next step should be a diplomatic campaign explaining India's position to governments. It should include verifiable evidence, briefings and closer cooperation on intelligence and terrorist financing. Equally important is maintaining communication mechanisms that reduce the risk of escalation. India and Pakistan remain neighbours, and any prolonged crisis can have consequences beyond their borders. India should pursue a calibrated policy: oppose terrorism firmly, respond when necessary, but keep diplomatic avenues available for de-escalation. The United States, Gulf countries, European nations and influential partners should be engaged through diplomacy. The international community should be encouraged to judge competing claims on evidence. A statement can set the tone; coherent policy and diplomacy must carry it forward.

BA NEBOBA | TAMIL NADU

The Pioneer
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Sri Lanka's dilemma: Can the system change without being overthrown?

The test now for Sri Lanka is whether political change can move beyond changing rulers. Uyangoda sees a struggle between an old ruling class and a new political force, almost "like a class war". A system designed to protect established power may resist transformation through the very institutions that give it legitimacy



NILANTHA ILANGAMUWA



Sri Lanka's most dangerous political question is no longer whether democracy should survive. It is whether democracy can survive being used to dismantle the political order that has lived comfortably inside it. Recently, I sat down with Professor Jayadeva Uyangoda and found myself returning to that question. He entered politics believing revolution could remake society, joined Rohana Wijeweera's underground movement, survived 1971, spent six years in Welikada prison, and emerged not as a liberal convert but as something more troublesome: a Marxist who believes liberal democracy is indispensable, yet fundamentally insufficient.

"I was never converted to liberal democracy," he told me. He retained his suspicion of capitalism and concentrated power while discovering, through defeat, imprisonment, reading and reflection, that freedom cannot be postponed until after revolution. "Liberal democracy is indispensable for political and social progress. But it is inadequate." In that contradiction lies the central argument of his political life.

Uyangoda's critique begins where conventional celebrations of democracy end. Sri Lanka has elections, universal franchise, constitutional rights and competing parties. Yet democracy has repeatedly operated alongside concentrations of wealth, political power, family influence, bureaucratic authority and ethnic privilege. His objection is therefore not to democracy but to democracy emptied of substance. "People, demos, are the true owners of democracy. And democracy had been captured by the elites." That is a brutal formulation in a country where the establishment presents itself as democracy's guardian. Parliament can function while citizens remain powerless; elections can occur while the same networks recycle power; constitutionalism can survive while inequality determines who can actually exercise freedom. His argument also goes beyond the familiar Marxist complaint about class. Liberal political theory, he argues, has treated society as an aggregation of autonomous individuals while neglecting communities, cultures and historically disadvantaged groups. For Sri Lanka, that omission is not theoretical. "Actually, liberal political theory doesn't have a theory of the state. It has only theories of government and regimes." Changing governments, in other words, is not necessarily changing the state.

His transformation began in prison. "The Welikada prison was my second university after Peradeniya." He read Marxism, literature, philosophy, political theory, novels, the Bible and prison literature; he sat law examinations and wrote poetry. Marxism gave him a language for class, production, exploitation and material suffering.

Prison exposed him to loneliness, emotional pain, guilt, loss and the interior life of people trapped inside an institution designed to deprive them of freedom. "I saw in others and experienced myself the emotional suffering while living in a prison for long years." A political philosophy that cannot adequately account for the inner life of human beings cannot explain human emancipation completely. That is why his later politics combines individual freedom, social equality, pluralism and collective rights.

His most provocative lesson from revolutionary experience is harder to dismiss. "I learned that violent revolution can overthrow capitalism. But it cannot replace it with a humane society." Uyangoda's prison education forced him to ask the more frightening question: what happens after victory? The Russian, Chinese, Cuban and Korean experiences showed that overthrowing exploitation does not automatically abolish domination.

A revolution can destroy one prison and build another. This is where his present interest in the National People's Power becomes politically explosive. A movement once committed to overthrowing the state is now attempting to govern through elections, Parliament, courts and the constitutional framework. "They are working within the very system they want to change," he said. "That's why I am waiting and watching this process with great curiosity and deep concern." He is watching whether an inherited state can be transformed from within without reproducing the habits of the old order. That is where the real political gamble now begins.

THE ETHNIC QUESTION MAKES THE EXPERIMENT HARDER. UYANGODA HAS SPENT DECADES ARGUING THAT SRI LANKA'S CRISIS CANNOT BE RESOLVED BY CHANGING GOVERNMENTS WHILE LEAVING POLITICAL POWER UNTOUCHED

The ethnic question makes the experiment harder. Uyangoda has spent decades arguing that Sri Lanka's crisis cannot be resolved by changing governments while leaving political power untouched. "Reforming the post-colonial ethnocratic state was the central task and challenge in all our conflict resolution efforts." He rejects Sinhala Buddhist ownership of the state and insists that equal citizenship must mean more than formal equality. Tamils, Muslims, Malaiyaha Tamils and other communities must have genuine access to power.

Yet he is sceptical of inherited vocabularies. Federalism, self-determination and old constitutional arguments have become so politically poisoned that repeating them can reproduce the divisions they were meant to solve. His preferred language is democratic pluralism: a republic in which identities remain real without becoming permanent political enemies. "Differences should not lead us to divisions. Rather, they should bring all of us together as citizens in a Democratic Republic with diverse identities, not keeping us apart as enemies."

His treatment of violence is equally unsentimental. Uyangoda refuses to romanticise either side of Sri Lanka's conflict. He speaks of Tamil civilians suffering violence from the state and from Tamil militant organisations, just as he has never denied the brutality of the revolutionary movement with which he was once associated.

His proposal for reconciliation is "strategic forgetting": not erasing history, but refusing to allow unresolved memories to dictate every political relationship in the present. Can a society permanently organised around its wounds ever become politically reconciled? He does not ask people to deny what happened. He asks whether memory itself can become a political prison.

This is why his reading of the Aragalaya and the current political moment matters, even where one may disagree with his interpretation. He sees the uprising not as a fashionable youth revolt but as a social movement exposing a rupture between citizens and the old political class. "The challenge today is to re-democratise Sri Lanka's democracy." Sri Lankans did not revolt because they had lost faith in democracy; they revolted because the democracy they inherited had become remote from ordinary citizens.

The test now is whether political change can move beyond changing rulers. Uyangoda sees a struggle between an old ruling class and a new political force, almost "like a class war". But his warning is difficult to ignore: a system designed to protect established power may resist transformation through the very institutions that give it legitimacy. Asked what he would tell his younger self, the man who entered revolutionary politics believing history could be remade through struggle, he answered: "Never abandon political hope for a better society and a better political system. And always be an idealist."

After revolution, defeat, prison, Marxism, liberalism, ethnic conflict and decades of scholarship, he has arrived not at certainty but at an insistence that political imagination must survive disappointment. For Sri Lanka, that is not a comforting message. It is a challenge to everyone who believes changing governments is the same thing as changing the country.

The writer is a columnist based in Colombo

From incredible India to intelligent India



ADITI RAWAT | KRISHNA GIRI

For more than two decades, Incredible India has told the world what this country offers — civilisations, landscapes, spirituality, cuisine and cultural diversity. The next phase requires a different proposition, one that goes beyond putting an AI chatbot into a booking engine. This year's World Tourism Day theme, "Digital Agenda and Artificial Intelligence to Redesign Tourism", invites a more consequential question: can technology make journeys more meaningful, destinations safer and better managed, and tourism's economic gains more widely shared?

AI's most immediate contribution is hyper-personalisation. Industry has traditionally segmented travellers and designed products around broad categories; AI can move closer to the individual, building around a person's interests, budget, diet, mobility and pace, and revising the plan mid-trip.

A visitor could say, in her own language, that she has four days in Tamil Nadu, is exploring Chola history, prefers vegetarian food and wishes to avoid crowds. An intelligent system could weigh those preferences against weather, transport and live conditions to build the journey. Done well, such personalisation can deepen the experience. On a recent visit to Japan, one of the authors used AI to curate a day around a seafarer family member. Personalisation, in this form, makes travel more meaningful rather than merely more convenient. The gain is equally significant for tour operators. AI can help them research unfamiliar circuits, rework routes when conditions change and curate experiences around individual preferences rather than sell one itinerary to everybody. The quality of the output, however, still depends on human judgement deciding what the technology should optimise for. Destination management is another area where AI could have significant impact. In Tirupati in January 2025, six devotees died and around forty were injured in a crush while waiting for Vaikunta Dwara darshan tokens. The episode illustrates the limits of digitisation: a system may know how many tokens it has issued without recognising that thousands of people are converging on one point faster than the space can safely absorb them. Research shows that crowd density and movement patterns can provide measurable warning signs. Studies of the 2006 Mina disaster and dense crowds suggest that such signals could support early detection of dangerous conditions. Maha Kumbh 2025 demonstrated India's ability to deploy AI-enabled cameras and command systems. The next step is predictive decision-making, using risk triggers to manage inflows, open alternative routes and position medical teams. Even a few minutes of warning could improve prevention and response, particularly in fragile Himalayan destinations.



Access itself can be managed more intelligently. What a destination can safely absorb changes with season, weather and emergency preparedness. Venice's day-tripper fee raised more than □5 million in 2025, yet visitor pressure remained high. Pricing can raise resources, but intelligent systems can do more to regulate flows through timed entry, seasonal quotas and, where justified, restrictions on repeat visits to the most fragile circuits. The economic opportunity may be greatest for small tourism establishments, which dominate tourism in many developing economies. Large hotel groups can employ specialists in pricing, analytics, multilingual marketing and demand forecasting. A five-room homestay, village guide or family-run restaurant generally cannot. AI can narrow this capability gap by turning heterogeneous information on booking patterns, reviews, seasonality and traveller preferences into usable business intelligence. It can also help them develop websites, translate listings, create marketing material, etc.

This can also address longstanding information asymmetries. Travellers often lack reliable information about smaller operators and emerging destinations, while those businesses know little about consumer demand and preferences. Reducing this asymmetry can allow them to compete more on the quality and distinctiveness of their experience than on the scale of operations. India cannot import global AI systems and assume they understand its tourism ecosystem. Models trained mainly on Western languages, destinations and traveller behaviour under-represent Indian languages, cultural practice and lesser-known places. An algorithm that knows Delhi but barely recognises Ziro is not merely imperfect; at scale, such systems decide which destinations and businesses are visible at all. Localisation, reliable local data and transparency about why one route is recommended over another are therefore not optional.

Safeguards matter equally. Tourism systems handle sensitive information about identity, location, spending and preferences. The Digital Personal Data Protection Act and the rules notified in November 2025 provide a general framework, but tourism will need clearer practices around consent, data sharing and retention across hotels, platforms, transport providers and public authorities. Access to intelligence itself must also not become another source of inequality. Rural operators who stand to gain most may have weaker connectivity, fewer digital skills and less capacity to pay. Multilingual voice interfaces, assisted adoption and shared digital infrastructure will therefore be essential.

None of this diminishes the importance of human hospitality. Tour operators who use these tools well will spend less time assembling routine itineraries and more time exercising judgement, curating experiences and solving problems. AI can translate a menu, optimise a route or analyse thousands of reviews, but it cannot replicate the host who explains a family recipe, the guide who brings history alive or the unexpected conversation that becomes the memory of a journey. Intelligent India should mean artificial and human intelligence used together, removing friction and spreading opportunity, while leaving more room for what makes travel worthwhile: people, places, culture and pleasure. Incredible India sent a powerful invitation to the world. Intelligent India should determine what happens once it is accepted.

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World Heart Day: Why every Indian must pay attention to blood pressure



DORAIRAJ PRABHAKARAN

Hypertension's cruelty is that it asks nothing of you until it takes everything. Most people feel no pain or symptoms, though a small minority get warning signs like headaches or dizziness. For years, it slowly damages the heart, brain and kidneys, then, without warning, speaks all at once with a stroke, a heart attack, or failed kidneys. A parent driving to work may struggle to speak, walk, or recognise loved ones. Survivors call stroke worse than death; families ask too late how this happened when all seemed normal.

Often, the answer is a number no one thought to check: blood pressure. High blood pressure is quietly at work for years before it declares itself. This World Heart Day, observed under the theme "Don't Miss a Beat", the most important beat may be the pressure pulsing, unnoticed, through our arteries.

Cardiovascular disease is the world's leading killer, claiming nearly 20 million lives a year, and in India it strikes earlier: heart attacks and strokes are increasingly common among adults in their forties and fifties, with uncontrolled blood pressure driving many premature deaths. The WHO estimates 1.4 billion adults aged 30-79 live with hypertension; only 1 in 5 have it controlled. India's numbers are more sobering: the ICMR-INDIAB study estimated 315 million Indian adults have hypertension, and a survey found fewer than three in ten were aware of it, one in seven were on treatment, and just one in eight had it controlled. Hypertension is a key modifiable driver of India's cardiovascular epidemic, raising the risk of heart attack, stroke and kidney disease.



The consequences ripple far beyond the patient. Stroke is now India's fourth leading cause of death and fifth leading cause of disability, leaving many survivors unable to walk, speak or work independently. Families bear the brunt: incomes vanish, caregiving shifts, and parents postpone children's education or weddings. A survey found nearly three in ten households seeking stroke treatment in public hospitals face catastrophic expenditure, while more than a third resort to distress financing, selling assets or taking on debt. Hypertension prevention thus protects household stability and dignity, not just health.

There is real progress to build on. The India Hypertension Control Initiative by the ICMR, the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, and global partners including the WHO and Resolve to Save Lives showed what is possible. Blood pressure control in public facilities increased from 37 to 48 per cent between 2018 and 2024, while out-of-pocket medicine costs fell from 47 to 9 per cent. This proves that simple, well-run systems with reliable drug supplies, standard treatment protocols and follow-up care can result in favourable outcomes. Extending this further, the ICMR's STAR NCD programme is evaluating system-level interventions for ambulatory care, particularly to improve the care cascade for hypertension and diabetes.

Hypertension is predictable and largely preventable, and small, consistent choices can make a measurable difference. Indians consume 8 to 11 grams of salt a day, nearly double the WHO's recommended limit of under 5 grams; reducing intake by reducing total salt consumption, or by using low-sodium, potassium-enriched substitutes, can be highly effective. A large Chinese trial followed nearly 21,000 people for five years and found such a substitute reduced strokes by 14 per cent, major cardiovascular events by 13 per cent and deaths by 12 per cent. Diets rich in fruits and vegetables, regular activity, managing weight, and limiting alcohol and tobacco all help in controlling high blood pressure. Routine check-ups, even when well, can catch the condition before a catastrophic emergency. Therefore, every adult should measure BP around age 20 and every five years thereafter if normal. Those with prehypertension (BP 120/80 to 140/90) should check annually, and those diagnosed should stay compliant with prescribed medication and follow a healthy lifestyle.

Hypertension prevention does not demand reinvention, only consistency. These modest choices compound into a lower risk of heart attacks and strokes that can upend not just one life, but an entire family's future. This World Heart Day, the message is clear: do not wait for symptoms that may never come. Know your numbers, get checked, and encourage your family to do the same. High blood pressure may be silent, but our response must not be, and the time to act is today.

The writer is the Executive Director, Centre for Chronic Disease Control

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NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | SEPTEMBER 29, 2026

SC to review plea against Sohrabuddin encounter acquittals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



The Supreme Court on Monday agreed to examine a plea against the Bombay High Court order that upheld the acquittal of all 22 accused in the alleged fake encounter killings of gangster Sohrabuddin Shaikh, his wife Kausar Bi and aide Tulsiram Prajapati in 2005, while voicing concern that 92 witnesses had turned hostile.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana issued notice on the plea filed by Nayabuddin Shaikh, brother of Sohrabuddin Shaikh, challenging the May 7 judgment of the High Court that acquitted 21 police personnel from Rajasthan and Gujarat and a farmhouse owner.

The bench indicated it would examine selected witness statements relevant to the acquittal.

"We would like to see statements of some witnesses. We are not summoning the record. You give us whatever three-four statements you feel are vital. We will examine acquittal," CJI said.

Justice Bagchi observed that the fact that 92 prosecution witnesses had turned hostile was a matter requiring consideration, particularly in assessing whether the trial had been fair and just. "Ninety-two witnesses turning hostile is a concern. Whether there was a fair and just trial... that's to be considered," Justice Bagchi said. The High Court had dismissed appeals filed by Rubabuddin and Nayabuddin Shaikh against the December 2018 judgment of a special CBI court in Mumbai, which had acquitted all 22 accused.

The CBI had investigated the case after the probe was transferred to it by the Supreme Court.

Of the 22 accused acquitted in the case, 21 were police officers from Gujarat and Rajasthan. The remaining accused was the owner of a farmhouse in Gujarat where, according to the prosecution case, Sohrabuddin and Kausar Bi were illegally detained.

According to the prosecution case, Sohrabuddin, his wife and Prajapati were travelling by bus from Hyderabad to Sangli in Maharashtra when they were allegedly taken into custody by a police team on the night of November 22-23, 2005.

The couple and Prajapati were allegedly taken in separate vehicles. According to the CBI, Sohrabuddin was killed on November 26, 2005, near Ahmedabad in an encounter involving Gujarat and Rajasthan police personnel. Kausar Bi was allegedly killed three days later. Prajapati, who was lodged in Udaipur Central Jail and was considered a key witness to the alleged encounter, was killed in a police encounter near the Gujarat-Rajasthan border on December 27, 2006.

In its judgment, the High Court had held that there was no ground to interfere with the trial court's acquittal.

It observed that the prosecution case was based largely on circumstantial evidence and that several links in the alleged chain of circumstances were missing.

The High Court had also held that the prosecution failed to establish that Sohrabuddin Shaikh and Kausar Bi were abducted by Gujarat and Rajasthan police personnel or that there was a motive to stage a fake encounter.

It further rejected the contention that the trial was not conducted properly merely because 92 prosecution witnesses had turned hostile.

The special CBI court, while acquitting the accused in December 2018, had held that the prosecution failed to establish a cogent case of a conspiracy to kill Sohrabuddin, Kausar Bi and Prajapati or establish the involvement of the accused in such a conspiracy.

Order Order

HC to hear Abhishek Banerjee's petition on his security cover



The Calcutta High Court will on October 6 hear a petition by Mamata Banerjee's TMC faction leader Abhishek Banerjee over the "sudden withdrawal" of his Z-plus security cover following the West Bengal assembly election results in May. The Diamond Harbour MP's lawyer moved the court of Justice Krishna Rao on Monday, seeking urgent hearing of his petition. Justice Krishna Rao said the plea will be taken up for hearing on October 6, and directed the petitioner to serve notice upon the parties in the meantime. Abhishek Banerjee's lawyer Ayan Bhattacharjee stated that his client had been allotted Z-plus security cover since 2016.

Bhattacharjee said that in 2024, after an assessment of the threat perception to Abhishek Banerjee by the Union home ministry, the MP was granted Z-plus security cover all over India. His counsel alleged that this security cover was suddenly withdrawn following West Bengal assembly election results in May, which BJP won. (*PTI*)

SC stays Delhi HC order on search of advocate's office



The Supreme Court on Monday stayed the Delhi High Court order that upheld the GST authorities' search of a lawyer's office and seizure of his computer. A bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu issued notice on lawyer Puneet Batra's plea and stayed the HC's order. On September 25, the top court asked the Goods and Services Tax (GST) authorities not to proceed with analysis of data seized from Advocate Puneet Batra's office till September 28. It had asked Additional Solicitor General S V Raju, appearing for the authorities, not to take action till the court hears the lawyer's plea.

Batra challenged the Delhi High Court's September 18 judgment, which held that law enforcement agencies can search a lawyer's office if there is prima facie evidence that the legal professional has committed an offence.

Last week, the top court took note of submissions from senior advocates Vikas Singh and N Hariharan and agreed to list for urgent hearing a plea challenging the Delhi HC judgment that upheld GST search of Batra's office. (*PTI*)

Collegium recommends three new judges for SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



Justice Sunita Agarwal



Justice DK Upadhyaya



Justice Aparesh Kumar Singh

The Supreme Court Collegium on Monday recommended the elevation of three High Court Chief Justices as judges of the apex court. According to the resolution issued by the Supreme Court, the Collegium recommended the elevation of Justice Sunita Agarwal, Chief Justice of the Gujarat High Court, as judge of apex court.

The collegium also recommended the name of Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya, Chief Justice of the Delhi High Court, as a judge of the apex court. Justice Aparesh Kumar Singh, Chief Justice of the High Court for the State of Telangana, is also recommended for the judgeship at the Supreme Court.

The recommendation was made at the Collegium meeting held on Monday.

Besides the CJI, Justices Vikram Nath, B V Nagarathna, M M Sundresh and P S Narasimha were part of the Supreme Court Collegium.

The Collegium's recommendation will now be processed in accordance with established procedure for appointment of judges to Supreme Court.



Examine statutory safeguards for minors: SC to Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday asked the Centre to examine whether a statutory framework can be put in place for social media intermediaries to ensure that they and other digital platforms comply with Indian laws governing minors, including the legal bar on children below 18 independently entering into contracts. On September 10, a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana had taken note of submissions made by senior advocate H S Phoolka, appearing for petitioner NGO 'Just Rights for Children Alliance', and sought responses on the plea from the Union ministries of electronics and information technology, as well as law and justice.

"We need some safeguards in India," the bench had said. The plea seeks safeguards for minors accessing social media, and to ensure no such platform enters into a contract with a child below 18 years of age.

"Something can be done, something should be done and will be done. We have to come back..." Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, told the bench on Monday.

Phoolka submitted that contracts entered into by minors are void under existing Indian law, and argued that platforms should be subject to enforceable obligations rather than merely voluntary guidelines.

Justice Bagchi said the requirement should not remain confined to a guideline and asked the solicitor general to examine whether it could be incorporated in statutory form under intermediary rules.

"Please pass directions under the intermediary rules that they fashion their software, or whatever the platform is called, in conformity with Indian law. The software has to conform with Indian law. That is our request," Justice Bagchi said.

SC asks registry to forward petition on adulterated medicines for consideration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



The Supreme Court on Monday asked its registry to forward a copy of a petition seeking a comprehensive framework to curb the manufacture and sale of counterfeit and adulterated medicines to authorities for consideration. "Have you given any suggestions to the authorities before filing this petition?" a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana asked petitioner Ashwini Kumar Upadhyay.

Upadhyay referred to the "vacuum" in the existing framework and said there were reports about how fake cancer drugs were supplied to many hospitals in Bengaluru.

"We will send your writ petition to be treated as a representation. That will be more effective than keeping the petition pending here," the bench observed.

It noted that the petitioner had not approached the authorities before filing the writ petition.

"In such circumstances where different kinds of actions are required to be undertaken by the respondents, we dispose of this writ petition without expressing any opinion on the merits with a direction to the registry to forward a copy of the writ petition to the respondent authorities for their consideration," the bench said.

In his PIL filed through advocate Ashwani Kumar Dubey, the petitioner had made the union ministries of Health and Family Welfare, Law and Justice and Women and Child Development, all states and union territories and the Law Commission as parties.

The plea sought directions to the Centre and states to complete investigations into fake medicine cases within three months and trials within one year.

SC issues contempt notice against Prof Bhrigu Nath Singh, VC of RGNAU and aviation ministry officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



The Supreme Court of India has issued contempt notices against Bhrigu Nath Singh, Vice Chancellor of the Rajiv Gandhi National Aviation University (RGNAU), and senior officials of the Ministry of Civil Aviation i.e. Samir Kumar Sinha IAS, Secretary and Madhu Sudan Sankar (Lateral Entry, Joint Secretary). It is glaring to note that Madhu Sudan Sankar is a repeated contemnor of court orders, who came from private company and joined on 3 years contract as Joint Secretary

This decisive step follows repeated non compliance with judicial directions, including the Allahabad High Court Single Bench order (17 September 2021), the Division Bench ruling (17 December 2021), Division Bench Order by the CJ Court (22 May 2024 & 15 Jul 2024) and the Supreme Court judgment dated 21 May 2026, which categorically quashed arbitrary & illegal administrative actions against the petitioner Jitendra Singh, First Registrar of RGNAU.

The most disturbing fact is that Visitor's Orders being quashed not once but twice for the same cause, is indeed unprecedented in India's constitutional and administrative history. The President of India, acting as Visitor to central universities, issues orders only after due process and advice; for those orders to be overturned twice by the judiciary underscores the depth of misrepresentation and malafide intent involved by the officials of RGNAU & MoCA. Despite clear and binding orders from the highest judicial authorities of the state & the country, it is therefore a matter of grave concern that despite clear directions, Prof Bhrigu Nath Singh (VC RGNAU), continue to act in open violation & wilful disregard of the law. Such misconduct by the VC also sets a dangerous precedence for students and future leaders, eroding respect for institutions and undermining the very values a university is meant to impart.

The Supreme Court has now taken cognizance of this defiance, reinforcing the principle that no authority is above the Constitution. The Court underscored that respect for judicial orders is non negotiable. Any defiance undermines governance, erodes public trust, and sets a dangerous precedence for India's higher education and public servants.

It is to be noted that the Jitendra Singh's case was represented by country's reputed senior advocate of Supreme Court Paramjit Singh Patwalia, assisted by Anupam Lal Das and Raktim Gogoi. And in the Allahabad High Court, the case a argued by renowned senior advocate Dr Lalta Prasad Misra.

It is expected that the Ministry of Civil Aviation and RGNAU to respond lawfully to the contempt notices promptly. Failure to comply may attract penal consequences, including fines, removal from office, and/or imprisonment.

Court acquits three in 2017 firing case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



A Delhi court has acquitted three men accused of firing at a man in Mundka in 2017, saying that the prosecution failed to prove the charges beyond reasonable doubt as the complainant and his brother did not identify them as the assailants.

Additional Sessions Judge Shiv Kumar was hearing a case against Amit alias Toto, Rahul alias Kalu and another Amit, who were accused of charges under IPC Sections 307 (attempt to murder), 323 (voluntarily causing hurt) and 34 (common intention).

In an order dated September 26, the court said, "Complainant and brother of complainant have not identified the accused persons in the court as assailants and not supported the case of prosecution... prosecution has failed to prove all the charged offences against the accused persons." Toto was also acquitted of charges under Sections 25 and 27 of the Arms Act relating to possession and use of illegal firearm.

The case related to an incident on July 14, 2017, when Devender alias Dholu was allegedly assaulted and fired at by a group of men at Mundka's Rani Khera Road.

According to the prosecution, the police later apprehended three men from bushes near the Rani Khera underpass. A pistol was allegedly recovered from Toto and two empty cartridges were recovered from the spot.

However, during trial, the complainant did not identify any of the accused in court. He told the court that it was dark at the time of the incident and that he could not identify the assailants. He also denied that a pistol had been recovered from Toto in his presence. The complainant's brother, Joginder, also failed to identify accused and said he had not seen the assailants. He denied that the accused were arrested in his presence or that the pistol and cartridges were recovered in his presence.

HC pulls up Jehanabad officials over neglect of Barabar Caves

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Patna



The Patna High Court has pulled up the Jehanabad district administration over the alleged neglect of the historic Barabar Caves and sought details of revenue generated from the annual Shravani Mela and its utilisation for permanent development of the site. Justice Rajiv Roy, in an order passed on September 21, observed that the administration appeared to be interested in revenue collection without adequately investing in infrastructure at the Mauryan-era site. "Certainly, the district administration is only interested in the collection of revenue with zero responsibility towards investing the money back to build infrastructure there," the court said.

It was hearing a petition filed by Rajballav Prasad, who had secured the tender for the 2024-25 Barabar Shravani Mela for ₹1.77 crore. The fair was halted after a stampede on August 12, 2024, in which seven people were killed and several injured. The petitioner eventually deposited the entire tender amount, with the final payment made on October 19, 2024, but was later asked to pay ₹1.37 lakh as penalty for delayed payment.

"The petitioner deposited the entire tender amount. Instead of appreciating the same, he has now been slapped with the penalty amount," the court said, terming the action "insensitiveness on the part of the respondents" and saying it "defies logic". The court said the stampede "clearly shows a mismanaged affair so far as the district administration is concerned" and noted that despite collecting ₹1.77 crore for the fair, permanent facilities at site remained inadequate.

"It has to be reiterated that the courts have repeatedly held that money so realised from a fair must be invested on the upliftment of the area to ensure proper sanitation, safety, improved infrastructure on permanent basis," the court said, adding these facilities were lacking "not only in year 2024 but till date". The court directed the Jehanabad District Magistrate to submit details of revenue generated from the Barabar Shravani Mela during the last five years and the amount spent on permanent development. It also sought a blueprint covering permanent toilets, year-round drinking water, benches, vending zones, cleanliness and greenery.

AdiVaani: Technology for the margins



RANJANA CHOPRA



India is home to over 700 tribal communities and more than 100 distinct tribal languages and dialects yet only a handful have a script, a dictionary or any presence online. For a Gondi speaking farmer trying to read a Government health advisory or a Santhali student searching for a word in a textbook, the digital world has, until now, simply not spoken their language. AdiVaani is changing that through one sentence, one recording, one translated page at a time.

AdiVaani is an AI based translation and language technology platform being developed under the Ministry of Tribal Affairs (MoTA) by IIT Delhi. Its mission is deceptively simple: build tools that let English and Hindi speak to tribal languages and let tribal languages speak back in text and in voice and vice versa.

AdiVaani has gone live with four languages - Santali, Mundari, Bhili and Gondi — with Kui and Garo close behind, and a further eight languages, including Katkari, Koya, Kokborok, Betta Kuruba, Chodri, Thadou Kuki and Tangkhul, lined up for the next phase.

A full toolkit, not just a translator

AdiVaani brings together a full toolkit under one roof, not merely a translator. It offers Text-to-Text Translation, converting English or Hindi text into a tribal language and back again, instantly; Speech-to-Text , which turns spoken tribal language into text and offers a lifeline for languages with few or no fluent readers; Text-to-Speech, which generates natural spoken tribal-language audio from written text so that non-literate speakers can access information aurally; and Speech-to-Speech, a cascaded pipeline that lets two people speaking different languages understand each other in near real time. The platform also carries an Optical Character Recognition feature that digitises old textbooks, folk manuscripts, primers and dictionaries existing only on paper, often the last surviving record of a dialect, alongside a public mobile App and Web Access portal carrying dictionaries, learning modules and feedback tools for continuous improvement.

Bringing the periphery to the centre

For decades, India's tribal languages have existed at the edge of the country's digital and administrative life rich in oral history, ecological knowledge and cultural memory, yet almost invisible to the internet, to AI systems and often to policy itself. AdiVaani inverts that equation. A welfare scheme notification, a health advisory or an NCERT textbook chapter that once existed only in Hindi or English can now be rendered accurately and respectfully into Santali or Bhili and read aloud to someone who cannot read at all. Government officials, teachers, and health workers can, in turn, understand what a tribal citizen is trying to communicate in their own words. The traffic runs both ways and that is the point: AdiVaani is not simply "giving" tribal communities access to the mainstream; it is giving the mainstream access to tribal India.

The project treats tribal languages not as data sources for AI but as living knowledge systems connected to oral tradition, agriculture, ecology and community identity.

Not just for tribal India — A platform for everyone

AdiVaani's promise extends well beyond tribal households. Researchers and linguists gain a reproducible, benchmarked dataset for some of the world's most under documented languages. Civil servants, doctors, teachers and NGO field workers posted in tribal districts most of whom are not themselves tribal get a real time translation companion that turns awkward, error prone communication into genuine dialogue. Students of linguistics and anthropology gain digitised manuscripts and oral archives that would otherwise decay unseen in local libraries. And every Indian, tribal or not inherits a small but meaningful correction to the digital record: languages that were at risk of existing only in memory now have a searchable, speakable, teachable home online.This is what makes AdiVaani more than a translation app, it is public infrastructure for inclusion, built the way inclusion should be built: with the community at the centre, not at the receiving end.

Community first, technology second

AdiVaani's most distinctive feature may not be its models at all but its method. Native speakers, translators, field linguists and community elders are treated as knowledge partners not just annotators. Every dataset passes through a maker checker superchecker workflow, where community validators catch the subtle ways AI tends to "flatten" a minority language toward Hindi or English,a dropped suffix, an over normalised idiom, a lost oral register. Machine generated translations are never treated as final: they return to native speakers for correction before they re enter the corpus. It is AI development grounded in consent, cultural respect and the recognition that a language is not a dataset it is a way a people remembers itself.

This is where the State Tribal Research Institutes (TRIs) become indispensable. Long before a sentence reaches an AI model, it is the TRIs in Jharkhand, Odisha, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh and elsewhere that anchor the entire corpus-building effort on the ground - mobilising native speakers, verifying dialectal variations across villages and blocks, and vetting every translated or transcribed sample before it is accepted into the training data. Their field knowledge decides which recordings are authentic and which idioms have been flattened in translation, making them the frontline check between raw community language and a usable digital corpus. Without this continuous, on-the-ground vetting by the TRIs, the models AdiVaani builds would carry the very distortions the project was set up to avoid.

Looking ahead

AdiVaani's work is far from finished. Over the next nine months, it plans to add ten more languages improve its speech recognition and voice technology, and build much larger collections of verified recordings reaching hundreds of thousands per language. But beyond the numbers, AdiVaani stands for something bigger: proof that technology can protect and support tribal languages instead of erasing them. In a country where languages are vanishing every few years, AdiVaani gives tribal communities a way to be heard in their own voices, on their own terms and gives the rest of India a reason finally to listen.

The author is Secretary, Union Ministry of Tribal Affairs

The machine age, read at last from India

The world's AI bookshelf has long spoken with an American accent. In an eight-volume series, IAS officer Dr Manish Ranjan gives the machine age an Indian voice — and gives the anxious general reader what has been missing all along: clarity



DR MANISH RANJAN



A strange weather has settled over our conversations. In drawing rooms and departmental canteens, in coaching centres and boardrooms, the same two questions circle endlessly: What exactly is this Artificial Intelligence? And what is it going to do - to my work, my children, my country? The buzz is everywhere; the understanding, almost nowhere. Between the salesmen of the future promising paradise and the prophets of doom promising apocalypse, the ordinary Indian reader has stood unattended - anxious, curious, and largely uninformed.

It has taken a serving administrator to attend to them. Dr. Manish Ranjan of the Indian Administrative Service has produced, in eight volumes, what may be described as the first complete Indian atlas of the machine age - written with deep analysis, current data and patient research, and illuminated throughout by case studies drawn from across the world and from within India. The series' quiet ambition is announced by its architecture: eight books, eight dimensions of a single subject - Artificial Intelligence, its knowledge, its systems, its impact.

The journey is designed like a well-planned expedition. Base camp is "Artificial Intelligence: Concepts and Applications," which does the patient, foundational work - what this technology actually is, and where it already operates, unnoticed, in our daily lives. From there the ascent begins. "AI for Everyone: How AI Turns the Promise of Equality into Reality" confronts the question on which this century may turn: will AI become the great equaliser - the tutor beside the furthest child, the doctor's knowledge at the poorest door - or a new and more efficient instrument of division? Dr. Ranjan does not flinch from either possibility, and it is precisely this honesty that gives his hope its weight.

"The Future of Humans in the Age of AI" lifts the gaze to what human learning, labour and society will look like when intelligent machines become our constant companions. Then the series turns to the reader's most immediate worry - the working professional's future. "20 Careers That Will Win by 2033: How to Stay Valuable When AI Rewrites the Rules of Work" is perhaps the most practically useful volume of the set, mapping the professions that will flourish and the human capacities - judgment, empathy, creativity, accountability - that no algorithm can replicate.

Two volumes then venture into territory where technology writing rarely dares. "The New Psychology of Love: Human Hearts, Machine Minds" examines how AI is quietly rearranging our personal, social and professional relationships - and, more unsettlingly, our very perception of what is real. Its darker sibling takes up that theme as a battle cry: framed as the human fight for your mind, your identity and a reality of your own, "AI and the War for Truth" confronts deepfakes, engineered misinformation and the new generation of cyber crimes - dangers that have already emptied bank accounts and reputations across the world, and that arrive in India with particular force in an election-rich, WhatsApp-forward society.

The final ascent is the boldest. "Will Artificial Intelligence Enslave Humans by 2033?" examines, with striking candour, the race between human control and machine capability - and locates the true danger not in rebellious machines but in resigned humans. And "Win the AI Decade: The New Rules of Work, Wealth and Success" plants the summit flag: a practical playbook for prospering in the ten years that will decide the next hundred.

Now to what makes this series historic rather than merely comprehensive. Until now, nearly every notable book on AI has been written through an American lens - American companies, American anxieties, American case studies - leaving the Indian reader to translate someone else's future into his own. For the first time, a series maintains genuine balance: global research standing shoulder to shoulder with Indian aspirations; international examples alongside the initiatives underway in our states; and a serious, sustained reckoning with what the future of AI in India actually looks like. Nowhere is the author's vantage more valuable than in the chapters on governance — for who better than a serving administrator to see how AI will transform the delivery of public services, the functioning of the welfare state, and the daily transaction between citizen and sarkar?

A word on the prose, because it is the series' secret weapon. The language is engaging and research-rich, yet scrubbed entirely of technical jargon - written in words a general reader can comprehend, and better still, enjoy. Not one line of code is required of the reader; only curiosity.

If the eight volumes had to be distilled into five sentences, they would perhaps be these. That AI is a tool and not a destiny - it will amplify whatever values we bring to it, and its direction remains a human choice. That understanding AI is now a civic necessity - the truly disadvantaged of this age will not be those who cannot code, but those who cannot question. That we must not compete with machines but compound with them, building careers on the judgment, empathy and accountability no machine possesses. That truth itself now needs defending - pause before believing, verify before sharing - and every alert citizen is a soldier in that war. And that a machine can attend to you, but only a human being can choose you - technology must serve our relationships, never substitute for them.

The books are available online across all major platforms, and they reward the reader with something this noisy decade rarely offers: clarity, and a certain calm courage about what is coming. Read them for the analysis; stay for the humanity. Artificial Intelligence, in these pages, is not merely explained. It is, at long last, demystified - and in an Indian voice.

The author is an IAS and the author of the eight-book series *The AI Series: From AI Basics to the Future*. An alumnus of the Goldman School of Public Policy, University of California, Berkeley, and the Saïd Business School, University of Oxford, he writes on Artificial Intelligence, society and the human future

China's eyes, Pakistan's finger, India's risk

Xi promised Trump that AI will stay under human control. But a human in the loop means little when the loop runs through Beijing



NISHANT SAHDEV



There is one sentence that hit me. It was spoken last July by India's Deputy Army Chief, Lt. Gen. Rahul R Singh. Describing Operation Sindoor, he said that when the two sides' military operations chiefs spoke on the hotline, Pakistan already knew which important Indian weapon system was "primed and ready for action", and asked India to pull it back. Then came the sentence: "He was getting live inputs from China."

As a country, we heard this, filed it under "China–Pakistan collusion", grumbled for a day and moved on. I think that was a serious mistake. That sentence is the most important thing any Indian official has said about nuclear danger in years, and we have not yet understood what it means.

Here is my argument. The world is worried that one day a nuclear power will hand its button to a machine. That is a real fear, and I wrote about it in my last week's column. But India faces a nearer and stranger danger. Pakistan will not need to hand its button to a machine. It is already handing its eyes to China. And in the age of AI, whoever controls the eyes increasingly controls the decision.

The bargain that kept us alive

Why has nuclear deterrence worked for 80 years? Not because leaders are wise. It has worked because of a brutal bargain: the person who decides to fire is also the person whose own cities will burn. Fear and responsibility sit in the same chair. That is what makes a leader pause.

What Lt Gen Singh described breaks that bargain. In the next India –Pakistan crisis, the eyes may sit in Beijing, the finger in Rawalpindi, and the risk in Delhi, Mumbai and Lahore. China would help shape the picture on which a nuclear-armed army acts, while its own cities stay out of harm's way. That is influence without exposure. It is the most dangerous kind of power there is, because it carries no reason to be careful.

Beijing played down the General's claim, and I accept it is the Indian Army's assessment rather than a proven fact. But nobody should doubt the direction. Around 80 per cent of Pakistan's imported weapons now come from China. Its jets, missiles, air defences and drones are Chinese. It would be naive to think the data that guides them will be anything else.

Doubt on trusting a borrowed detector

I have spent my working life around scientific instruments, and they teach you one lesson early: never trust a result from a detector you did not build, calibrate or understand. Detectors see ghosts. They mistake noise for signal. That is why it's difficult to announces a discovery on the strength of somebody else's black box.

Now think about what AI does to a war room. It does not just pass on photographs. It delivers conclusions: "launcher identified", "missile armed", "strike likely". It delivers them in seconds, in a region where a missile can cross the border in under ten minutes. And it delivers them with a confidence that tired, frightened human beings find almost impossible to resist.

So picture the moment that matters most. A Pakistani general, in the worst hour of his career, looks at a clean, confident screen. He did not build the system. He does not know what data trained it. He cannot know what its makers chose to show him and what they chose to leave out. Yet on that screen may rest a decision about nuclear escalation.

And we must be clear-eyed about the interests of the country that builds the screen. I do not believe Beijing wants a nuclear war in South Asia. No sane state does. But China gains when India is pinned down on its western front. Lt Gen Singh called it killing an enemy "with a borrowed knife". He also said China was treating the conflict as a "live lab" for its weapons. A laboratory needs test subjects. In that experiment, India is on the other side of the glass.

The hollow heart of "human control"

This is why I found the Washington summit's language on AI so unsatisfying. Xi Jinping told President Trump that AI must always remain "under human control". The two sides agreed to set up a channel for AI incidents. Fine words, and a useful step.

But human control of what, exactly? Every major pledge so far, including the one Joe Biden and Xi made in 2024, is about a country's own trigger. None of them says a word about the targeting data a country pours into a friend's war. By this definition, a Pakistani general acting on a Chinese machine's verdict counts as a "human in the loop".

I say a human in the loop is only as good as the loop. If the loop runs through a third capital, with its own software and its own agenda, then the human at the end of it is not in control in any sense that matters. He is simply the last person to press the button.

Physicists have a name for this kind of trouble. Two bodies moving under each other's pull are predictable. Add a third, and they are not: a tiny nudge can send the whole system somewhere nobody chose. Washington and Beijing have been working on a two-body problem. South Asia is a three-body problem, and no hotline between two capitals can fix it.

Let us be honest about ourselves

Some will say India is being hypocritical. We, too, receive intelligence from friends. Since 2020, India and the United States have shared geospatial data under the BECA agreement.

That objection deserves an answer, and here it is. The problem is not that friends share information. It is live, automated targeting support flowing into a nuclear crisis from a country that bears none of the risk. India should argue for a rule, not against a country, and it should be willing to live by that rule itself. That is what gives the argument its force. A principle India applies to its own partners is one Beijing will struggle to reject without revealing its intentions.

What India must do

First, India should draw the line out loud. Any country that feeds live targeting data or AI-driven intelligence to a side fighting India should be treated as a participant in that conflict, not a bystander. This is not a threat of war. It is a statement of consequences, and India is not without leverage. Our trade deficit with China crossed $110 billion last year. Beijing cannot be our trading partner in peacetime and our adversary's eyes in wartime.

Second, India must build its own eyes. The answer to a borrowed eye is a sovereign one. The 52 military surveillance satellites the Government approved in 2024 should be treated as urgent, because in a crisis the side that sees clearly is the side least likely to panic.

Please read the complete article online at dailypioneer.com

The author is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a contributing opinion writer at *The Wall Street Journal*

What Bhagat Singh's legacy means beyond martyrdom



SURJIT SINGH FLORA

Bhagat Singh was 23 when British authorities hanged him in Lahore on March 23, 1931. His execution helped make him one of India's best-known revolutionaries. Yet the story of his lasting influence is larger than the courage he showed in prison or the anger his death provoked. Singh wanted British rule to end. He also argued that independence would mean little if workers and the poor remained subject to exploitation. His socialism, secular politics and faith in reason gave his revolutionary commitment a broader purpose.

At the same time, his use of political violence, including an act that killed a police officer, remains difficult to defend. Any serious account of Singh must hold these facts together. His courage mattered, but so did his ideas and the human consequences of his actions.Born in Punjab in 1907, Singh came of age amid growing resistance to British rule.

He joined the Hindustan Socialist Republican Association, or HSRA, a revolutionary organisation that sought independence and a socialist republic. Its members accepted the risks of arrest, imprisonment and death.Those risks weren't abstract. Singh spent his early 20s organising and writing under the threat of surveillance and prosecution. Stories about his private life, including a frequently repeated account that he refused to marry, have become part of his public image.

His political record offers clearer evidence of his priorities: he gave his youth to a cause that could cost him his future. In December 1928, Singh and fellow revolutionary Rajguru killed police officer John Saunders in Lahore. The attack followed the death of nationalist leader Lala Lajpat Rai after police assaulted demonstrators. Accounts commonly identify officer James A. Scott as the intended target, but the familiar version of the killing as a simple case of mistaken identity is not certain. Saunders was killed, and the motive doesn't erase that fact.The case became central to the prosecution of Singh and his comrades. Authorities hanged Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev on March 23, 1931.

Their deaths brought grief and anger across India, but their significance rests on more than the spectacle of execution.Singh's political vision challenged the idea that independence alone would deliver justice. By the late 1920s, the HSRA had adopted socialism as a goal.

Singh argued that transferring power from British officials to Indian elites wouldn't be enough if most people remained poor and powerless. Freedom, in his view, had to change the conditions under which ordinary Indians lived.He left no complete plan for governing an independent India. His writings nevertheless make clear that he saw political freedom and economic equality as connected.

A country could govern itself and still leave workers exploited. The question of who ruled India, he argued, couldn't be separated from the question of who



benefited from its wealth and power. Singh also opposed religious divisions in politics. He believed people from different communities could join a common struggle against colonial rule and social injustice.

His essay "Why I Am an Atheist," written in prison in 1930, reflects his willingness to examine belief through reason rather than accept it on authority. The essay is a personal argument, not evidence that the independence movement shared his atheism. That habit of questioning shaped his understanding of revolution. Singh wrote essays, letters and public statements, and he insisted that ideas must guide political action.

His jail notebook and writing for young activists reveal a thinker who continued to read and argue while imprisoned. They offer a fuller portrait than images of him at the gallows or slogans detached from his politics.His actions, however, weren't all the same. On April 8, 1929, Singh and Batukeshwar Dutt threw low-intensity bombs in the Central Legislative Assembly in Delhi. They stayed at the scene and submitted to arrest.

The bombing was designed as a symbolic protest against colonial laws, not as an attempt to kill. That intent explains the act's political purpose, but it doesn't erase the risks of using explosives in a public chamber. The Assembly bombing also differed sharply from the killing of Saunders. One took a life; the other sought publicity without intending to kill.

Treating them as interchangeable obscures both Singh's strategy and the moral questions it raises. In jail, Singh joined a hunger strike demanding political-prisoner status and equal treatment for Indian prisoners.

The protest focused attention on prison conditions and the unequal treatment of inmates. Revolutionary Jatin Das died during the strike, bringing further public scrutiny to the authorities' handling of prisoners. The strike didn't secure every demand, but it made prison treatment part of the wider political debate.Singh and his comrades also used their trial as a platform. The proceedings gave them an opportunity to challenge British rule before an audience far larger than those who attended revolutionary meetings.

That visibility turned a criminal prosecution into a political argument. It didn't end colonial rule or settle whether revolutionary violence was justified, but it helped spread Singh's ideas.The HSRA was only one part of India's independence movement. Mass protests, labor and farmer organizing, political negotiations and nonviolent civil disobedience also challenged British authority. Gandhi's campaigns relied on nonviolent resistance and broad public participation. Singh and his comrades accepted political violence. Their methods differed, but both drew attention to a government that denied Indians control over their political future. Singh's fame shouldn't be mistaken for a claim that he alone secured independence. India's freedom came through the efforts of many people and organisations over decades.

His distinctive contribution was to insist that ending colonial rule wasn't enough if the new nation preserved deep economic inequalities. Today, Singh remains a figure of public commemoration and debate. March 23 is observed in India as Shaheed Diwas, or Martyrs' Day, in memory of Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev. Students, activists, labor groups, writers and filmmakers continue to draw on his image. Some emphasise his patriotism and willingness to face death; others focus on his socialism, secularism or criticism of inequality.

Commemoration can simplify a life. The fearless martyr is easier to celebrate than the political thinker who questioned religious authority and argued over class. A slogan about revolution can obscure what Singh believed revolution should achieve.

His legacy is more meaningful when his ideas remain attached to the familiar image. His methods also demand scrutiny. Killing Saunders was a deliberate, lethal act, even if Singh and his comrades believed they were retaliating against colonial violence. The Assembly bombing had a different purpose, but it still involved explosives and risked harm.

Admiration for Singh's opposition to British rule doesn't require accepting every tactic as justified.Accounts of his final words and private conversations often circulate without firm evidence. The same care is needed with the date of his birth, which historical accounts place on September 27 or 28, 1907.

September 28 is widely used for commemorations, but that convention doesn't erase the uncertainty. Accuracy matters because the record of Singh's writing, trial and actions is substantial enough without embellishment.Bhagat Singh remains important because his demand for freedom extended beyond the end of British rule.

He wanted a society in which ordinary people had a fairer share of power and resources. His execution made him a martyr; his writings show the political questions that martyrdom alone cannot answer. Remembering him fully means honoring his courage while confronting both the life taken at Lahore and the ideals he wanted an independent India to pursue.

The author is a veteran journalist and freelance writer based in Brampton Canada

EOI Ref No. HIL/RSY/Outsource/2nd/2026-27 Date 25.09.2026

HIL (India) Limited
(Govt, of India Enterprise)
SCOPE Complex, Core-6, 2nd Floor, 7 Lodhi Road
New Delhi-110003, Website - www.hil.gov.in

Interested bidders may download the details from our website (www.hil.gov.in) & CPP portal website (https://eprocure.gov.in/epublish/app)

Description	EMD Rs.
Expression of Interest (EOI) for utilization of HIL's Formulation plants at Rasayani Unit on outsource basis for the manufacturing of agrochemicals, water soluble fertilizers, biopesticides, bio fertilizers, and micronutrients on as is where is basis for supply in HIL Brand, **which is due on 16.10.2026 at 11:00 Hrs.**	Rs. 5,00,000/-
Further Corrigendum, if any to the EOI will be hosted in the above websites **CBC02111/11/0002/2627**	

कार्यालय नगर पालिक निगम, भोपाल
सामरिक विभाग (मुख्यालय) अटल भवन लिंक नम्बर 02 तुलसी नगर
लिखित आमंत्रण घोषणा पत्र
क्रमांक 154 /यां.वि./26 भोपाल, दिनांक 24/09/2026
निम्न कार्य हेतु म.प्र लोक निर्माण विभाग में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से ऑनलाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। विस्तृत विवरण website https://www.mptenders.gov.in पर है।

क्रमांक	निविदा क्रमांक	कार्य का संक्षिप्त विवरण	अनुमानित लागत (रु.में)	निविदा क्रय करने का अंतिम दिनांक	समय
1	2026_UAD_538340_1	REPAIRING AND MAINTAINANCE OF CC ROAD AND DRAIN AT SARVADHARMA B SECTOR FROM VISHAL MEGA MART TO DAMKHEDA BASTI , FROM SHREE APARTMENT TO KIRANA STORE MANDAKINI COLONY SARVADHARMA C SECTOR NEAR ABHISHEK SAINI HOUSE , FROM GANPATI COLONY GATE TO HANUMAN JI MANDIR AND VARIOUS OTHER PLACES WARD 82 ZONE 18	2,52,15,821 /-	27-Oct-2026	05:30 PM

नोट– संशोधन वेबसाइट पर ही देखे जा सकेंगे समाचार पत्रों में प्रकाशित नही होंगे ।
नि. क्र. 783/026/027
कार्यापालन यंत्री (सिविल) नगर निगम भोपाल

INDORE MUNICIPAL CORPORATION, INDORE
Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana, 107-109, First Floor, Palika Plaza, Indore
Email : pmayindore@gmail.com, Ph.: 0731-2547774
NIT No.: 22/PMAY/2026-27
NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Date : 23.09.2026
Online Percentage Rate Tenders are invited for the following work based on MPPWD SOR 01/04/2024 and amendments till date from Contractors/Reputed firms who have successfully executed works of similar nature and magnitude.

Sr. No.	Name of Work	Probable Amount of Contract (₹in Lakhs) (PAC)	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)	Cost of Bid Document	Period of Completion (in Months)
1	Supply, Installation, Testing, Commissioning of 33/11 KV Sub Station Work and 11 KV line at Bada Bangarda Bhudhania for Kshipra Parisar (KH-16), under PMAY Located in Indore, M.P.	293.17	₹1,46,590/-	₹15,000.00 + GST	04 Months (Including Rainy Season)

Note: The EMD shall be in the form of online payment only as given in the Bid Data Sheet.
Important dates for tender processing are as under :-
1. Last date for purchase of tender document and online submission of tender : 23.10.2026 before 18.00 Hrs.
2. Pre-Bid meeting will be held on : 01.10.2026 at 15.00 Hrs.
3. Technical Bid will be open on : 27.10.2026 at 16.30 Hrs.

- If the office happens to be closed on the date of opening of the technical bid as specified, the bids will be opened on the next working day at the same time and venue.
- **Note- Bid should be submitted online only, Physical copy will not be accepted.**
- Tender document and other details shall be available on Website - www.mptenders.gov.in
- For any Information regarding website please contact on 0120-4001-002 & 0120-4001-005

Executive Engineer (PMAY)
Indore Municipal Corporation, Indore

PUBLIC NOTICE
It is hereby informed Public at large that my clients namely SAMSUDDIN KHAN, S/o Late Dan Khan residing at H.No.A-467 Defence Colony, New Delhi-110024, have severed his family relations from his son namely Mohammad Shami aged about 27 years, due to out of control and misbehaves, act against my client's wishes, and has created an unbearable family atmosphere. Therefore, my client has severed all his relations with him and debar/disown him from all his movable and immovable properties. Any person dealing with him in any manner whatsoever (financial, commercial, or personal) shall do so entirely at their own risk and responsibility. My client and his remaining family members shall not be held liable or responsible for any of their acts, deeds, debts, or dealings.
Abdus Samad (Advocate)
Ch No. 243, Saket Court Complex, New Delhi-110017

Public Notice
This is to inform the general public that (1) Mrs. Shashi (2) Mr. Deepak Jha (3) Mr. Yash Raj Kaushik are the Possessors of the Property Bearing Portion of Plot No. 67, area measuring 58.33 Sq. Yds. (Out of 155.5 Sq. Yds), Out of Khasra No. 72, Situated in the area of Village Nawada, Colony known as Vipin Garden Extn. Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059. They are in Possession through Notarized GPA, ATS and WILL dated 01.04.2025 executed by Mr. Birendra Kumar in favour of (1) Mrs. Shashi (2) Mr. Deepak Jha (3) Mr. Yash Raj Kaushik, in respect of Property Bearing Portion of Plot No. 67, area measuring 58.33 Sq. Yds. Out of Khasra No. 72.
(1) Mrs. Shashi (2) Mr. Deepak Jha (3) Mr. Yash Raj Kaushik intends to transfer the ownership of above said property by way of Sale Deed to Mr. Sudhir Khare and Mrs. Archana Chauhan. Subsequently, Mr. Sudhir Khare and Mrs. Archana Chauhan are in the process of mortgaging the said property with SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.
If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-days period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline(s): +91012-04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया Central Bank of India
1911 से आपके लिए "केन्द्रित" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911
Regional Office (Gurugram)
1st Floor KNG Square, Plot No.06, Sector-44, Gurugram, Haryana-122003
Tel: 0124-41028938
E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE (Under SARFAESI Act 2002)

APPENDIX- IV-A [SEE PROVISO TO RULE 8(6) & 9(1)] SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) & 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged / charged to the secured creditor, the **Physical / Symbolic Possession** of which have been taken by the Authorized officer of **Central Bank of India,** secured creditors, will be sold on **16.10.2026 "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis** for recovery of dues to the **Central Bank of India** from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties. For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in: **www.centralbank.bank.in** or (**https://BAANKNET.com**)

DESCRIPTION OF PROPERTIES TO BE AUCTIONED ON 16.10.2026 (15 DAYS NOTICE)
Amount in Rupees

S. No.	Name of Branch	Authorised Officer/B.M.	Name of the Account	Description of Property & Owner Name	Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (Rs. in Lakhs)	Date & Type of Possession	Reserve Price / EMD / Bid Increase
1.	Naraina New Delhi	Ms. Swati Rani Mobile: 8800013528	Satish Kumar Singh and Poonam Singh	Residential Property bearing No. B-1/5 and 6, First Floor Back Side Portion, Without Roof/ Terrace Rights, Area measuring 50 Sq Yards, Situated in the area of Village- Palam, Colony known as Rajapuri, Gali No.-5, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi- 110059, **Owner- Mrs. Poonam Singh W/o Mr. Satish Kumar Singh and Mr. Satish Kumar Singh S/o Mr. Tej Bahadur Singh**	Rs.11,26,590.45 on 18.12.2025 + Interest + Other Charges	28.06.2025 (Physical)	₹ 12,96,000.00 / ₹ 1,29,600.00 / ₹ 10,000.00
2.	Delhi Cantonment New Delhi	Mr. Suraj Kumar Mobile: 8957330934	Rajesh Tiwari and RakeshTiwari	Flat No- E- 100 (Old No- WZ 346), Flat on Third Floor Without Roof/Terrace Rights, Area measuring 80 Sq Yards, out of Khasra No. 95/22, situated in the area of Village- Palam, Delhi State, Gali No. 17-B, Colony known as Sadh Nagar, New Delhi- 110045, **Owner- Mr. Rajesh Tiwari and Mr. RakeshTiwari**	Rs.25,07,504.42 on 15.05.2024 + Interest + Other Charges	11.02.2025 (Physical)	₹ 20,70,000.00 / ₹ 2,07,000.00 / ₹ 20,000.00
3.	Jonapur New Delhi	Mr. Bhushan Kumar Mobile: 9617493179	Mr. Ishwar Singh	EWS Residential Flat No. F-430"1-BHK, Ground Floor Nand Nikunj, NandGhram, Ghaziabad-201003 Measuring area 19.53 SQ. MTRS in the Name of **Mr.Ishwar Singh**	Rs.8,00,095.00 on 05.05.2026 + Interest + Other Charges	03.12.2024 (Physical)	₹ 6,84,000.00 / ₹ 68,400.00 / ₹ 10,000.00

E-AUCTION DATE: 16.10.2026, TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 4:00 P.M WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES
Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: 16.10.2026 Upto 3:30 PM. Bidder will register on website: (**https://BAANKNET.com**) and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in Global EMD Wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer (after generation of challan from (**https://BAANKNET.com**).
The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider "**https://BAANKNET.com**" E-auction will be held on **"As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever is there is" basis.** (All other charges/dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser).
For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in **www.centralbank.bank.in** Secured Creditor or Auction Platform {**https://BAANKNET.com**} **BAANKNET** Helpdesk: (+91) 8291220220, **E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com**
NOTICE FOR SUB STATUTORY 15 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) & 9(1) OF SARFAESI ACT 2002
The borrowers/guarantors/ mortgagors are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.
DATE: 28.09.2026
PLACE: GURUGRAM
Authorised Officer, CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA, Regional Office (Gurugram) KNG Square, Sector-44, Gurugram

SBI STATE BANK OF INDIA E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE
BRANCH OFFICE: HOME LOAN CENTRE, A1/24, JANAKPURI, NEW DELHI-110058
NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION SALE ON 30.10.2026 FOR MOVABLE PROPERTY
E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Movable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act,2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated /charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer **State Bank of India,** the Secured Creditor, will be sold on **" As is Where is", As is What is" and Whatever there is" on 30.10.2026**, for recovery of bank due to the secured creditor as under :-
Interested bidder may deposit Pre-Bid EMD with BAANKNET before the close of e-Auction. Credit of Pre-Bid EMD shall be given to the bidder only after receipt of payment in BAANKNET's Bank Account and up-dation of such information in the e-auction website. This may take some time as per banking process and hence bidders, in their own interest, are advised to submit the pre-bid EMD amount well in advance to avoid any last minute problem.
Date / Time of E-Auction on 30.10.2026 for 8 Hours from 10:00 AM to 06:00 PM with unlimited extn. of 10 minute each.

S. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s)	Outstanding Dues for Recovery of which Property/ies is/are being Sold	Vehicle Description	Reserve Price (Rs.) (below which property could not be sold) / Earnest Money (EMD) 10% of the Reserve Price / Bid Increase Amount	Name of the Authorised Officer
1.	**Mr. Saurav** S/o Mukesh Kumar **Car Loan A/c. No. 42087439772** H. No.25, Shree Chand Park, Dharampura Extn., Najafgarh, New Delhi-110043.	**Rs.9,96,093.00 as on 13.06.2024 plus future Interest and other Charges etc. thereon**	**Make & Model:** HYUNDAI VENUE 1.2 KAPPA MT SX **Vehicle No.: DL9CBC3746 Engine No.: G4LAPM576616 Chassis No.:** MALFD81BLPM487890 **Date of Registration: 19.07.2023 Fuel:** Petrol	₹ 3,70,000.00 / ₹ 37,000.00 / ₹ 5,000.00 / *GST as applicable	Mr. Madan Kumar (Chief Manager) HLC, A1/24, Janakpuri, New Delhi-110058. Tel-011-79681631 / Mr. Rakesh Sharma Mob: 7503037863

Last Date of EMD Deposit on or before 30.10.2026 upto 9:00 A.M.
Account/ Wallet in which EMD to be remitted : Bidder's own wallet Registered with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing by means of NEFT/RETS. EMD of Reserve Price to be transferred by bidders by means of challan generated on his/her/their bidder account maintained with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing by means of NEFT from his /her/their bank. For any assistance, please call BAANKNET HELPDESK: +91 8291220220, support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com and/or Authorized Officer.
TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF THE E-AUCTION ARE AS UNDER:
(1) E-Auction is being held on **"As is where is", "as is what is basis " and "whatever there is basis "**and will be conducted **"On Line".** The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider **BAANKNET** at their web portal: **https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing**
(2) Bank shall reserve the right to cancel/postpone the auction.
(3) The Vehicle are available for inspection during banking hours on **29.10.2026 from 11:00 AM to 17:00 Hrs , Contact Person : Mr. Rakesh Sharma, Mobile: 7503037863, M/s Kuber Consultant (Resolution Agent).**
(4) **Successful bidder to pay GST as applicable on the successful bid amount, viz sale value.**
(5) To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized Officer there is no encumbrance on the property/ies. However the intending bidder should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of the property/ies put on auction and claims/tights/dues/affecting the property prior to submitting their bid.
The e-Auction Advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the Bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank. The Authorized Officer shall not be responsible in any way for any third party claims/rights/ dues.
(6) The Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of the successful bidder shall be retained towards part sale consideration and the EMD of the unsuccessful bidders shall be refunded. The Earnest Money Deposit shall not bear any Interest. The successful bidder shall have to deposit 25% of the sale price, immediately on acceptance of bid price by the Authorized Officer and the balance of the sale price on or before 15th day of the sale. Default in deposit of amount by the successful bidder would entail forfeiture of the whole money already deposited and property shall be put to the e-auction and the defaulting bidder shall have no claim/right in respect of property / amount.
(7) For detailed terms and conditions of the sale please refer to the link at the Bank's Service Provider's web portal: **https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing & e-auction website: https://BAANKNET.com**
Place: New Delhi Date: 28.09.2026 **Authorized Officer, State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, Janakpuri, New Delhi**

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform general public that Mahboob Ridha s/o. Md. Naseem has acquired Property bearing No. 20, area measuring 33 sq. yds., out of Khasra no. 15/8/2, situated in the area of village Razapur Khurd, in the colony known as Sai Enclave, Mohan Garden, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi 110059, by way of Notarised GPA, Notarised ATS & Will dated 24.04.2026. Now, Mahboob Ridha s/o. Md. Naseem intending to sell said property to Mr. Vivek Gautam and further availing a loan on above said property from Truhome Finance Limited (earlier known as Shriram Housing Finance Ltd.) in case anyone has any objection, the same may be raised within 7 days of this publication to Mr. Ajit Sharma (Advocate), Partner of AccuLaw Source LLP, Office no. 361, 2nd Floor, Sec-1, Vaishali, Ghaziabad, U.P. Pincode 201010 or contact : +91 9560309909 (M).

PUBLIC NOTICE
My client, Manveer Singh son of the L. Sh. Buddhan Singh, R/o WB-91, Ganesh Nagar-II, Shakarpur, Delhi-110092, has disowned his daughter Pooja Bhati & severed all ties with her due to her misconduct. My client or his family shall not be held responsible for any of her actions in future.
Kirti Madan (Advocate), Ch.No. G-6 1st Floor, Karkardooma Court Shahdara Delhi-32

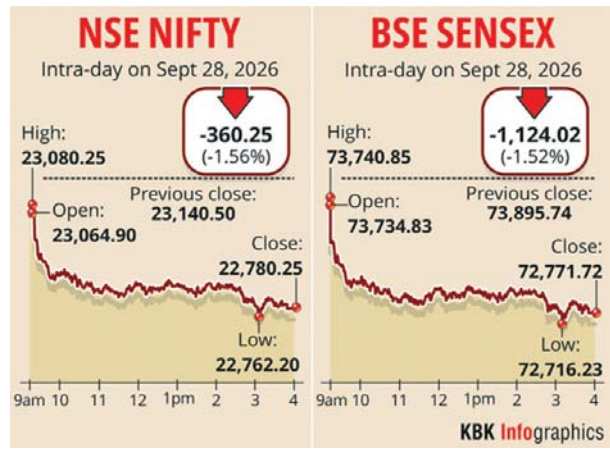
PUBLIC NOTICE
It is publically notified that Plot No. 156, Block-D, Sector-41, Noida, Distt Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh, area measuring 180 sq.mtrs., has been allotted in the name of **Swaran Singh Mundi** S/o Shri Harnaik Singh Mundi R/o D-156, Sector-41, Noida, Distt Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh, & **Mrs. Harbir Dhillon** W/o Late Shri Harpal Singh R/o Pine Drive-50 Malibu Town, Sector-47, Gurugram Haryana, and Mr. **Swaran Singh Mundi** has executed a General Power of Attorney was executed in favour of **Alamdeep Singh** S/o Shri Tara Singh R/o Mal Majra Tehsil Samrala Distt Ludhiana Pubjab-141114 and the same was registered on 28.10.2021, so with the help on the notice it is informed the transfer of the above plot in favour of **Viapak Rai** S/o Late Shri Anil Kumar Aggarwal & **Mrs. Rachna Rai** W/o Shri Viapak Rai both R/o M-99, Greater Kailash Part-II, New Delhi-110048 and the Agreement to Sell was not registered. If any one has any objection he/she may submit his/her, objection in the Housing Department of Noida Authority alongwith sufficient proofs within 30 days of the publication this notice. **Alamdeep Singh Mrs. Harbir Dhillon**

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The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | SEPTEMBER 29, 2026

Sensex tanks 1,124 pts, hits 6-month low

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Mumbai



Stock markets tumbled on Monday, with the benchmark Sensex plunging 1,124 points to a six-month low and the Nifty closing below 22,800 as surging crude oil prices, geopolitical uncertainties, and weak global trends hit investor sentiment.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 1,124.02 points, or 1.52 per cent, to settle at 72,771.72, the lowest closing level since March 30, 2026. During the day, it lost 1,179.51 points, or 1.59 per cent, to 72,716.23.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 360.25 points, or 1.56 per cent, to end at a near six-month low of 22,780.25. As many as 47 Nifty shares closed lower while three were up, reflecting across-the-board selling.

Analysts said surging crude oil prices following the US-Iran stalemate over the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, foreign fund outflows, a spike in US bond yields and weak Asian markets triggered selling in financial, PSU banks, metals, FMCG, oil & gas and auto shares.

Among the 30 Sensex firms, 29 ended lower. Larsen & Toubro fell the most by 2.81 per cent. Power Grid dropped 2.62 per cent, Adani Ports by 2.38 per cent, HDFC Bank by 2.3 per cent, Hindustan Unilever by 2.27 per cent and Reliance Industries by 2.24 per cent.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 3.81 per cent to $108.3 per barrel.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth ₹3,693.93 crore on Friday, according to exchange data. "Bears remained firmly in control as the market breached a key psychological support level, reflecting growing investor caution amid deteriorating global macro conditions.

"The US rejection of the ceasefire proposal has heightened concerns that tensions in West Asia could persist for longer than anticipated, reducing the likelihood of a near-term diplomatic resolution and increasing the risk of prolonged supply-side disruptions and higher commodity prices," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said.

Rising US bond yields are narrowing the India-US yield spread, potentially leading to foreign fund outflows and keeping market sentiment cautious, the analyst said.All BSE sectoral indices ended lower. The PSU Bank plummeted 3.25 per cent, Power tumbled 2.30 per cent, Telecommunication 2.30 per cent, Utilities 2.27 per cent, MidSmall Private Banks 2.17 per cent, Industrials 2 per cent, MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt 1.99 per cent Services 1.93 per cent and Private Banks index 1.86 per cent.

"Indian equity benchmarks closed sharply lower, extending their recent weakness as a fresh surge in crude oil prices and renewed uncertainty surrounding US-Iran talks weighed heavily on investor sentiment. Selling remained broad-based through the session, with the broader market underperforming frontline indices," Ponmudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

Plan rabi sowing scientifically: Agriculture Minister tells States



Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Monday asked state governments to approach the upcoming rabi season with scientific planning, keeping in mind the drought and water scarcity that some regions faced during the just-concluded kharif season due to climate change.

Addressing a two-day national conference on preparedness for the rabi (winter) season, Chouhan said, "When we speak of the Rabi season, we must also consider the Kharif season, which caused great concern because of climate change. Weather patterns have shifted."

He said kharif crops had been affected in places, though they had not failed everywhere. "In many places the crop is very good, but there is a threat of drought and water scarcity in some regions," he said, adding that rainfall had been excellent in some areas and below average in others.

"I urge state officials to approach Rabi planning scientifically by assessing water availability and soil moisture in specific regions and making advance arrangements for irrigation water," he noted.

"Since water resources are limited, we must plan strategically and must not delay preparations," he said, stressing the need to plan for pre-sowing and subsequent irrigation. *(PTI)*

Rupee falls 28 paise to close at 96.03 against US dollar



The rupee depreciated 28 paise to close at 96.03 (provisional) against the US dollar on Monday, on risk-off sentiments in global markets after the US rejected a deal proposal by Iran, diminishing hopes of reopening of the Strait of Hormuz.

Forex traders said global risk sentiments deteriorated as the stalemate between the US and Iran continued; falling risk assets and a surge in crude oil prices may continue to pressurise the rupee.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened on a negative note at 95.89 against the American currency. During the day, the local unit slipped further to close at 96.03 (provisional), a 28 paise fall from its previous close.

On Friday, the rupee appreciated 24 paise to close at 95.75 against the US dollar.

"The Indian rupee declined by nearly 20 paise on risk-off sentiments in global markets after the US rejected a deal proposal by Iran, diminishing hopes of reopening the Strait of Hormuz. Brent crude oil breached the USD 108 per barrel mark while global equities tanked. US dollar and US Treasury yields also strengthened," said Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset Sharekhan.

Choudhary further added that the rupee is expected to trade with a negative bias as global risk sentiments deteriorated with the continued stalemate between the US and Iran. "Falling risk assets and surge in crude oil prices may continue to pressurise the rupee.

However, any intervention by the RBI may support the rupee at lower levels," Choudhary said, adding that traders may take cues from speeches by various FOMC members. *(PTI)*

Sensex, Nifty tumble over 5% in past month

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty have dropped more than 5 per cent over the past month, wiping out ₹ 17.17 lakh crore in investor wealth as surging crude oil prices, geopolitical uncertainties, and elevated bond yields dampened market sentiment.

Indications of further monetary tightening by the US Federal Reserve also weighed on sentiment during this time. The 30-share BSE Sensex tumbled 4,161.87 points or 5.40 per cent since August 27 last month. The 50-share NSE Nifty also plunged 1,310.6 points or 5.44 per cent.

Investors' wealth eroded by ₹17,17,487.02 crore to ₹ 4,74,36,620.19 crore ($ 4.94 trillion) during this period.

On Monday, the BSE benchmark tanked 1,124.02 points, or 1.52 per cent, to settle at 72,771.72, its lowest close since March 30, 2026. The Nifty dropped 360.25 points, or 1.56 per cent, to end at a near six-month low of 22,780.25.

Investors' wealth declined by ₹7.52 lakh crore on Monday alone.

"Bears remained firmly in control as the market breached a key psychological support level, reflecting growing investor caution amid deteriorating global macro conditions.

The US rejection of the ceasefire proposal has heightened concerns that tensions in West Asia could



persist for longer than anticipated, reducing the likelihood of a near-term diplomatic resolution and increasing the risk of prolonged supply-side disruptions and higher commodity prices," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped nearly 4 per cent to $108.3 per barrel. Brent crude at $108 and the US 10-year yield at 5.2 per cent are strong headwinds that are weighing on markets, an expert said.

Exports up 15% despite uncertainties: Goyal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Mumbai



India's merchandise exports have risen 15 per cent till September 21 during this fiscal year despite global economic uncertainties triggered by the ongoing wars, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday.

Addressing the media after the 14th India-UAE High Level Task Force on Investment meeting here, the minister also said the UAE – India's seventh largest source of FDI – has expressed an intent to invest another $ 25 billion in the near future, with the ultimate objective of taking its investments in India to $ 100 billion in the years to come.

"We have increased our merchandise exports by upward of 15 per cent in the first six months (up to September 21) this year, which is a pretty important and significant achievement given the fact that we are living in a world where two wars are going on and the Strait or Hormuz, which is our principal sea route, is facing so much stress," Goyal said.

Tata Trusts propose Tata Sons rejig to keep it private

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Mumbai



Tata Trusts, which own 66 per cent of Tata Sons, have proposed merging two operating companies with the Tata Group's holding company in a restructuring that would allow it to shed its classification as a non-banking financial company and a core investment company, helping it retain its status as an unlisted private company. The proposed restructuring involves the merger of Tata Electronics Systems Solutions Pvt Ltd (TESS) and Tata Consulting Engineers (TCE) with Tata Sons - the holding company of the salt-to-software, cars and airline conglomerate, according to a statement issued by the Tata Trusts on Monday.

The Trusts, which have vehemently opposed listing the holding company, have asked the Tata Sons board to consider the proposal and take necessary steps, including seeking a prior no-objection certificate from the Reserve Bank of India for the proposed merger.

The restructuring is aimed at ensuring the reorganised Tata Sons does not meet the regulatory criteria for either an NBFC or a core investment company, the Trusts said.

The proposed restructuring comes against a backdrop of growing differences between Tata Trusts and the board of Tata Sons over its future ownership structure.

The Trusts, chaired by Noel Tata since October 2024, have opposed listing Tata Sons and in July 2025 unanimously resolved that efforts should be made to retain the company as an unlisted private entity.

The position gained urgency after RBI classified Tata Sons as an upper-layer NBFC in 2022, a status that carries a regulatory listing requirement. Tata Sons has sought to exit the NBFC framework, but the RBI rejected its request in September, leaving the listing issue unresolved.

The dispute has also spilled into the appointment of Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran. The Trusts had backed his reappointment for a third five-year term in July 2025, but opposed the board's subsequent decision in 2026 to reappoint him after he indicated he would not seek another term.

Noel Tata and the Trusts argued that the Tata Sons articles required the Trusts' nominee directors' support for the appointment and described the board's decision as invalid. The board has nevertheless backed Chandrasekaran and proceeded with steps linked to regulatory compliance. The latest restructuring proposal offers the Trusts a route to address the listing requirement while preserving Tata Sons as an unlisted private company.

"The Tata Trusts today, as majority shareholders with a 66 per cent stake in Tata Sons Private Limited (TSPL), outlined a strategic reorganisation plan for the company which, when given effect to, would ensure that the reorganised entity would neither be an NBFC nor a core investment company," it said in the statement.

India, UAE agree to trade in local currency, integration of payment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Mumbai



India and the UAE on Monday agreed to take steps for the timely implementation of initiatives relating to settlement of trade in local currency, integration of payment and messaging systems, and central-bank digital currencies.

These issues are important as they have the potential to make bilateral trade and investment more efficient, accessible and resilient, the commerce and industry ministry said in a statement.

The matters came up for discussion during the 14th meeting of the India-UAE High Level Joint Task Force on Investments (HLJTFI) here.

The task force was set up in 2013 to promote trade, investment and economic ties. It acts as a forum to resolve issues faced by investors of the two countries. It was co-chaired by Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and Managing Director of Abu Dhabi Investment Authority (ADIA) Sheikh Hamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan.

"The co-chairs reviewed the progress made by the central banks of the UAE and India on initiatives relating to local-currency settlement, the integration of payment and messaging systems, and central-bank digital currencies. It was noted that these initiatives have the potential to make bilateral trade and investment more efficient, accessible and resilient. The two sides agreed to take steps to work together to support their timely implementation," it said.

The areas where two-way investment flows can be enhanced include energy, industry, logistics, infrastructure, technology and artificial intelligence, space, food security, agricultural innovation and the startup ecosystem. "Civil aviation cooperation between Abu Dhabi and India was also discussed at the meeting, with the aim of enhancing air connectivity to support the broader economic relationship," it said, adding investment opportunities and collaboration in developing an aviation and logistics hub in Dholera (Gujarat) were also explored.

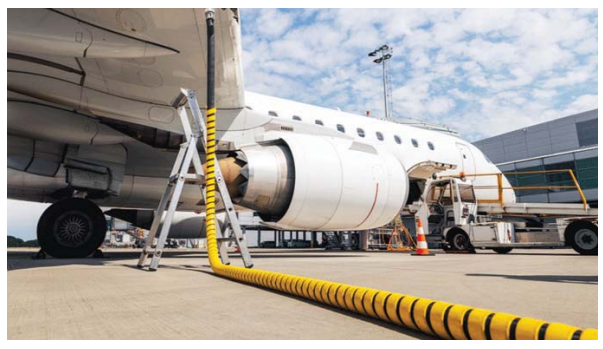
The bilateral trade has reached $101.25 billion in 2025-26. The non-oil trade touched $76.2 billion last year. The two nations have implemented a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) in May 2022.

In August 2024, both partners implemented a bilateral investment treaty (BIT) with the aim of protecting and promoting investments.

As the UAE and India continue to work towards the shared ambition of $200 billion in bilateral trade by 2032, the two continue to expand investment cooperation across the sectors that will drive future growth, including energy, infrastructure, technology and AI.

Surging jet fuel demand to boost SAF market: Report

PIONEER NEW SERVICE
New Delhi



Jet fuel demand in India would rise from about 192,000 barrels per day in 2024 to 277,000 barrels per day by 2031, providing a strong market for the Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF), as per a report released on Monday.

The government has announced SAF blending roadmap starting with 1 per cent blending in 2027 and increasing to 2 per cent in 2028 and 5 per cent in 2030 to decarbonise the aviation industry.

The report jointly developed by S&P Global Energy and the SAF Association estimates that the SAF demand will be 46,000 tonne in 2027, which would rise to 250,000 tonne in 2030.

India's aviation sector is expected to remain one of the fastest-growing sources of refined product demand through 2060, providing a strong foundation for developing a domestic SAF market, the report said.

"This expansion is driven by rising middle-class mobility, continued growth in domestic and international air travel, airport infrastructure development, and ongoing airline fleet additions," it said.

The report, released at 2nd India SAF Conclave, noted that while some short-term weakness emerged in 2026, particularly in the international segment, the underlying demand trajectory remains firmly positive.

India's aviation fuel consumption softened in mid-2026, with July demand falling to about 180,000 barrel per day reflecting weaker flight activity, higher operating costs, and supply-side disruptions, it said.

However, first-half 2026 jet fuel consumption still increased by nearly 2 per cent year-over-year, suggesting the recent slowdown is temporary rather than structural and does not alter the longer-term growth outlook, the report said. "The demand outlook is further supported by rising passenger traffic, the continued expansion of low-cost aviation, and increasing international connectivity," it said. New infrastructure, including Navi Mumbai International Airport and Jewar Airport in Noida, is expected to ease capacity constraints and support additional growth in flight activity. International aviation is likely to remain an important demand driver, with international seat capacity expanding faster than domestic capacity in 2026 despite higher ticket costs. "Policy support is also expected to play an important role in sustaining aviation growth. A key structural driver is the government's continued focus on expanding air connectivity through UDAN (Ude Desh Ka Aam Nagrik) Regional Connectivity Scheme," the report said.

It highlighted that the government has introduced an aviation turbine fuel (ATF) pricing stabilization mechanism, including a fixed ATF price in Delhi and a dedicated stabilization fund.

While not a direct subsidy, the mechanism reduces fuel price volatility and improves cost visibility for airlines, it added.

Labour Minister Mandaviya calls for continuous reskilling amid AI boom

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya on Monday highlighted the transformative potential of AI and emerging technologies and stressed the need for continuous reskilling and a future-ready industrial relations system that balances productivity with workers' skills, safety and participation.

The Union Labour & Employment Minister was speaking at National Conference on Industrial Relations and Labour, organised by CII. He called for meaningful social dialogue between employers and workers, particularly as new technologies reshape the world of work, a CII statement said.

Mandaviya also highlighted the role of the four Labour Codes in creating a modern, pro-growth framework while simplifying compliance for industry and strengthening protections for workers.

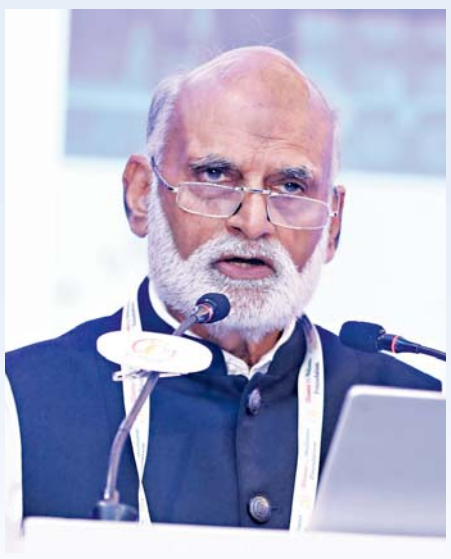
The minister emphasised the importance of expanding social security coverage and building an inclusive labour ecosystem that reaches workers across the formal and unorganised sectors. Mandaviya called upon the government, industry, workers and other stakeholders to work together, develop best practices and build a stronger culture of partnership.

Reiterating India's vision of becoming a developed nation by 2047, he stressed that when workers' dignity and industry's growth advance together, economic growth and employment can move in tandem, laying the foundation for sustainable growth.

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | SEPTEMBER 29, 2026

EXPERTS STRESS EARLY DETECTION, HEALTHY LIFESTYLES AND COMMUNITY AWARENESS FOR HEART HEALTH

HEALTH LEADERS FLAG POLLUTION, STRESS AND CHANGING LIFESTYLES WHILE CALLING FOR STRONGER FOCUS ON PREVENTION AT 'ILLNESS TO WELLNESS' CONFERENCE



Mr. Anil Rajput,
Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation



(Padma Bhushan) Dr T.S. Kler, Chairman & HOD, BLK-Max Heart & Vascular Institute & Chairman, Pan Max - Electrophysiology



(Padma Bhushan) Dr. (Prof.) K. K. Talwar, Chairman, PSRI Heart Institute



(Padma Shri) Dr. Ganesh Kumar Mani, Chairman, Cardiac Sciences, Cardiac Surgery (CTVS), Max Smart Super Speciality Hospital, Saket,



Dr. Gautam Singal, Member, FICCI Health Services Committee & Senior Consultant and Professor of Cardiology, Amrita Institute of Medical Sciences & Research Centre

Ahead of World Heart Day 2026, the Illness to Wellness Foundation organised a conference in New Delhi under the theme "Healthy Heart for a Healthy Life", bringing together leading cardiologists, healthcare experts and public health voices to highlight the growing importance of prevention, early detection and healthier everyday choices amid concerns around stress, pollution and changing lifestyles. The conference focused on building a stronger culture of prevention through awareness, healthy living, regular health checks, emergency preparedness and greater community participation.

(Padma Bhushan) Dr T.S. Kler, Chairman & HOD, BLK-Max Heart & Vascular Institute & Chairman, Pan Max - Electrophysiology, said, "It is important to support the call for the Government of India to establish structured preventive cardiovascular programmes and strengthen health education and prevention so that awareness translates into sustained action and reaches people at the community level. This preventive approach must also take into account the broader environmental and lifestyle factors influencing heart health, from air pollution, noise pollution and stubble burning to rising stress, changing work patterns and evolving lifestyle habits."

(Padma Bhushan) Dr. (Prof.) K. K. Talwar, Chairman, PSRI Heart Institute, New Delhi, stressed the importance of community preparedness during cardiac emergencies, saying, "Every minute is important. It is only the person who is by the side that matters." He called for wider community CPR training to enable people to provide immediate assistance while medical help is arriving.

Dr. Talwar also underlined the importance of preventive awareness and CPR skills, saying, "Apart from the awareness, the preventive steps, all of us probably should also have the knowledge how to do a good quality CPR by the side."

(Padma Shri) Dr. Ganesh Kumar Mani, Chairman, Cardiac Sciences, Cardiac Surgery (CTVS), Max Smart Super Speciality Hospital, Saket, Delhi, highlighted the importance of preventive cardiology and healthier everyday habits, particularly the role of stress and sedentary lifestyles. "Preventive cardiology has taken a big centre stage, and we need to move beyond looking at heart disease only when a problem arises. The emphasis should be on prevention, early action and making healthier choices part of everyday life. Small, consistent changes can play an important role in protecting heart health over the long term," he said.

In his address, Mr. Anil Rajput, Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation, said "A healthy life is shaped by the choices we make every day - what we eat, how active we remain, how we manage stress and whether we give ourselves enough time to rest and recharge. Building a culture of prevention is not just about responding to illness; it is about making healthier choices a part of everyday life. When individuals, families, communities and institutions come together to prioritise wellbeing, we can create a healthier and more aware society."



L to R Dr. Vinayak Agarwal, Head, Clinical Cardiology, Fortis Hospital; Dr. Krishan Yadav, Senior Consultant, Cardiology, Yatharth Super Speciality Hospital; Dr. (Prof.) Sandeep Bansal, Vardhman Mahavir Medical College & Safdarjung Hospital, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India; Dr. Vanita Arora, Clinical Lead, Cardiac Electrophysiology, Indraprastha Apollo Hospitals and Dr. Rahul Chandola, Senior Cardiothoracic and Heart Lung Transplant Surgeon, PSRI Hospital



Ms. Ritika Samaddar, Regional Head, Department of Clinical Nutrition and Dietetics, Max Healthcare; Dr. Tanu Singh, Founder, Lifeyoga; Dr. Rajesh Kesari, Member, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation; Dr. Jyoti Keswani, Director, Central Council for Research in Yoga & Naturopathy (CCRYN) and Additional Charge, Morarji Desai National Institute of Yoga, Ministry of Ayush, Government of India; Dr. Mohit Dayal Gupta, Director—Professor of Cardiology, GB Pant Hospital; Ms. Seema Singh, Founder Director, Seema Singh's Diet & Nutrition Clinic and Mr. Ajay Prakash Shrivastava, Chancellor, Maharishi Mahesh Yogi Ramayan Vishwavidyalaya, Ayodhya

Prevention is a collection of small decisions taken every day. We need to make prevention a habit, not just an afterthought or a reaction."

The conference featured two sessions addressing complementary aspects of preventive heart care. The first session, "Know Your Numbers for Heart Care: BP, Blood Sugar & Lipid Profile," moderated by Dr. Vinayak Agarwal, Head, Clinical Cardiology, Fortis Hospital; brought together Dr. Krishan Yadav, Senior Consultant, Cardiology, Yatharth Super Speciality Hospital, Dr. (Prof.) Sandeep Bansal, Vardhman Mahavir Medical College & Safdarjung Hospital, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India; Dr. Rahul Chandola, Senior Cardiothoracic and Heart Lung Transplant Surgeon, PSRI Hospital; and Dr. Vanita Arora, Clinical Lead, Cardiac Electrophysiology, Indraprastha Apollo Hospitals. The discussion focused on understanding cholesterol, triglycerides and other indicators of cardiovascular risk, regularly monitoring blood pressure, blood sugar and lipid levels, early identification of abnormal readings, timely intervention, lifestyle changes and building a culture of regular health checks and accessible screening across communities, workplaces and institutions.

The second session, "Heart Care through Holistic Wellness: Nutrition, Fitness, Ayurveda & Meditation," moderated by Dr. Rajesh Kesari, Member, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation, featured Dr. Jyoti Keswani, Director, Central Council for Research in Yoga & Naturopathy (CCRYN) and Additional Charge, Morarji Desai National Institute of Yoga, Ministry of Ayush, Government of India; Dr. Mohit Dayal Gupta, Director-Professor of Cardiology, GB Pant Hospital; Ms. Seema Singh, Founder Director, Seema Singh's Diet & Nutrition Clinic; Dr. Tanu Singh, Founder, Lifeyoga; Mr. Ajay Prakash Shrivastava, Chancellor, Maharishi Mahesh Yogi Ramayan Vishwavidyalaya, Ayodhya; and Ms. Ritika Samaddar, Regional Head, Department of Clinical Nutrition and Dietetics, Max Healthcare. The session explored the role of balanced nutrition, regular physical activity, healthy weight management, Ayurveda, meditation and mindfulness, adequate sleep, emotional wellbeing and healthy daily habits in supporting heart health, while highlighting holistic heart-care practices suited to an individual's age, health status and lifestyle.



The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | SEPTEMBER 29, 2026

BRIEFLY

Chikitha and Ganesh advance to Asiad archery quarters



Defending champion Jyothi Surekha Vennam was stunningly ousted by 14-year-old Korean Kang Yeonseo, who shot a perfect score of 150, but debutant duo of Chikitha Taniparthi and Ganesh Mani Ratnam Thirumuru advanced to the quarterfinals of their respective women's and men's individual compound archery competitions at the Asian Games here on Monday.

Jyothi had claimed gold in individual, women's team and mixed team competitions in the previous edition of the Games in Hangzhou.

Against Yeonseo, Jyothi produced a score of 146 in the pre-quarterfinals, having played catch-up with Kang.

Under pressure after trailing Kang, Jyothi responded with a perfect 30, but the Korean prodigy matched it to retain her four-point lead at 120-116 before eliminating her more experienced opponent from the competition. (*PTI*)

Asiad volleyball: India go past Hong Kong for second win



The Indian men's volleyball team edged past Hong Kong, China in a Pool C preliminary round match for its second consecutive win at the Asian Games here on Monday.

India prevailed 3-0 (25-22, 25-19, 25-21), raising their level at crucial moments to close out a match in which Hong Kong kept up the pressure for long periods.

India, who began with a 3-0 win over Vietnam, will next face Qatar on Tuesday. Hong Kong were particularly effective with their attacking play from the right flank, finding ways to trouble the Indian defence and remain in contention despite India holding the lead for much of the contest.

India head coach Dragan Mihailovic said the team was "still looking for a good performance". "We had lots of small mistakes. The problem is a little bit mental. The Hong Kong guys were making some easy mistakes, but we cannot, as a serious team, expect that somebody will be giving mistakes for us to win the game," said the coach. (*PTI*)

The new fearless young generation of Indian sport



SHAKYA MITRA

In what has otherwise been a disappointing Asian Games campaign for India, a far cry from the extraordinary performance in 2023 when the country won a record 28 gold medals and 106 medals overall, one of the brightest stories has been 18-year-old squash player Anahat Singh.

Her semifinal against a higher-ranked and fancied Japanese opponent Satomi Watanabe was a remarkable demonstration of composure and belief. Two games down and facing three match points in the third, Anahat somehow found a way back into the contest and eventually won. The significance of the comeback went beyond simply reaching the final.

A defeat at that stage would still have assured her a bronze medal. For an 18-year-old competing at one of Asia's biggest sporting events, that would hardly have been an outcome to be ashamed of. Yet Anahat appeared unwilling to accept that her story had already been written. She wanted to change her destiny. Though she went down in the final and won a silver medal, her strength of character at such a young age was admirable.

That mentality may well be one of the most significant developments in Indian sport today.

The India in which many of us grew up during the 1980s and 1990s and the India in which a youngster like Anahat Singh has grown up are almost unrecognisable from each other, at least when it comes to sporting expectations.

For much of the 1980s and 1990s, Indian sport existed under the shadow of Olympic underachievement. India went through three consecutive Olympic editions without winning a medal. At the 1996, 2000 and 2004 Olympics, there was just one medal in each edition. Even the Asian Games and Commonwealth Games, where India's medal prospects were considerably better, rarely generated the kind of expectations that exist today.

Sport was often about celebrating an individual achievement rather than expecting sustained success.

That began to change, particularly with the 2008 Beijing Olympics and the subsequent hosting of the 2010 Commonwealth Games, followed by the Asian Games in Guangzhou later that year. India's sporting ecosystem did not transform overnight, but the psychological shift had begun. Athletes started believing that medals were not occasional miracles but achievable targets.



Young athletes today have grown up in that altered environment. PV Sindhu won a World Championship medal at 18 in 2013, Manu Bhaker broke on to the world stage by 16-17 eventually winning two Olympic medals in 2024 and now we have Anahat Singh. It is entirely possible that these athletes would have little knowledge of an India that routinely returned from Olympics empty-handed. Rather they have seen Indian sport from merely participating to competing and winning.



That does not mean the achievements of the earlier generation should be forgotten. Quite the opposite. The fearlessness of today's athletes exists partly because others were brave enough to go first.

Abhinav Bindra changed the possibilities of Indian Olympic sport when he became the country's first individual Olympic gold medallist in 2008. Saina Nehwal played a crucial role in breaking the psychological dominance of China in badminton and showed that Indian players could compete with the very best. Sushil Kumar's bronze medal in Beijing began a remarkable run in wrestling, with India winning a wrestling medal at four consecutive Olympic Games thereafter.

They walked so that others could run.

What is different now is that those who are running have grown up watching the road already being built.

It would be unfair, however, to suggest that one Manu Bhaker, when she broke through in 2017-18, or one Anahat Singh represents an entire sporting revolution. They are exceptional talents and their trajectories cannot simply be replicated. India's sporting challenges remain substantial, from infrastructure and coaching to competition depth and access.

But exceptional athletes can have an influence far beyond their own medals.

When a teenager watches Manu Bhaker compete fearlessly on the Olympic stage or sees Anahat Singh recover from two games down and three match points in an Asian Games semifinal, the message is not merely that these athletes are talented. It is that the stage itself is not something to fear.

The next generation of Indian athletes is not necessarily walking into international competition asking whether India can win. Increasingly, they are asking themselves whether they can win.

There is a subtle but profound difference.

India's Asian Games campaign may not ultimately resemble the historic success of 2023. But sporting progress cannot always be measured only by the medal table. Sometimes it can be seen in the manner in which a young athlete responds when the odds are stacked against her.

Anahat Singh's comeback is therefore more than a memorable squash match. It is a glimpse into a generation that does not remember India's sporting failures because, for them, those failures are history.

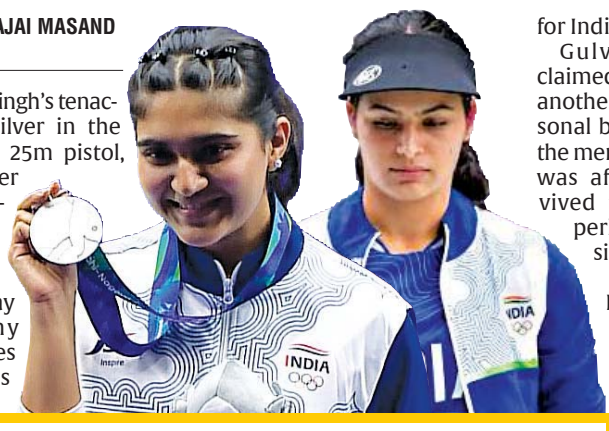
They have grown up in an India that expects to compete.

And perhaps, increasingly, they are growing into athletes who expect to win.

The author is a sports management consultant with over a decade of experience in sports promotion and development. His work across both the private and government sectors gives him a well-rounded view of India's sports ecosystem

India at Asiad: Silver for shooter Esha, runner Gulveer

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH/AJAI MASAND
■ Nagoya



Young shooter Esha Singh's tenacity fetched her a silver in the women's individual 25m pistol, while distance runner Gulveer Singh's rampaging form translated into another second-place finish on a rain-soaked day dotted with many missed opportunities and some surprises for India at the Asian Games here.

Gulveer, who has already claimed the 10,000m silver, added another one to his kitty with a personal best timing of 3:36.72sec in the men's 1500m competition. This was after 21-year-old Esha survived five shoot-offs to clinch perhaps the most hard-fought silver of her career.

Kurash player Picky Balhara threw up a pleasant surprise with her bronze in the -78kg category. She became a two-time Games medallist and thereby the most successful Indian Kurash player at the mega-event by adding to her silver from 2018 edition.

Another brilliant performance was by Vithya Ramraj in the women's 400m hurdles competition as she surged past the legendary P T Usha's over four decade-old national record to claim the bronze medal. Ramraj clocked 54.75sec, bettering Usha's 55.42sec established at the 1984 Los Angeles Olympics.

The medal haul stood at 41, including four gold, 18 silver and 19 bronze medals. The country was placed just outside the top 10, something that has remained consistent since the start of the Games.

In the boxing ring, Olympic bronze-medallist Lovlina Borgohain (75kg), Priya Ghanghas (60kg) and Kapil Pokhariya (90kg) delivered trademark assured performances to sail into semifinals and be assured of bronze, joining three others in the medal rounds.

Among shockers was defending women's individual compound archery champion Jyothi Surekha Vemman's pre-quarterfinal exit, landing another blow to a largely underwhelming campaign so far by India. Another defending champion who failed to protect his crown was track veteran Avinash Sable in men's 3000m steeplechase competition. (*PTI*)

DAILY SUDOKU

		9	6				1	2
						8		6
					1	3		7
	4		1	3				5
9	2		8		6		4	1
5				4	7		3	
2		6	3					
7		4						
8	5				4	9		

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.



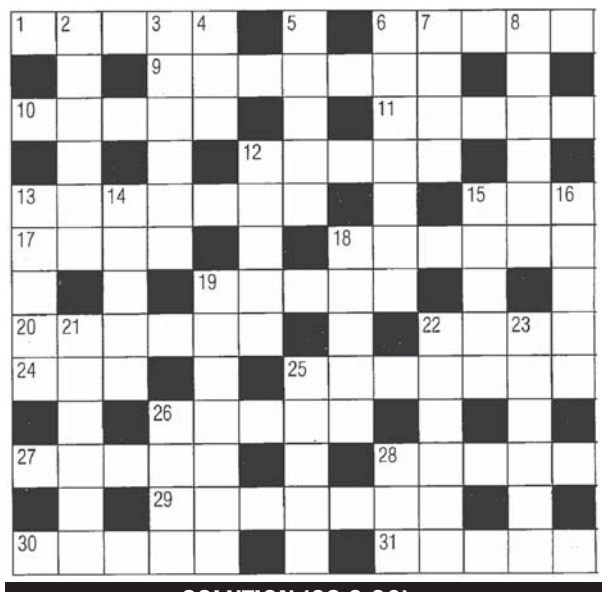
No.SS2256 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

SOLUTION (28.9.26)

3	8	9	2	7	1	4	6	5
4	1	7	8	5	6	3	2	9
5	2	6	4	3	9	8	7	1
2	9	8	7	4	3	1	5	6
6	7	3	5	1	2	9	8	4
1	5	4	9	6	8	7	3	2
9	6	2	1	8	7	5	4	3
7	3	5	6	9	4	2	1	8
8	4	1	3	2	5	6	9	7

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DOUBLE CROSSWORD
TUESDAY | SEPTEMBER 29, 2026



ACROSS

1 Spills the beans about the girl holding the money (5)
6 High ones are fun (5)
9 Best imaginable mother? (7)
10 White as an owl (5)
11 Species of tiger, one reads (5)
12 It's a lot more than little, note (5)
13 Stood up tall when dragged around the end of the pier (7)
15 Masculine pieces (3)
17 Just a single right can be a knockout! (4)
18 Withdraw when about to get weary (6)
19 An Indian instrument is wrong for Jack (5)
20 Romantic name for a village Green (6)
22 Punishment for being thin? (4)
24 Title held by Osiris (3)
25 It's reasonable for a soldier to go in a pub (7)
26 Hundreds of drops of water will seep away (5)
27 Blue blooded boy by another name (5)
28 Rosie's willowy form (5)
29 Remove the ones we doubt? (4,3)
30 Piano for the finale? (5)
31 She gives thanks for any change (5)

DOWN

2 It has an eye for the tourists (6)
3 Hat taken off if too expensive (6)
4 Despite the soppy exterior, a person of intelligence (3)
5 Figures in black and blue (5)
6 A god to swear by? (7)
7 I'm having a morning with a holy man (4)
8 He may be on time for the match (6)
12 They aimed to spread the news (5)
13 Those grasping old Oriental secret societies, one imagines (5)
14 River (a converted sewer?) (5)
15 Imitate an operatic character with a tragic end (5)
16 Staircase feature unfamiliar to the Spanish (5)
18 Light on artificial silk (5)
19 Spoke savagely when all tangled up (7)
21 Strictness in interpreting most of our rights (6)
22 In a wild feast, one can be fun (6)
23 Nominally a man set up with a place (6)
25 She's in Colindale (5)
26 Start after Elizabeth (but before the French?) on TV (4)
28 Blooming well caught? (3)

SOLUTION (28.9.26)

ACROSS
3, Menai
8, Flo-od
10, Frock
11, AI-M
12, Met-re
13, Wilfre-d
15, I-nert
18, R-e-d.
19, Sc-en-es
21, Replica
22, Loot
23,Dear
24, Drowned
26, B-races
29, Lob
31, Sinus
32, Nettles
34,Rigid
35, Oak
36, Cheer
37, Ur-G-ed
38, Decks

DOWN
1, Blair
2, Pomfret
4, (Mon-)Eyed
5, Afri-C-a
6, I-Rene
7,Score
9, Oil
12, Med.-Lars
14, Rep
16, End-Ed
17, Tsars
19, S-cowled
20, Blobs
21, Roman
23, Debtors
24, De-sir-e
25, No-t
27,Right
28, Cured
30, Pekes
32, Nick
33, L-ag

Squash: Indian men and women enter quarters



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nagoya

The Indian men's and women's teams on Monday marched into the quarterfinals of the Asian Games squash competition with the latter producing a gritty win over Japan here.

Indian women, seeded third, got past Japan 2-1 despite lead player Anahat Singh losing to world number six Satomi Watanabe in five games. The 17th ranked Anahat had beaten the world number six Japanese in the individual semifinals before finishing with a historic silver.

Indian women, bronze medallists in the previous edition, had beaten China 3-0 in their opening match.

Veteran Joshna Chinappa, featuring in a record seventh Asian Games, gave India a 1-lead over Japan with a 11-1, 11-8, 11-9 win over Erisa Sano.

Next up was Anahat against Satomi for the second time in three days. Satomi was able to get the better of the Indian this time, pulling off a 11-8, 8-11, 7-11, 11-8, 11-9 win in a 43-minute battle. In the decider, Tanvi Khanna had to dig deep against Akari Midorikawa for a 12-10, 11-9, 4-11, 12-10 victory, sealing the match for India and a place in the quarterfinals. The men's team, which won the gold in China, blanked South Korea 3-0 to seal place in last eight stage.

In the opening singles, Velavan Senthilkumar defeated Jooyoung Na 11-6, 11-4, 11-7 before singles silver medallist Abhay Singh had a comfortable 11-4, 11-7, 11-1 result over Jeongmin Ryu. Veer Chotrani outplayed Seojin Oh 11-6, 11-4, 11-2 in inconsequential third singles.

Earlier on Monday, the Indian men were barely troubled as Suraj Chand, Chotrani and Senthilkumar all registered comfortable wins to seal tie in straight matches.

Shaili Singh's mark wrongly measured by officials: AFI



PHILEM DIPAK SINGH ■ Nagoya

Claiming that the officials at the ongoing Asian Games took a "shorter" measurement of long jumper Shaili Singh's effort which denied her a medal, the Athletics Federation of India (AFI) has decided to move the Court of Arbitration for Sport (CAS) against their decision.

Shaili finished fourth with a best jump of 6.42m in the women's long jump event on Sunday, with compatriot Ancy Sojan taking the silver with 6.53m. China's Huang Yingying took the gold with her final attempt of 6.55m.

The bone of contention is Shaili's fourth attempt, which officially measured 6.41m. According Shaili's mentor and legendary long jumper Anju Bobby George, the distance was wrongly measured at the behest of an official who was not close to the landing pit.

"We saw her jump was clearly ahead of the gold-winning mark. Initially, the official near the landing pit pointed to Shaili's leg mark for the measurement.

"But later another official who was standing far behind came and pointed to a mark which was far shorter from board," Anju said.

"They took the measurement at the mark pointed by the official who was standing far behind. The measurement should have been done on the mark pointed by the official nearest to the landing pit," said Anju, who won a long jump bronze in the 2003 World Championships.

Shaili herself lodged a protest and videos of the jump were shown at that time. (*PTI*)

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | SEPTEMBER 29, 2026

Asiad cricket: India enter semi-final

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Nagoya



The Indian men's cricket team entered the Asian Games semi-final without even taking the field after its quarter-final against Afghanistan was abandoned due to inclement weather here on Monday.

The defending champion side made it to the last four as it is ranked No.1 in the ICC T20I rankings while Afghanistan is currently placed 10th.

India will take on winners of the quarter-final between Nepal and Sri Lanka to be held here on Tuesday. If that match is abandoned, then Sri Lanka, by virtue of their higher ranking, will take on India in the semi-final.

There has been consistent rain in Nagoya for the past few days and even a curtailed match was a remote possibility on the day. "Hopefully, in the upcoming games, we will get the opportunity to play some good cricket and show our game to the people in Japan," said India leg-spinner Ravi Bishnoi after the game's cancellation was announced.

The first quarterfinal between Pakistan and Hong Kong was also washed out, allowing the former to move ahead on the basis of their higher ICC ranking.

India are being led by Shreyas Iyer with VVS Laxman taking over the coaching responsibilities as regular head coach Gautam Gambhir is with the ODI team that is currently playing a home series against the West Indies.

The team features all major stars such as pace spearhead Jasprit Bumrah and 15-year-old batting sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi among others. Bishnoi said the players are looking forward to the opportunity of watching other sports while they are here. "The Asian Games are definitely a different experience from the other series and World Cups. You get to see different sports and experience them as well," Bishnoi said.

Decoding eras: Kohli scales mount 15K quicker than Tendulkar, comparisons unfair

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi



Virat Kohli reached 15,000 ODI runs in 74 fewer innings compared to the peerless Sachin Tendulkar but does this mean that he has well and truly surpassed the 'Mumbai Master' in the format?

The answer may not be as simple as the statistics suggest because the 50-over game that Tendulkar played for over two decades was very different in its rules and texture.

Kohli and Tendulkar are both geniuses, both are unique for the times that they ruled and hence not comparable by mere number-crunching.

But is Kohli a bigger phenomenon than Tendulkar in ODIs? In some cases yes but such a comparison can never be linear. But both of them have a couple of landmarks to their credit, which are unlikely to be touched by anyone else in near future. Kohli's number of hundreds, which is 55 and still counting, and Tendulkar's quantum of runs, 18,426. Kohli has 15080 runs to his credit in the format and it is virtually impossible for him to surpass Tendulkar given the dwindling ODI count in the calendar. In terms of innings played — Kohli had reached 15,000 ODI runs in his 303rd innings (315th match) while Tendulkar had reached the same milestone in 377 innings (387 matches). Even more striking is that Kohli took 1578 lesser deliveries than Tendulkar to hit the mark. Tendulkar faced 17,528 balls to reach 15,000 runs while for Kohli the volume of deliveries faced to achieve the same milestone was 15,950 balls.

Kohli played at least nine per cent fewer balls which indicates that he scored the runs at a faster clip than the 'Master Blaster'. Kohli's average runs per innings compared to Tendulkar's is also significantly more.

Kohli's runs-per-innings figure stands at 49.5 compared to Tendulkar's 39.9. The batting average (when unbeaten knocks are computed) is 58.8 for Kohli compared to Tendulkar's 44.24 which was considered to be brilliant for his peak era — between 1995-2011. Kohli's strike-rate of 94 plus is also better than Tendulkar's 86. Until he reached 15,000 runs, Tendulkar (41 tons) had 14 fewer hundreds than Kohli (55). (*PTI*)

Prasidh Krishna: Maturing fast into main act from sidekick

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Thiruvananthapuram



Prasidh Krishna's 10-0-60-2 spell naturally failed to attract a deeper analysis after Virat Kohli, Shubman Gill and Kuldeep Yadav ripped the West Indies with magical acts, fashioning India's eight-wicket stroll in the first ODI. But Prasidh's effort against Caribbeans gave enough indications of a bowler who is willing to bend his back for team even in oppressive conditions.

"Hard lengths is something that I've been doing all my life. I was slightly on the shorter side and we have been working for quite some time now. When you come in, knowing what exactly has to be done, there is clarity within the team, there is clarity inside me as to what I do when I come in," Prasidh said in the post-match press conference.

True to his strength, the pacer produced two accurate back of the length deliveries to get rid of Keacy Carty and Roston Chase to impede the tourists further amidst Kuldeep's strikes.

"There is enough communication going on. So, all of those things accumulate and help me bowl well," he added.

But the spell is also significant from a different angle. Frontline pacers Jasprit Bumrah and Arshdeep Singh are in Japan for the Asian Games duties and an off-colour Mohammed Siraj, perhaps, did not invoke enough confidence in management to warrant a place in the eleven.

That left Prasidh to operate with Nitish Kumar Reddy and Gurnoor Brar, all of seven ODIs old. (*PTI*)

South Africa seals series victory over Australia

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Johannesburg



David Miller and Temba Bavuma posted centuries for South Africa in a 32-run win in the second cricket ODI on Sunday that clinched the series and saw Australia once again exposed against spinners.

Miller hit a belligerent 142 runs off 93 balls to notch his eighth ODI hundred and Bavuma scored 103, his sixth century in the 50-over ODI format, as South Africa reached 365-9.

Australia's Jack Edwards, playing in only his second ODI, took 5-67 and Josh Hazlewood, who dismissed Aiden Markram off the first ball for a golden duck, took 3-70, also in 10 overs.

Australia, which preferred to chase for the second straight game after winning the toss, fell short in the run chase and was 333 all out in the final over.

Sunday's game marked the annual Pink Day fixture, which raises money for cancer research and treatment. Miller wore the name of his mother Jenny, a breast cancer survivor, on the back of his jersey.

Australia, a six-time World Cup champion in the format, hasn't won any of the six bilateral ODI series against South Africa since 2014. The Australians will be aiming for a consolation win in the last game on Wednesday.

"Another good all-round team performance," Bavuma said. "Unbelievable innings by David and then the bowlers as well ... there was a lot more spin than was expected. The way the spin complemented our attack it was great."

Australia wastes a good start

Just like in the Durban opener, where Australia lost by 67 runs, the visitors squandered a rollicking start to the chase by captain Mitchell Marsh (84) and Travis Head (84) . The pair combined in a 130-run opening stand in 17 overs before Australia struggled against Keshav Maharaj (2-54) and Markram (1-55) with captain Bavuma fully utilizing the 30 overs of spin option.

Maharaj trapped Alex Carey for 17 and Matt Renshaw for 32 - both lbw dismissals - and Cameron Green fell for 17 while attempting a big hit against Bjorn Fortuin.

"Really disappointing," Marsh said. "Fair play to South Africa. I thought they played really well, outplayed us again. We haven't been able to execute in those middle phases which is a great learning curve for our players."

Xavier Bartlett (50 off 28) gave a late counterpunch to reduce the margin of defeat and damage the figures of third spinner Fortuin (2-70), who conceded 19 runs in his last over.

Neeru Dhanda leads Indian hunt for historic trap gold



AJAI MASAND ■ Nagoya

Neeru Dhanda is breaking new ground in Indian women's shotgun shooting. The world No. 13 took the sole lead in the women's trap qualification at the Asian Games on Monday, moving closer to an elusive individual gold that no Indian woman has won before.

Fresh from becoming the first Indian woman to win an ISSF World Cup gold in shotgun, at Lonato, the heartland of the sport, the 26-year-old picked up from where she had left off on the opening day, underlining her credentials as a serious contender for the title.

Neeru, who had shot 24 in each of her two rounds on Sunday, maintained her consistency with scores of 24 and 23 on Monday to take her aggregate to 95 after four rounds. She holds a one-point advantage over Qatar's Bassil Ray, with a group of three shooters a further point behind, keeping the contest finely poised ahead of the final day of qualification.

The shooters will fire their fifth and final round of 25 shots on Tuesday, after which the top eight will advance to the final. Neeru, a Naib Subedar in the Army from Haryana's Jind district, will also be spearheading India's hopes of a team medal alongside Manisha Keer and Aashima Ahlawat.

Manisha and Aashima are both placed 20th with identical scores of 84, taking India's combined tally to 263 and placing the team third in the standings. China lead with 278, while Kuwait are second with 265. With only six teams competing in the women's trap, India remain in hunt for podium finish, although they will need a strong final round to close gap. (*PTI*)

Lovlina, Priya, Kapil punch their way into semifinals, assured of Asiad medal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Nishio (Japan)



Lovlina Borgohain's medal collection continued to swell as the seasoned Indian boxer assured herself of a second consecutive Asian Games podium finish by moving to the semifinals while Priya Ghanghas and Kapil Pokhariya too advanced to the last four stage here on Monday.

Lovlina notched a commanding 5-0 win over South Korea's Seong Suyeon in the women's middleweight (75kg).

Asian Championship gold medallist and reigning Commonwealth Games champion Priya then came from behind to also register a unanimous decision victory over Tajikistan's Mijgona Samadova in the 60kg quarterfinal.

Pokhariya, one of only three boxers to miss out on the podium at last month's Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, then outpunched South Korea's Kim Gichae 0-5 to storm into the men's 90kg semifinal.

Six Indian boxers including Parveen Hooda (65kg), Ankush Panghal (80kg) and Narender Berwal (+90kg) will thus return with medals from the continental tournament, improving on last edition's four-medal haul.

Happy with Asian Games haul: Rudrankksh Patil

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi



Talented Indian shooter Rudrankksh Patil says he is still waiting to reach peak form, but his three-medal haul at the Asian Games has given him confidence that he is moving in the right direction.

The 22-year-old from Maharashtra, who has seen his share of the highs and lows, bagged a bronze medal in the men's 10m Air Rifle Individual event and clinched silver medals in the team events of the men's 10m Air Rifle and men's 50m Rifle 3 Positions.

"I am personally very happy with these medals, honestly. Looking at where I was and where I am right now," Rudrankksh told PTI on his return from a successful Asian Games on Sunday. "In the last Asian Games I was 4th, this time my rank was 3rd. So I am happy to see that there was some improvement in that. Team medals are of course special, this time it was silver, I was hoping for gold. But you know, it is a silver at the Asian Games, so I cannot complain; I am happy about it."

Rudrankksh became only the second Indian world champion after Bindra with his gold at the 2022 World Championships but has not been able to replicate that success at the Olympics and Asian Games. Asked when he expects to regain his best form, Rudrankksh said he too was waiting for it but remained focused on the process.

"I am also waiting for it, but I am working towards it. It just comes; it's just one period when you are in extremely good form and everything is very easy. I am working hard every single day. These medals are the proof that we are working in the right direction, so I am happy about it," he said. (*PTI*)

India blank Bangladesh 10-0 in final group fixture, face Pakistan in semifinals on October 1

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kakamigahara



Defending champions India blanked Bangladesh 10-0 amid heavy downpour in their final group fixture of the Asian Games here on Monday with captain Harmanpreet Singh scoring a hat-trick.

India finished on top of Pool A and set up a blockbuster semi-final against arch-rivals Pakistan on October 1. The other semi-final will be played between Malaysia and South Korea.

India dominated Pool A with wins over Indonesia, Sri Lanka, Japan, South Korea and Bangladesh - finishing with a goal difference of +45. The team will now have a well-deserved two-day break before the all-important semifinals.

India's goals came via Abhishek (3), Jugraj Singh (22) Harmanpreet Singh (27, 40, 45), Sukhjeet Singh (32), Lakra Shilanand (44, 45), Sanjay (59) and Mandeep Singh (60).

Rain left the pitch and the players drenched, making movement difficult. But the much fitter Indian team was better prepared for the rain-hit conditions. The start of the match was delayed by 30 minutes after the game between Pakistan and Oman had to be suspended for about 15 minutes amid heavy rain, forcing adjustment of timings for subsequent matches in the day.

India made their intentions clear early on and opened the scoring in the 3rd minute. Sanjay joined the attacking build-up and despite finding himself at a tight angle inside the Bangladesh circle, he showed good awareness to find Abhishek.

The forward shifted slightly to his left before unleashing his trademark reverse hit that flew past the Bangladesh goalkeeper to give India a 1-0 lead.

India continued to build attacks consistently but struggled to add to their advantage in the opening quarter. Bangladesh earned a penalty corner in the 12th minute, with Amirul Islam producing a decent drag-flick, but goalkeeper Suraj Karkera was alert to the danger and kicked the ball away.

India thought they had earned another penalty corner in the 15th minute, but Bangladesh successfully used their video referral to overturn the decision.

There was a brief injury scare for Abhishek shortly afterwards as he was helped off the field by the physio, although the forward did not appear to have suffered anything serious and returned to the pitch later.

The drizzle intensified into heavy rain at the start of the second quarter, leaving the pitch increasingly waterlogged.

India doubled their advantage in the 22nd minute after Mandeep Singh was blocked by Bangladesh defenders inside the circle and India were awarded a penalty corner. Jugraj Singh's goal-bound drag-flick struck the foot of a defender positioned on the post, prompting the umpire to signal a penalty stroke. Jugraj stepped up and calmly converted to make it 2-0.

The heavy pitch made it difficult for both teams to move the ball at pace, but India continued to press. In the 27th minute, an aerial ball into the Bangladesh circle found Mandeep, who cleverly created another penalty corner.

Harmanpreet took responsibility and unleashed a powerful flick that beat the Bangladesh defence to put India 3-0 ahead at half-time.

Soon after the break, in the 32nd minute, Dilpreet Singh and Sukhjeet Singh combined brilliantly with quick touch-play to outfox the Bangladesh goalkeeper, leaving Sukhjeet with the simple task of guiding the ball into the open goal for India's fourth goal.

Sukhjeet almost added another in the 37th minute after combining with Shilanand Lakra, but the Bangladesh defence reacted quickly. A minute later, Harmanpreet's aerial flick from a penalty corner narrowly missed the post.